12.5
Author: SYOUGO KINUGASA
Illustrator: TOMOSE SHUNSAKU
Welcome to the 2nd Year Classroom
CLASSROOM OF THE ELITE 2nd Year
ROYAL MTLS

12.5
ようこそ実力至上主義の教室へ2年生編
Welcome to the Classroom of the Second-year
衣笠彰梧×トモセシュンサク

“I didn't think I'd have the experience of meeting up with a student at Keyaki Mall.”
“You haven't had this happen before?”
“Obviously not.”

“You seem to be talking in a manner as if you're on equal standing with the current Prime Minister, Mister Ayanokōji.”
“For me it's a situation where i have nothing to fear. I have no intention of clinging on to the congressman's position, just to stare at the expressions of those around me.”
“Ayanokōji-san. You do understand that you currently are a member of the Kyouei-party, right?”

“I'll transfer to your class and make it graduate as class A. However, only on the condition that you, Ichinose Honami, drop out of this school.”
This is the one condition I demand. As long as she'll accept it, the deal will be concluded.

WELCOME TO CLASSROOM OF THE ELITE YEAR 2

# CLASSROOM OF THE ELITE YEAR 2 12.5

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# Prologue:
# Behind the Scenes

THE TENSE END-OF-YEAR SPECIAL EXAM period continued.

Cameras were set up from multiple viewing angles.

Discussions between the participants unfolded on the monitor.

A one-on-one battle between representatives, where no one was allowed to intervene.

The full picture, with its distorted rules, wasn't even disclosed to the homeroom teachers until immediately beforehand.

Despite being suddenly thrust onto the battlefield, the students earnestly faced the challenge head-on.

Hoshinomiya Chie watched over the special exam with bated breath while suppressing her frustrating feelings.

She desired only one thing: the victory of her class.

Her jaw hurt from clenching her teeth so hard, but she had yet to even notice it.

She intended to use any means necessary in this special exam if she was able to.

The rules of the end-of-year special exam, as initially informed, originally allowed the teachers to have some limited room to get involved.

However, once the lid on the actual rules was opened, it turned out that a completely different exam was being implemented.

The reason for the sudden change wasn't explained by the school and remained unclear.

It was a mystery, not only to Hoshinomiya, but also to all the teachers involved with the second-year students.

However, now the reason was clear.

An anomaly, no, a spectator, sat before her.

The presence of this visitor had thrown a wrench in her plans.

"Why..."

Hoshinomiya muttered in a low voice.

The incident occurred just when hope was beginning to show itself—after Horikita Suzune's defeat.

Ayanokōji Kiyotaka appeared resolutely, with words, conduct, and merciless strategies that wouldn't make one think that he was a student.

Ichinose Honami was hanging her head, confirming her defeat.

"It's unfair, something like this..."

Though no one heard her, she couldn't help but lament.

The overwhelming presence of a joker.

The strongest hand that Chabashira held made her painfully aware that there was no chance of winning.

All she could do was watch through the screen, and the outcome was mercilessly decided.

“The end-of-year special exam has now concluded. Thank you for your hard work.”

The one in charge of the school, Chairman Sakayanagi, spoke with an appreciative and inquiring tone.

After watching the special exam to its end along with the four homeroom teachers and several men in black suits, the visiting man slowly rose from his elegant chair.

Seeing this, the men in black, standing by behind him, hurried to prepare for their departure.

“Thank you for your help this time, Chairman Sakayanagi. I appreciate the thorough preparations you’ve made.”

Coffee was poured into an undeniably expensive-looking cup alongside the most beautiful tea sweets one had ever seen.

Although they had gone almost untouched, a hand was extended to Sakayanagi as a sign of gratitude.

Sakayanagi hurriedly took his hand and bowed deeply.

“It’s nothing, Prime Minister Kijima. Thank you very much for taking the trouble to come here.”

It was the current prime minister, Kijima.

A man who was also a proponent of the Advanced Nurturing High School had come just to observe this special exam.

Since this was the case, Hoshinomiya had no choice but to be content with the situation.

With the prime minister visiting, it wouldn’t be surprising if some changes were made.

Kijima turned his gaze back to the monitor.

On the screen—ignoring Ichinose, who was standing in a daze, unable to support herself—was the figure of Ayanokōji leaving the room.

“It’s truly regrettable that there were expulsions, but the notion that each student has the freedom to utilize the exam’s rules should be respected.”

“It helps our school greatly to hear you say that. Minister Ogiso has strongly requested to operate without fear of the risk of expulsion—”

Sakayanagi began to explain the expulsions, but Kijima gently stopped him.

Ogiso refers to the Minister of Education, Culture, Sports, Science, and Technology, which the teachers understood while they exchanged glances.

“I understand. But of course, we can ensure that the student who ended up being expelled will receive thorough support, correct?”

“Naturally. We will promptly contact several schools for her transfer that match her academic abilities and personality.”

“Is that so? Please take care of it well.”

Kijima checked the time on his modest-looking wristwatch and turned his back to leave the room.

Sakayanagi hurriedly followed him.

“As planned, we will visit again on April 1st, so please take care of us well.”

“Of course. Company President Kōenji was also looking forward to meeting with you, Prime Minister Kijima.”

“That’s good to hear. Since it’s been three years, I’m looking forward to meeting him as well.”

While having this conversation, Sakayanagi and Kijima left the room.

The four homeroom teachers left behind sighed in relief from the heavy atmosphere.

“Congratulations, Sae-chan. Even if it’s temporary, you’re in Class A now.”

“I’d like to thank you, but the exam just ended... and there’s also the matter of Maezono who got expelled. I can’t just happily celebrate.”

*Is the expulsion of a single student more significant than the joy of being promoted to Class A?*

Hoshinomiya felt irritation growing inside her as Chabashira answered with a serious expression.

*In reality, she must be mocking my continual failures*, she thought.

*Or perhaps... she doesn’t even consider me worth noticing.*

With each surge of frustrating emotions, her resentment grew deeper.

*I will never let this woman win.*

*I won’t let her graduate from Class A.*

Such a resolve, akin to murderous intent, swelled up far more than before the exam.

# Chapter 1:
# Checking Each Other's Answers

MARCH 14TH. It was dusk right after the end-of-year special exam concluded.

The class representatives were sent back to their respective classes, still unable to sort out their feelings.

Or rather, it might've been the participants who were more unsettled than the representatives. They had to start by understanding the full scope of the exam, what happened behind the scenes, and how it was all settled. It wasn't enough to just know who won or lost—they needed to understand the events that had occurred. On their way back to the classroom, where the participants were waiting, it was clear that Horikita and Yōsuke had many questions and doubts about the confrontation between Ichinose and me, but perhaps because Chabashira-sensei was there, they walked in silence all the way to the classroom.

Unable to bear the silence any longer, Chabashira-sensei was the first to speak.

"...Just to clarify, this special exam was quite unique compared to previous years. An important condition was that the information that was given between you representatives and the participants waiting in the classroom was different. The only common understanding was about the class's victory or defeat and the existence of any expulsions. I won't explain this point in detail after we return to the classroom."

"The actual rules... specifically, the rules given to the representatives... it's okay for us to explain them to the participants to clear up any misunderstandings, right?"

"Of course. It's up to you to decide what should be done. We're going to depart soon, but you should discuss and resolve any concerns."

Before touching the classroom door, Chabashira-sensei turned back and advised Horikita and the others.

"Yes, that's the plan. Even the representatives don't know in detail what kind of battles were fought individually. We believe it's necessary to share information."

The representatives didn't know what actions they each took.

Even so, their feelings were focused on understanding the details of the battle between Ichinose and me.

The only thing they knew was that Ichinose had been defeated and Maezono had been expelled.

"You too, Ayanokōji-kun—you'll make time for us, right?"

"Of course. I never intended to end the day with lingering doubts."

With this affirmation, Horikita was satisfied and nodded, and Yōsuke followed suit.

The teacher and the three representatives returned.

The participants who welcomed us back quickly cast curious and varied gazes our way.

When Chabashira-sensei returned the students' confiscated phones, I quickly skimmed through the messages that arrived as soon as I turned on my phone. After, I placed it in my pocket.

Chabashira-sensei slowly spoke to the still visibly shaken students.

"The end-of-year special exam ended in your victory. With this, Class 2-B has gained a significant amount of class points and… from next month, as third-years, it's almost certain that you'll be promoted to Class A for the first time. However, the situation has also resulted in Maezono being expelled. I find it hard to outright congratulate you in this situation... but still, I want to commend you for fighting well."

In a situation where it was inappropriate to burst into joy, Chabashira-sensei praised the students' efforts while commending them.

However, there was little joy among the classmates.

The reality of their win was still faint, and Maezono had been expelled.

Wildly celebrating now would only invite disapproval.

Everyone was eager to know the details without delay.

"Did Maezono really get expelled?"

Among the hesitant students, Sudō was the first to ask directly.

"Half correct, half incorrect. Indeed, Maezono is processing her expulsion in the staff room, but if you can come up with the necessary private points right here, it's possible to avoid it."

Normally, it wouldn't be strange to confirm one or the other, but Chabashira-sensei must have been aware of the class's total private points. Considering that they likely hadn't reached 20 million, that measure couldn't be considered. Holding out faint hope for Maezono would only be cruel.

In fact, even if we forcibly tried to save her, we wouldn't be able to make it in time.

We couldn't stop the expulsion. There was nothing more to do than silently accept it.

"Will I be able to see her if I wait...?"

At this point, Mii-chan voiced her anxiety.

The strong-willed Maezono and the timid Mii-chan. At first glance, they seemed like a mismatch, but surprisingly, the two often hung out together and got along well. It was natural for her not to accept the sudden farewell.

"No... I wonder. At least not right away. She's only just been told about her expulsion and she's severely shaken. Until that settles, it will be difficult."

At the mention of being shaken, the classmates exchanged complex looks.

"There are many things you might be curious about, but I'm not allowed to speak on the details. If you have questions, it would be good to discuss them later. That's all from me."

Having said that, she quickly ended the conversation, considering the developments that lay ahead.

Horikita obtained permission from Chabashira-sensei and hurriedly took the podium.

"I'm sorry, but could everyone please stay for a while?"

"Are you going to tell us what happened with Maezono-san's expulsion?"

Nishimura, who had been waiting for this moment, asked Horikita with dissatisfaction.

"Yes. I judged that we can't leave any unresolved issues from this end-of-year special exam. But I can't do it alone. Could I get everyone's cooperation?"

Maezono, who had disappeared from the class.

The cost of victory.

An unclear battle, with its details unknown.

It wouldn't have been strange if at least Kōenji had left his seat, but there was no such sign.

He only moved his gaze to check the situation, staring at himself in a hand mirror.

It seemed he wasn't completely uninterested in the details of the exam, or perhaps he wasn't listening to the teacher or Horikita's conversation. Instead, perhaps he was just absorbed in his own reflection.

It was unclear which it was, but it seemed certain he would stay for a while.

"Including myself, I want to clear up what seems to be our biggest concern first."

After saying that, Horikita began an explanation to eliminate discrepancies between the representatives and participants.

What they each knew and what they didn't.

What the rules were for determining victory, etc.

By reducing discrepancies to some extent, the situation would become clearer.

Yōsuke honestly conveyed that his way of fighting hadn't worked well, and Horikita reflected on how everything had gone smoothly until she was completely defeated by the opposing general, Ichinose.

Then, everyone's attention began to gather on what lay ahead.

That I, the general, had completely shut out Ichinose, who Horikita had described as a formidable opponent.

The process resulted in Maezono's expulsion, but representatives like Horikita and Yōsuke were also unaware of the circumstances.

First and foremost, Maezono's case was an unavoidable topic.

"In my opinion... There was definitely a risk of expulsion for the student assigned the role of traitor, but if the rules were properly understood, the risk of expulsion was almost zero. I thought Maezono-san and Ayanokōji-kun understood that well..."

With my name called, most of my classmates turned their gaze to me. Triggered by Horikita's words, I stood up and moved closer to her to explain.

Chabashira-sensei could've left, but it seemed she intended to observe the discussion.

"First, I want to apologize for the sudden expulsion of a classmate."

I said that and bowed in apology.

As usual, it was important to proceed with the discussion in an orderly manner.

"The role of the traitor had risks and rewards. If identified as a traitor, one would be expelled, but if not, one could receive either 5 million private points or 50 class points. It didn't matter which Maezono intended to choose; anyone would consider taking the reward home at least once. However, due to the nature of the traitor, the longer they stayed, the more they would end up leaking information to the opposing class. Therefore, getting them to confess early and dealing with them was undoubtedly the right choice for a straightforward victory."

This was the first thing representatives like Horikita and Yōsuke would think of, and participants would easily imagine confessing immediately if they were the traitor.

"Horikita, you've fought directly as a representative, so you'd understand. In this special exam, Ichinose was an unimaginably strong opponent. We can agree on that, right?"

"...Yes, she was strong. I couldn't envision any way to win."

Drawing out a clear declaration of defeat again, I nodded.

"I felt the same. Until I faced her, I thought I could manage somehow, but as soon as the one-on-one fight started, I immediately sensed it. For Ichinose, this exam was the best stage to demonstrate her abilities, knowing both her enemies and allies thoroughly. She had the insight to expose both truth and lies."

Horikita nodded with her eyes closed, likely recalling the actual battle.

"There was no chance of winning by fair means. Yet, being appointed as the general, I had to think about how to win. After desperately thinking within the limited time, I came up with only one path to victory."

I paused here, letting everyone digest and absorb my words before continuing.

"The method to win was—to expel the traitor early on."

Naturally, being told this, everyone's line of thought would come to a stop.

‘*What is he saying?’* Being confused in such a way would only be expected.

“Expelling Maezono... the traitor, how does that lead to victory?”

Horikita, who was next to me, spouted out the obvious question on everyone’s minds.

“I can’t beat Ichinose with a straightforward fight given my abilities. To defeat such an opponent, I thought the only way was a surprise attack. I approached Ichinose early on to negotiate, proposing that we both use up the rights of the traitor. If both parties lose that right, no handicap is created, and no one gets expelled. It should’ve been a welcome development for Ichinose, who believes in winning fairly.”

Ichinose disliked sacrificing her comrades more than anyone. No, to be precise, she doesn’t welcome anyone’s expulsion.

That was something everyone had felt over these past two years—no explanation needed.

“My aim was to use the traitor rights to make Ichinose complicit in the expulsion. That was the only method I could think of.”

At this point, the classroom became momentarily noisy.

Those who understood the explanation, those who didn’t, and those who fell into both categories.

Only Chabashira-sensei, who had been observing objectively, remained calm.

“Mutually using the rights of the traitor... Indeed, it would be easy to establish with Ichinose-san, and it indirectly implicates her in Maezono-san’s expulsion... That was your aim...”

Horikita, being the representative, naturally imagined the scenario faster than the participants.

“Faced with the reality that she’d unwittingly helped in expelling Maezono, Ichinose was greatly and intensely disturbed. Coupled with her strong feelings of guilt, she couldn’t perform to her usual standards and couldn’t make satisfactory nominations.”

She explained and demonstrated that this was the result.

“Wait a minute, please.”

Yōsuke, unable to contain himself, stood up vigorously.

“I also fought as a representative. I wasn’t useful, and I understand that I don’t have the right to complain or object. But... even so, was it worth sacrificing a classmate? Even if expelling Maezono meant a 100% chance of victory, I can’t simply agree, but what if we’d lost? Wasn’t that possibility considered? No matter the representative, I think this method is bordering on overstepping.”

“Indeed, that’s true. I think Ichinose-san would be disturbed if she knew she helped in Maezono-san’s expulsion, but that doesn’t guarantee a sure win... right?”

There seemed to be students who agreed. One of them, Ichihashi, muttered this.

“That’s right. If you’re looking at the situation with just hindsight, then that’s all that there is to it. But it was a choice between struggling aimlessly and losing or paying a sacrifice to bet on the chance of winning. Weighing the options, as the class representative and the general, I chose the latter. I thought a defeat here could be fatal. If Class A had won as speculated and our class lost, the gap in class points would’ve been 300. There’s no guarantee we could recover in just one year. It’s true for any exam, but especially this one—it was a battle we absolutely couldn’t afford to lose.”

While there were some lies in the reasoning, there was no falsehood in the background leading to Maezono’s expulsion.

To lose without sacrifice, or aim for victory even with the sacrifice.

Fundamentally, it was impossible for anyone to provide a perfect answer.

However, losing would mean a significant setback from the path to Class A; that fact loomed in the background.

“I’m not trying to justify myself, but I wouldn’t mind taking a vote here. I believe most of us wouldn’t say it’d be better for us to lose the exam than to sacrifice Maezono.”

The classroom fell silent. Students looked at each other or turned away.

It was clear they didn’t want to vote.

Most likely, Horikita wouldn’t call it either.

It would only cause pain to everyone. The answer was already understood.

As painful as it was, the fact that this class had won was greater than imagined.

A world where Sakayanagi won and Horikita lost.

It was crucial to avoid that. They couldn’t go without calculating it in their mind.

Also, the fact that it wasn’t themself who was sacrificed was something that couldn’t be ignored.

Denying it would require rethinking Sakura’s sacrifice.

Still, if there were those who would strongly deny—

“—Isn’t that too arrogant? It wasn’t right for Ayanokōji-kun alone to decide. Even a representative doesn’t have the right to decide if it’s okay to sacrifice Maezono.”

Thus, students like Yōsuke, who could protect others more than themselves, existed.

Such objections were anticipated.

“That’s right. But given the situation where I couldn’t consult anyone, I had no choice but to decide alone. And I didn’t end up thinking like Yōsuke. I was entrusted with the fate of the class, and I regarded that my top priority was to bring victory to the class.”

I confronted Yōsuke’s objection head-on with my opinion.

“But... when I think about Maezono, who was randomly chosen—”

“Sorry, but there was a proper reason why it was Maezono.”

*Why had it been Maezono*—eventually, students would have voiced their dissatisfaction on this point.

Therefore, I preemptively cut off their words.

“If I’d chosen a classmate who would end up becoming a sacrifice purely based on my preferences, a lot of discontent and anxiety would surface. Maezono wasn’t randomly chosen in such a worrying way.”

“...There’s a convincing reason behind it—is what you’re trying to say?”

Horikita, trying to stay calm, grasped what I wanted to express.

“The reason Maezono was chosen to be expelled was—”

Here, I reported that the details about me being the general in the end-of-year exam, which was a crucial piece of information, had leaked to the other classes, and it was Maezono who leaked it.

“...I’m pretty sure Horikita-san did tell everyone to keep it absolutely secret, right?”

Ichihashi, who had joined the argument, recalled the discussion from just a little while back.

“Yes. Originally, I asked Horikita to keep it that way. One of the reasons I took on the role of representative and general was to aim for a surprise element. If an unexpected pawn would instead appear while everyone assumed Horikita would be the general, they might start being suspicious of things that aren’t even there. As a result, it could’ve shaken Ichinose and her classmates. If that plan succeeded, we might have won without expelling anyone. However, the day before the exam, students in Ichinose’s class already knew I was participating as the general.”

“So the information leaked early. And it was Maezono who did it...?”

“Yes. I had asked not to leak it no matter what since it was information that directly related to my strategy, so it would also directly affect the outcome. I started investigating after finding out about it leaking to other classes.”

At this point Sudō, perhaps holding some doubts, raised his hand while seated and began to speak.

“So, is there evidence that Maezono leaked it? If there is... where did you get such evidence? I’m sure Maezono wouldn’t do something that would be so easily found out.”

Sudō, who was properly following the discussion, asked a praiseworthy question.

"To explain that, I first need to talk about why Maezono leaked the information in the first place. Of course, it's hard to imagine her passing information to another class without any reason."

The students, starting with Sudō, nodded as they listened.

"Is there anyone who knows about Maezono and Hashimoto dating?"

At this point, I skipped the detailed explanation and asked that question. Most students looked at each other in surprise, so it was clear at a glance that most of the students weren't aware of this.

However, as expected, some did possess that information.

Immediately, Kushida and Matsushita raised their hands.

Then, conservatively, Mii-chan also raised her hand. This made it a total of three people.

Regarding Kushida—it was as expected. Even though she'd been ostracized in the class after her true nature was exposed, her ability to gather information was still high. On the other hand, Matsushita might've figured out her relationship with Hashimoto from observing me investigate Maezono before the exam. As for Mii-chan, Maezono probably secretly confided in her due to their close relationship.

"Hashimoto is well known for placing an emphasis on information gathering, including from his own class. He was intentionally extracting information from this class by connecting with Maezono."

"So she was asked to do it by her boyfriend, right?"

"It seems their boyfriend-girlfriend relationship was taken advantage of from the beginning."

If Maezono and those close to her knew, it would be a hurtful truth.

But the more one knew about Hashimoto Masayoshi, the more they'd feel convinced.

To make my point more convincing, I turned my gaze to Sudō, who had asked the question.

"Sudō, has Maezono ever called you to gather and talk about me?"

I asked, and he tilted his head as if he couldn't immediately recall. However, as I mentioned the names of several participants from the meeting and its timing, it seemed he gradually began to remember.

"Ah, yeah. That did happen. You really know a lot about it, huh…?"

Although I didn't know about the scene of the gathering or the conversation itself, if the talk's main topic was about me, it wouldn't be strange if they had decided to keep a lid on it. That was why it might've been surprising that I was able to obtain its details.

“That gathering wasn’t just Maezono’s idea; it was executed under Hashimoto’s instructions behind the scenes.”

Sudō, looking back on past events, was at a loss for words, and Ike, looking puzzled, spoke up.

“Hey, why do you know about that, Ayanokōji… It was supposed to be a secret…”

I was well aware that bringing up this topic would raise such questions.

At this point, it’d be ideal if she voluntarily took the initiative to speak up rather than everyone hearing it from me.

“It’s because I told him. What Ayanokōji-kun’s saying is true. There’s no mistake.”

Matsushita, who had been present at the scene, raised her hand and confidently identified herself as a witness.

Her assessment of the situation was accurate, and her timing was faultless.

Although more than half of the class still wasn’t quite convinced, this would still prevent objections.

This much was enough to justify expelling Maezono.

Because there was no need to convince all the students.

It was enough to convince some of the students while leaving others with lingering distrust.

To put it simply, achieving a fifty-fifty split would be considered best.

I saw this working out positively for the class in the long run.

“Well, I was quite convinced, but... can I say something...?”

While verbally expressing his agreement, Sudō still appeared somewhat unconvinced.

It seemed that he had a slightly different perspective from other students.

He pulled out his chair and stood up to verbalize his thoughts.

“I understand that you did everything you could for the class to win. The initial strategy failed because of Maezono’s leak, and Ichinose was stronger than expected, so you fought ready to harm your comrades. But… was expelling Maezono really the only option? I mean... I thought, if it were you, Ayanokōji, you could’ve come up with a way to win without sacrificing anyone.”

Sudō had seen a certain extent of my abilities and had some suspicions.

Because of that, he seemed to have thought that a better method could’ve been devised.

The perspective that it might’ve been possible to win without using Maezono wasn’t bad.

Because Sudō’s insight was half correct.

While it would lower the chances of winning, it wasn’t impossible to win without expulsions.

I thought about deliberately being vague, but before that, the student next to me moved to speak.

"Ayanokōji-kun is certainly skilled enough to be entrusted with being the general. But, it's also true that she was still stronger than that. I can guarantee that, having fought her directly. I really couldn't stand against Ichinose-san. And almost immediately, I realized that I couldn't win. Just before switching, I was sure that Ayanokōji-kun too... would lose. I was forced to accept defeat to the point that I couldn't even believe in my comrade's victory."

As the class leader, Horikita had challenged the exam with extraordinary resolve.

The pressure she felt was enough to lend credibility to her words without needing further details.

"I see… So, Ichinose was that strong..."

Normally, one wouldn't get the impression that Ichinose was strong or scary.

That was probably why it was hard to imagine, but Horikita's honest report convinced many of the classmates.

"May I say something? Having witnessed her strength firsthand, I can come to a conclusion. I cannot blame Ayanokōji-kun's decision. No, rather, looking at the results, I now think it was the only and best choice he could've made. It was... necessary for our class to win."

Horikita, entrusted as the class leader, answered thus.

Of course, she couldn't simply be happy. It was her role to do what was possible to avoid expulsions. However, she accepted the necessary measures, albeit painfully.

No, it was a situation where there was no choice but to accept it.

Nothing said here could bring Maezono back.

Instead of looking backward, one must think positively.

"...Understood. If the class leader says so, I'll support it. After all, Ayanokōji fought with the resolve to be resented by his comrades for the sake of the class."

Sudō nodded in understanding and sat back down in his chair.

Sudō's unexpected question and Horikita's response.

*Had the situation moved as intended—about half and half?* No, perhaps a bit more were convinced.

Unlike my expectations, words of criticism did not continue.

I thought about whether there was any need to stoke the dying fire, but then a student quietly spoke up.

"But, you know. But… three people have been expelled from our class, right? Yamauchi-kun, Sakura-san, and then Maezono-san… All of them, Ayanokōji-kun was involved with… right?"

While hesitating, Azuma made that remark.

"What do you mean by that?"

Albeit in a gentle tone, Matsushita asked Azuma.

"I mean, it's a bit too coincidental, you know…"

Though hesitating, her implications questioned whether it was really just a coincidence.

"Are you saying Ayanokōji is deliberately causing expulsions?"

Sudō, who declared himself on the defense, quickly retorted to Azuma.

"I'm not saying that much. But we won't become victims next, right?"

"Well, I might understand what Azuma-san is saying. It does make me a bit uneasy..."

Mori also seemed to harbor doubts, affirming Azuma's statement. Although I would've also wanted to see some opposing views, the voices raised and their reasons were somewhat weak.

"I'm not sure if I have the right to speak, but may I?"

Kushida made a statement in a manner that could neither be judged as angelic nor demonic.

"Azuma-san and the others might think that Ayanokōji-kun is intentionally getting people expelled, but I don't think that's the case. For example, the reason Sakura-san got expelled was originally due to my issues with Horikita-san, and it was just because I drew the bow against the class that led to an expulsion. If everyone had unanimously agreed, no one would've been expelled. If Ayanokōji-kun hadn't acted, we wouldn't have cleared the exam, and our class points would've been taken away. In other words, he just took on the role that no one else wanted to. It's the same with Yamauchi-kun's betrayal, and from what I've heard, there were issues with Maezono-san too. So, in a situation where we couldn't win without sacrificing someone, he took the lead to minimize the damage. We shouldn't look at it in a bad light, but in a good one, right?"

Kushida also explained to Azuma and the others that all these measures were necessary to save the class.

While acknowledging the consequences of her own rampage, her words carried weight because she was directly involved.

With Kushida and Matsushita's support, Azuma and his group reluctantly lowered their raised hands.

At that moment, a male student who had pulled out his chair stood up and reached for the classroom door.

"Where are you going, Kōenji?"

Sudō, who quickly noticed the anomaly, questioned Kōenji.

"Where? I was thinking of heading home now."

"The discussion isn't over yet."

"I was just killing time until my date. I don't want to be late for my rendezvous, so I'll be excusing myself."

Kōenji, who had been checking his appearance in the mirror and using his phone, clearly wasn't waiting to see the outcome of the discussion. Rather, he was acting on his own convenience.

Indeed, since Chabashira-sensei had already concluded homeroom, there was no problem with him leaving.

"As usual, you're doing whatever you want. You know this is an important discussion, right?"

"Important? I can't see what's so important about it at all."

Saying this, Kōenji lightly dismissed Sudō's words and left the classroom.

The class atmosphere was somewhat anticlimactic. That was why Chabashira-sensei, perhaps deciding that now was the time to cut into the conversation, returned to the teacher's podium.

"Kōenji isn't here, so maybe we should just disband for now."

She seemed to think it was time to put a stop to the student-led discussion and intervene as the homeroom teacher.

"I agree. If no one else insists on continuing, let's end it here."

With a stern expression, Yōsuke watched the proceedings and showed no objection.

Despite his dissatisfaction, he appeared to agree that it was best to stop at this point.

*Incidentally, as a side note, the class points after the exam are likely as follows:*

***Class Points at the End of the Year-End Special Exam***

*Horikita's Class A: 1233 Points*
*Sakayanagi's Class B: 1093 Points*
*Ryūen's Class C: 1040~1090 Points*
*Ichinose's Class D: 714 Points*

Horikita's class slightly pulled ahead and was promoted to Class A.

Ryūen's class was close behind Sakayanagi's class.

Only Ichinose's class was significantly left behind.

These were the current class points, but what followed was crucial.

Since Sakayanagi would be expelled, it was almost certain that her class would receive a penalty.

As no student had chosen to voluntarily withdraw during these past two years, it was unclear. However, recent research into past cases revealed that a penalty of 300 class points had been imposed as initially expected.

Thus, if the same penalty applied, Sakayanagi's class would drop to 793 points and probably fall to third place.

That meant there was a high probability of transitioning to a state of two strong and two weak classes.

*With the spring break ahead of us, we will have to move around a lot more than expected.*

# 1

After school, all the students had left the classroom. It seemed like Kei wanted to go home with me, but when I told her it was better to go home with Satō and the others today, she quickly backed off, sensing the situation.

The cause of Maezono's expulsion was all due to me alone, and immediately after a classmate's expulsion, being seen as a couple would only worsen Kei's reputation. To avoid that, it was safer to go home alone today.

Horikita and Yōsuke knew the details better than anyone, and they should've wanted to question me further. Yet, they understood this and didn't stay in the classroom for long.

"Well... I guess I'll head home too."

Thinking that, I was the last to leave the classroom.

All that was left was to head straight back to the dormitory—

"Hey, Ayanokōji-kun."

As I exited the classroom, Kushida called out to me.

It seemed she'd been waiting for me, judging from the absence of people around.

"I have something I want to ask you."

"It might be better to do this over the phone."

"Because someone who sees us might start a bad rumor?"

She seemed well aware of that possibility.

"If you don't mind, shall we discuss the matter right here?"

"I'm not in the mood to curry favor with the class right now. Besides, it makes more sense to ask you directly."

"What do you want to say?"

"Just now in front of Azuma, or rather in front of our classmates, I defended you and smoothed things over, but you actually intentionally got Maezono expelled, right? It was a chance to eliminate a traitor."

"No, that was—"

I tried to deny it superficially, but Kushida slightly raised the corners of her mouth and continued.

"Sure, Ichinose was strong in the recent exam—no doubt about that. But if it's you, Ayanokōji-kun, you could've cornered her mentally by other means, right?"

The expression 'cornered her mentally by other means' rather than 'won using your abilities' was a brilliant read.

"Our naive classmates and the good-natured Horikita think in convenient ways, so they wouldn't imagine something like that."

Kushida's insight, always probing into others' minds, was evident.

“Besides, even if by some chance you lost, you’d view it positively if you could get rid of Maezono, right?”

If we lost, and Maezono was eliminated as a result, most people would see that as a purely negative outcome. However, she had reasoned that even if we were defeated, losing her wouldn’t be a significant blow to the class.

“I’m genuinely impressed. What an approach.”

“Why’d you think so?”

“Because you’re the person who pushed me to the brink of expulsion, Ayanokōji-kun. It would be strange if you weren’t thinking something like that.”

She didn’t mention any minor details, but that was the main reason.

I was genuinely impressed, but still, it was better to avoid saying anything explicit here.

“I just did what was necessary to win. She was a tough opponent.”

“Hmm?”

Realizing it was an excuse, she didn’t probe any further.

“Never mind me, I was impressed by how you handled yourself. It was a perfect intervention. Many students, while wary of you, acknowledged the accuracy of your statements.”

The unanimous special exam incident must’ve left a significant impression on Kushida.

“Of course. I’ve lost a lot, so I need to recover some ground and secure a safe position in the class, because while in the hands of Ayanokōji-kun, who knows what will happen next?”

Securing her position to avoid being targeted for expulsion.

*It’s fine if it’s for her own sake. If that motivates her, then it’s a good thing.*

“Horikita seems to trust you too, Kushida.”

“Stop it. Horikita and I are enemies, but we’re just in a truce for the same goal.”

Kushida would surely continue to navigate skillfully within the class.

I wouldn’t be able to watch it from the inside, but that was the moment I felt certain.

# 2

*Here, we go slightly back in time.*

It was around the time Horikita and the others began discussing Maezono's expulsion within the class.

In another class, a reflection meeting about the end-of-year special exam was about to start.

Ichinose's class had been on the edge and had to win at all costs.

The three representatives, along with Hoshinomiya, returned and sat down in their seats with little to say.

In the silent classroom, Ichinose hung her head down, unable to look up.

However, she had to explain in order to move this stalled time forward.

"...Everyone... I'm sorry."

Ichinose's words came out strained.

"Today's exam... we lost because of me..."

Neither the participants nor even the representatives knew the details of the special exam.

The battle between representatives wasn't public. They could only infer from the results and their appearance.

That was the same not only for Horikita's class but also for Ichinose's class.

A classmate's expulsion was a painful event, but still, that class grasped victory.

You could say that there were plenty of reasons to keep moving forward.

On the other hand, this class was different.

Only the heavy reality of defeat weighed down upon them.

—Or it should have.

The oppressive atmosphere didn't last long enough to affect the class negatively.

This was because the students in the class tended not to favor that kind of atmosphere.

"You shouldn't be the one apologizing, Honami-chan."

"We should've debated better and been more helpful, I think."

The words communicated weren't blaming Ichinose, but comforting her.

"That's right. You don't need to worry about it at all."

Who spoke, and such matters, weren't necessary in this place.

Not just one person, but similar follow-ups naturally flew one after the other.

Yes, it was by no means a rare sight.

You could call it an ordinary scene.

In sad times, everyone encouraged each other, and in tough times, everyone acted cheerfully.

They never targeted and cornered a specific person.

Of course, that positive way of thinking itself wasn't wrong.

But now, what was happening before their eyes was a familiar, unchanging licking of wounds.

Himeno watched the class with an indescribable frustration.

*This can't continue*. Only that awareness strongly resided within her.

Of course, she understood that it wasn't just Ichinose's fault that they'd lost.

As the other students said, there might've been more that they could've done as participants.

Himeno herself knew she hadn't achieved praiseworthy results.

*But still, no progress can be made if we keep turning our backs on the results.*

...Himeno thought.

That was why she wanted to object and have everyone think again.

She was determined to not let the defeat end as a defeat. Instead, she wanted to carry it forward to the next opportunity.

However, she couldn't speak.

The words reached her throat, but then it retreated back.

She was a student who neither liked stepping forward nor was she good at it.

Thinking she could muster the courage just this once wasn't as easy as she thought.

*Nervousness*. Her hands started to slowly sweat.

Her upper and lower lips were heavily stuck together and wouldn't part.

Her throat became dry.

Her gaze couldn't settle, and her head began to hurt.

It was always like that—the frustration of not being able to convey her intentions in front of a crowd.

But Himeno was beginning to change.

Until now, she'd been alone. However, now there was a student nearby who understood her.

Thus, seeking help, Himeno looked at Kanzaki.

They'd formed a small group with the spirit of creating a system where they could express their opinions to Ichinose.

Just the first word would be enough. If Kanzaki could prompt her here and now, she could speak.

It was Himeno's small resolution, different from before.

However...

Kanzaki, far from showing a willingness to stand up, wasn't even looking around.

He seemed to be waiting for this time to end, his head bowed and motionless.

Then she turned to another friend, Hamaguchi. As if trying to cling onto him, she directed her gaze.

Hamaguchi quickly noticed Himeno, but looked baffled and gently shook his head from side to side.

With Kanzaki sitting still, he seemed to say, 'It isn't the time.'

Himeno couldn't get the push she needed, and time just passed.

"Right now, we might be in a pinch. But hey, there's still more to come."

Shibata stood up, determined to encourage Ichinose, who was trying to shoulder the responsibility alone. He approached her, showing a triumphant pose.

"So what if we lost this time? We still have a whole year ahead. Hey, isn't that right, everyone?"

He then looked around the classroom, trying to rally everyone, and shouted.

Himeno's feelings were contrary to reality, which was cruel.

Concealing her feelings, she ended up aligning her pace with her rousing classmates who told her to fight.

The repeated confirmation bias was filling the classroom.

The one who watched these classmates with the coldest eyes was their homeroom teacher, Hoshinomiya.

She endured as much as she could, often feeling nauseous.

As a teacher, she needed to avoid unnecessary intervention.

That was the rule of the school.

She'd hardly intended to adhere to it originally, but she reached the limits of her patience.

Hoshinomiya spread her palms wide, raised them high, and then slammed them powerfully onto the teacher's desk. The atmosphere, which had begun to regain some liveliness, froze instantly.

"Everyone… do you really understand the situation?"

Hoshinomiya muttered in a flat tone to the students who were licking each other's wounds.

"I'll say it frankly—you're all abnormal, very abnormal."

The harsh words continued from the teacher.

The students, who had been forcing on smiles, now had their expressions stiffened.

"Chi- Chie-chan?"

A male student, concerned about the frozen state of the classroom, called out Hoshinomiya's name in such a way.

But ignoring him, she glared at Shibata, who was standing by Ichinose.

"Shibata-kun, you just said we still have plenty of time ahead, right?"

"Uh, uh... Yes..."

"Do you seriously think so?"

"Well, yeah. I mean, it's too early to give up. In soccer terms, we might be behind but if it's just a two or three-goal difference, if we can just get the ball rolling—"

"Two goals, three goals? Momentum? Don't be stupid. The loss really hurt this time."

"No. But Sensei, if we have one more year—"

"If we have a year? No, that's not it. You understand, don't you? That we only have one year left."

"There's definitely a chance to turn things arou—"

"There isn't. Let me use your beloved soccer as an example. Far from scoring two goals back, no matter how you think of it, we've probably given up three more goals today, and now we're losing by something like ten goals. That's how far behind we are. And to top it off, our opponents are better than us. It's about time you understood that."

The students refused to face reality.

Unable to bear it, Hoshinomiya continued.

Yet Shibata still refused to give up.

"Sensei, have you heard of the term 'giant-killing'? If it's us, we could—"

"Shut up. What all of you need to do is to accept reality, not babble on about these pipe dreams."

It was necessary to bring the students lost in a deep forest back to reality.

Seeing Hoshinomiya raise her voice in such a frightening tone for the first time, Shibata, who was about to retort, ultimately had no choice but to swallow his words.

He was instructed to return to his seat, and reluctantly, Shibata moved away from Ichinose.

"We're finished. Isn't that right, Ichinose-san?"

Hoshinomiya approached the ever-downcast Ichinose and spoke to her.

"Sensei..."

Hoshinomiya, who'd been overseeing the exam, knew.

She knew that Ichinose had been devastated by Ayanokōji and was deeply mentally wounded.

Yet, she had to make her accept it.

*The reality that this class had no chance of winning anymore.*

“This is my responsibility. From now on, I don’t have the confidence to continue being the leader of this class—”

Ichinose began to express her intention to step down from her position.

But Hoshinomiya didn’t let her finish her words.

“That’s not it.”

“...Eh?”

“I wasn’t looking for weak words like those. I just want you to look at reality.”

Until moments ago, Hoshinomiya had been angry. However, now, she showed a gentle smile.

“You understand that we’re losing now, and that at this rate, we won’t be able to win in the future, right?”

“...Yes…”

Forced to face the harsh truth, Ichinose had no choice but to agree.

Hearing this, Hoshinomiya nodded with satisfaction.

“It’s alright, Ichinose-san. I believe in your abilities. Just leave all your worries to me, your teacher.”

Hoshinomiya gently patted Ichinose’s shoulder and whispered in her ear.

If they were to allow Ichinose to step down now, it would significantly disrupt the future management of the class.

Hoshinomiya decided it was crucial to delay the conclusion of the meeting.

“So for now, take your time and take care of your heart first. Okay?”

With those words, Hoshinomiya left Ichinose and returned to her usual demeanor.

By solely leaving things to the students, they would no longer escape from the lowest point—Class D.

The only option left was for her to take action herself and save the class from outside the rules.

Now, all Hoshinomiya hoped for from Ichinose was to prevent the class from falling apart in the meantime.

“That’s the end of all the gloomy talk. While we can’t change the result we got this time, from now on, it’ll be different. Soon, it’ll be Spring break and we’ll be having the three-way conferences. We’ll need to be thinking of your career paths too.”

She said, trying to conclude the matter.

She didn’t want to breathe the deteriorating air of the classroom any longer.

Despite being close to victory, Ichinose, unable to fully demonstrate her abilities against Ayanokōji, fell ill from this day and began missing school.

And without showing up at school even once, she entered into a gloomy spring break.

# Chapter 2:
# See You Next Time

AFTER THE INTENSE end-of-year exam, it was soon Saturday, March 19.

At 7 a.m., Ryūen left the dormitory alone and headed towards the outskirts of the school.

At that early hour, when many were still asleep, the temperature was somewhat chilly.

Upon reaching his destination, he noticed that the person he was meeting had already arrived.

With her small back turned to Ryūen, she seemed to be quietly admiring the scenery.

After watching from a distance for a while, Ryūen deliberately made his footsteps louder as he approached.

"You got here pretty fast."

He spoke, taking care not to startle her.

By chance, they hadn't seen each other for several days since their last decisive encounter.

*What expression will she show when she turns back, and how will she respond?*

Ryūen didn't want to stir things up—he just genuinely wanted to know.

Slowly turning around, cane in hand, Sakayanagi faced Ryūen.

Her large eyes, staring at Ryūen, harbored the same strong will as before.

"Regrettably, since my legs are quite inadequate, I have to carry out my schedule a bit earlier than the average person."

After explaining why she had arrived early, she added to her comment.

"And besides, knowing this is going to be the last time I get to see this scenery, I end up feeling reluctant to part with it."

*So I came for a walk a bit earlier*, she implied with her tone.

The one who called her out was Ryūen

The one who was called out was Sakayanagi.

While Sakayanagi intended to wait for Ryūen to start the conversation, he remained silent.

This was done so that she couldn't read his expression or gestures, preventing her from determining what sort of emotions he was feeling as he stood there.

He was trying to see if going straight to the point was the correct move here.

Sensing Ryūen's heightened wariness, Sakayanagi decided to open up a bit instead.

“Thank you for giving me this grace period right up until the time of my voluntary withdrawal. There was still unfinished business I needed to take care of, which did require some time, and having it granted was helpful.”

Normally, the bet between Ryūen and Sakayanagi would’ve meant the loser had to leave the school immediately after the end-of-year special exam. It wouldn’t have been strange if Sakayanagi had packed up and left the school with Maezono right after the exam. She was able to stay just because she received her opponent’s, Ryūen’s, permission.

If the expulsion had been a school-mandated exam rule, there would’ve been specific regulations.

Therefore, the expulsion would’ve been executed immediately, but Sakayanagi’s situation was a voluntary withdrawal set up solely by the students themselves, and the school side was merely mediating to enforce the arrangement. There were no detailed rules set between the two parties, and it wasn’t clearly stated whether she would leave the school within the day or not. Thus, it was agreed that she would voluntarily withdraw within a month, and the school had accepted this arrangement.

“Surely you don’t think that I did it to be considerate of you.”

“Oh, was that not the case?”

“You’re terribly mistaken. It was just more convenient for me. It’s better to have some time to deeply engrave the reality of your expulsion into the minds of the Class A students.”

If Sakayanagi disappeared right after the exam without them even knowing the reason or understanding why, the cruel reality of the situation and the shock wouldn’t be as significant, he stated.

“Oops, you guys aren’t in Class A anymore, huh?”

Ryūen laughed artificially, and Sakayanagi smiled in return.

“I see. So it was just for your own sake. I shall retract my words of thanks then.”

Seeing her unfazed demeanor, Ryūen scoffed and put his hands in his pockets.

“As promised, I will be leaving this school soon, but what business did you have with me?”

Seeing his demeanor and how he didn’t get to the main point straight away, Sakayanagi guessed what he wanted to say. She softly urged him to make it easier for him to talk.

“There’s something I want to hear before a loser miserably leaves this school.”

Ryūen, seemingly showing mercy, provoked her again with a provocative tone.

“Please feel free to ask. If it’s something I can answer, I will gladly do so.”

As if she had come to this place for that purpose, Sakayanagi showed a welcoming attitude towards the conversation.

The conditions should've been set, but as Ryūen opened his mouth to speak, he shut it again.

However, this was slightly different from before.

Contrary to his intentions, he couldn't immediately find the words he wanted to say.

There were things Ryūen intended to ask that he could only find out here and now.

Yet, hesitation arose.

*Whether it should be confirmed or not.*

Although the answer should've been clear within himself, seeing the person in front of him made Ryūen waver.

To avoid showing his hesitation, Ryūen started walking and passed by Sakayanagi.

And when they were back to back, he stopped again.

"Despite your expulsion being decided, you seem the same as always. Just putting on a brave front?"

"Well, what do you think? How did I appear in your eyes?"

"...Hmph."

Nothing had changed. She was still an audacious woman throughout. That was Ryūen's frank impression.

As long as the other party maintained a strong stance, Ryūen could no longer afford to hesitate.

There were things he had to ask, things he had to convey.

"I'm not satisfied with that match."

The words were hard to spit out.

He was dragging out feelings that had never existed in him before into the daylight.

"Not satisfied? The matter was settled clearly, wasn't it?"

"Cut the crap. I admitted defeat to you in the final stages."

He acknowledged the reality that he was defeated by a worthy opponent, albeit with frustration.

He was trying to accept the reality of his expulsion.

But in the end, the result was reversed.

It was difficult to simply accept that unquestionably.

"You judged that you exerted your full strength and stepped down from the battle. But that was just your premature calculation. It wasn't the real conclusion."

What she thought was a victory turned out to be a defeat, and what he thought was a defeat turned out to be a victory.

Such things often happen in the world of competition.

"Even so, this time it's different. If it'd just been between you and me, I would accept it, but the result was overturned because of some message from Ayanokōji. You expect me to easily accept that?"

"Whether you accept it or not, the result is the result. It's unchangeable."

A person who spoke with logic, and one who tried to defy it.

"Even so… I understand your feelings, Ryūen-kun. It must feel like a fishbone stuck in your throat when you don't understand the reason why I accepted defeat all on my own."

The situation where defeat was 99% certain had been overturned.

Undoubtedly, the 'message' from Ayanokōji that Ryūen received was the reason.

*It had to be because of Ayanokōji's message. I had always felt a sense of unease.*

*However, I couldn't have imagined that a single message would completely turn the game on its head.*

"If you had wanted to win then and there, you could've. But you took the risk of expulsion and overlooked the traitor, Hashimoto. What kind of message could twist that intention?"

The only way to find out was to confront Ayanokōji or Sakayanagi.

"Well, I find it interesting to leave that unpleasant feeling as it is... but since I said I would answer what I can, let me tell you in detail."

After saying that, Sakayanagi recalled her feelings during the exam and adorned a self-deprecating smile.

Ryūen, with his back turned, couldn't see her expression.

Perhaps both of them had expressions neither wanted the other to see.

"The message I received from him through you and Hashimoto-kun was about the future Ayanokōji-kun envisions."

"...Huh?"

"He has one more year of school life left. He wanted you, not me. If one of us had to be expelled and disappear, he wanted to fight Ryūen Kakeru, not Sakayanagi Arisu—"

That was the message Ayanokōji conveyed to Sakayanagi.

"So you're saying, you lost on your own will, taking into account his wishes? Even though it meant overlooking Hashimoto instead of crushing him…? Impossible."

Hearing that message, Ryūen felt anger well up before he could even agree or disagree.

It wasn't directed at Ayanokōji, who intervened, but at Sakayanagi's overly naive thinking.

"If I had been given such a message, I would've ignored it. I'd crush Hashimoto and then go punch him. I wouldn't let it go like he wishes."

"You might've done so. You are simpler than you think."

"Ah?"

"Indeed, if this message had been conveyed directly by you, Hashimoto-kun, or some third party, I wouldn't have stepped down from the match either."

While recalling her interaction with Hashimoto during the end-of-year special exam, Sakayanagi continued.

"Because it was a hidden message, I judged that picking up on it was the best course of action."

"I don't get it—what do you mean?"

"Yes, I suppose this is something only I can understand."

Ryūen frowned at the explanation he couldn't comprehend.

Sakayanagi, without turning around, could imagine his expression and smiled slightly.

"Of course, I don't completely agree. Honestly, I was bedridden for half a day afterward."

In other words, she recovered in half a day.

"Maybe you are more suited to fight Ayanokōji."

Ryūen hadn't intended to make such a self-deprecating remark, but he blurted it out in response to Sakayanagi's absurd reasoning.

"I understand it's frustrating not to have been able to overcome the challenge yourself. But even if I had forcibly defeated you... no, let's not dwell on what-ifs."

Ryūen, standing behind her, wasn't satisfied with the match's outcome.

He was more upset by his incomprehension than she'd anticipated.

*I'd thought Ryūen would simply be happy with any kind of victory.*

That was where Sakayanagi's reading had been off.

Only one thing became clear in Ryūen's mind—what he should've done.

"Passing on Ayanokōji's message to you was a mistake."

"Fufufu."

"What's so funny? You self-destructed because of that message. He intervened in the outcome without being asked. I should've fought to the end for myself alone."

"And you would've lost to me and accepted defeat?"

"Don't assume. If I'd used the traitor rights effectively, there was a chance I could've defeated you."

If Ryūen hadn't planned to deliver the message, he could've used the traitor as he saw fit.

He'd been fighting with a handicap, albeit a slight one.

“I see. Indeed, that is true. But even if you’d kept the traitor rights and used it strategically, I wouldn’t have lost.”

She claimed that it wasn’t a possibility but a certainty. No matter when Ryūen would’ve used the traitor, she was confident she would’ve responded perfectly.

However, it was clear that this conversation would lead nowhere as neither would concede, so it had to be dropped.

“You’re in a more unsettled state right now than you imagine. Do you think you can beat Ayanokōji-kun like that?”

“I will defeat him. It’s decided. That’s why I’m standing here now.”

“I see. But do you think you can win in just one more year?”

“Of course.”

“Do you really feel that way? Right now, you seem quite unsteady. Ayanokōji-kun would probably have the same impression if he saw you now.”

Normally, anyone would be sick of Ayanokōji’s silly messages and reject them.

Yet Sakayanagi talked about Ayanokōji with genuine happiness.

Ryūen, who didn’t know the details, understood that Sakayanagi’s love was real.

She had emotions that transcended mere profit and loss.

“You’re free to blindly believe in Ayanokōji, but I still don’t like it.”

“You don’t like it, huh? You’ve been saying some pretty idealistic things. Isn’t it your principle to use any means necessary to win? You couldn’t ignore the message Ayanokōji-kun wanted to send to me, and you were manipulated. Your strength was simply insufficient. I accepted defeat knowing the content of the message, and my strength was insufficient. Isn’t that all there is to it?”

Ryūen, who emerged as the victor, was less accepting of the situation than Sakayanagi, who’d lost.

That irritated Ryūen even more.

He knew the real reason. It was because what Sakayanagi was saying was correct.

“Don’t mistake me for a saint. The core of Ayanokōji-kun’s actions is selfish. If it benefits him, others are nothing but disposable pawns. I think you and I are similar types of people, but there’s no comparison, Ryūen-kun. He truly believes this from the bottom of his heart. And he has evolved further in this school. He found a purpose. And for that purpose, he would hurt someone, push them to expulsion, and even manipulate others’ victories and defeats. That is the person called Ayanokōji Kiyotaka. He will use anything and anyone if it benefits him. Someone’s faint romantic feelings, special relationships—everything is used for his own ends.”

One-on-one. Fair and square. Even if the parties involved decided those conditions, Ayanokōji, who wasn't a part of that agreement, was free to act as he pleased. Ryūen himself had continued such selfish battles throughout his life.

But even in areas where he excelled, Ayanokōji easily surpassed him.

He executed his plans so perfectly and efficiently to the point of it frustrating Ryūen.

"Ha... I'm impressed that you're so into such a crazy guy."

"I pride myself on having feelings for Ayanokōji-kun that are second to none."

Like a child showing off a toy, Sakayanagi said this with a proud smile.

"I understand—the feeling of not liking it."

The words directed at Ryūen were also partly a reminder to herself.

She hadn't completely given up on the possibility that Ayanokōji saw her as special.

Of course, Ayanokōji had probably envisioned a future where Sakayanagi could win.

He had anticipated all possibilities and prepared in advance to be ready no matter how things turned out.

He always prepared countless options and anticipated every pattern.

"Considering the outcome, he even calculated that you would agonize over it. The only way his calculation could be wrong is if you suffer mentally and lose your fighting spirit over something of this magnitude."

Sakayanagi smiled at the person behind her as if to say, "You're not that weak, are you?"

"I..."

"If the fangs really have fallen out, then perhaps for the first time, Ayanokōji-kun might have to reconsider that it should've been me, not you, who's worthy to be on the battlefield."

*I'm not losing my fighting spirit*. He kept telling himself that, but the feeling that he was being drained was an undeniable fact.

Sakayanagi, feeling Ryūen's emotions firsthand, sincerely thought it was enviable.

"It's really regrettable, isn't it? Not being able to continue watching Ayanokōji-kun's actions from the front row."

"Then, shouldn't you be begging me here to let you stay, even if it means bowing your head?"

As a matter of fact, Sakayanagi's expulsion hadn't yet been implemented.

"Unfortunately, I have no such intention. I've already packed my bags. Besides, I think this incident has been a good learning experience for me. It has broadened my perspective."

Contrary to the troubled Ryūen, Sakayanagi was ready to take another step forward.

"That's too bad. If you'd apologized by rubbing your forehead on the ground, I might've been able to negotiate with the school to cancel the bet."

"Let's not make such graceless gestures."

Her resolve was firm and unwavering. That was a certain fact.

"Still, it was unexpected. Considering how you provoked me when we met, I thought you would be happy with this result..."

Sakayanagi smiled slightly regretfully.

"That end-of-year special exam was different. That's what I thought."

Ryūen intended to defeat Sakayanagi fairly from the beginning to the end.

And because he was sure he could defeat her, he had unwavering confidence.

But even then, Sakayanagi had surpassed such a Ryūen fair and square.

Even if defeat seemed likely, Ryūen was more satisfied with the process than frustrated.

"What should I make of this? This is a new feeling for me. A win is a win. I should be happy as you say. That's how I've always done it, but... doubts are coming up."

It would be easy to push her away here since they weren't allies. That would be the natural thing to do.

But now, Sakayanagi sincerely wanted to support Ryūen.

"I will give you a solution. If you are unwilling to accept the reality that you have won, it would be best for you to simply withdraw from school."

"Ah...?"

"Right? If you want to lose to me, feel free to lose even now. If you choose to withdraw before me, that would undoubtedly be a defeat."

She conveyed that defeat, which could be found scattered everywhere, was easy to pick up.

Ryūen turned around and glared, meeting Sakayanagi's gaze, who then smiled.

"Fufu, well, those were my honest feelings, but I admit it was said in a rather mean way."

Saying this, Sakayanagi, as a guide, showed the way to the lost Ryūen.

"Fighting against Ayanokōji-kun means you will also have to confront the contradictions you currently hold. He cannot be measured by simple standards. Without turning your contradictions into your weapons, you cannot possibly stand against him. Even I felt I had misjudged him."

Sakayanagi, who had thought of and observed Ayanokōji more than anyone else, spoke with weight in her words.

“What I said earlier about you withdrawing is true. However, losing is always an option. Fortunately, you have won. Therefore, you still have the right to continue fighting. To easily give that up would be foolish, wouldn’t it?”

He had no intention of giving up; he’d merely been wavering.

Ryūen, who was hungrier for victory than anyone else, would never make such a choice.

“You have no choice but to continue fighting tenaciously and to cling on. There are things that can only be obtained by doing so. Eventually, they will benefit you. However, I cannot guarantee that what awaits at the end is hope.”

At this point, Ryūen’s abilities were far from matching Ayanokōji’s.

No matter how favorably one looked, that reality wouldn’t change.

“While you struggle, I intend to wait in anticipation for the day I can have a rematch with him.”

“...Even if Ayanokōji deemed you unnecessary, do you intend to keep chasing after him?”

“Of course. I did stop for a moment at that time, but my feelings haven’t changed at all. I’m repeating myself at this point, but Ayanokōji-kun is special to me.”

After a brief silence, Sakayanagi chuckled amusingly.

“Even though you are weakened, it seems your spirit isn’t dead.”

“I’ve experienced similar humiliation at this school before. Perhaps those experiences were useful.”

Otherwise, she wouldn’t be standing here now.

It wouldn’t be an exaggeration to say that she had been led by Ayanokōji until this point.

“Let me give you my greatest advice—know that you cannot defeat him alone.”

“That’s your advice? Don’t make me laugh.”

"You should be well aware of the height of the wall that is Ayanokōji-kun. You have grown over the two years of school life here, but you cannot possibly overcome that wall. You may utilize brutality and violence, but to Ayanokōji-kun, those are child's play. He can fight in your area of expertise without hesitation."

"Then what should I do?"

"You need to change your way of thinking and adopt more flexible thinking. It's nearly impossible to defeat the nearly flawless Ayanokōji Kiyotaka-kun. Not only directly, but even cunning strategies won't work. Therefore… I will create a special weakness in him for you."

"You, creating a weakness in him?"

"Yes. That might help you someday. No matter how brilliant his mind is, or rather because it is so brilliant, unexpected weaknesses can arise."

This advice was given because Sakayanagi, in her own way, wanted to get back at Ayanokōji for being mean.

Using a message that only a genius like herself could decipher, she was confident she could control Ayanokōji's thinking.

*She's the one more suited…* He was about to let out such ridiculous feelings again. The words were in his throat, but this time, he forcefully swallowed them.

"It might be good to continue wandering for a while. If you don't give up, a path will open up."

"Don't talk as if you can see through someone else's mind. Are you Ayanokōji or what?"

"That is the highest compliment, I suppose."

After answering, Sakayanagi lightly tapped the ground with her cane.

"Is it about time? I have another appointment after this."

Ryūen realized that they had been talking for quite a while.

This would probably be the last conversation he would have with Sakayanagi.

"What will you do after leaving here?"

"I was given the name of the school where Masumi-san transferred. I intend to visit her first to apologize."

"She'll be startled if you show up."

"Well… knowing her, the first thing she'll probably do is sigh."

Saying this, Sakayanagi began to walk.

"Let's meet again sometime. Until then, please avoid an unsightly expulsion."

Sakayanagi had always been in a hostile relationship with Ryūen.

Indeed, he had always been that way with everyone.

But now, he was attacked by an indescribable sense of loss.

Having acknowledged Sakayanagi after the end-of-year special exam, something had significantly changed.

A rival—perhaps it was okay to call her that. He might have lost such an opponent.

From now on, Ryūen had to face Ayanokōji alone.

Ryūen didn't look back until Sakayanagi's presence was gone.

However, soon, a new question emerged.

"Huh?"

Naturally, he looked back, but Sakayanagi was already gone.

"...Next time, huh? You won't have a next time, will you? Are you just making excuses?"

But there was no point in thinking about someone who was leaving the school, so he threw the thought out of his mind.

Ryūen, for his part, first had to focus on the battles of the upcoming third year.

Now that Sakayanagi was gone, he had no choice but to concentrate on his fight with Ayanokōji, whether he liked it or not.

He had returned to the competitive stage with a significant increase in class points, but the current number is just decoration.

He couldn't open the path to Class A without defeating Ayanokōji.

His doubts hadn't completely disappeared, but the fog was clearing.

While slightly grateful to the merciless little goddess.

He would accept the fact that he couldn't match her now, just for this moment.

And he would change that fact within a year.

"One year. Just one year, huh? Hah... bring it on."

For Ryūen Kakeru, the most important year of his life was about to begin.

# Chapter 3:
# The Vacant Throne

SPRING BREAK HAD BEGUN, and several days had already passed.

The fervor of the end-of-year special exam was nowhere to be found now, and many students were likely enjoying their spring break regardless of year or class.

However, it was a fact that there were classes that couldn't afford to do so.

Ichinose's class, who were defeated by Horikita's class, and Sakayanagi's class, who were defeated by Ryūen's class.

The students of both classes, with only one year left, had to carefully prepare for the battles ahead during spring break, or their future prospects would be bleak.

Sakayanagi's class was facing a particularly big problem. They had just learned that their leader was going to voluntarily withdraw.

Now that it was known she was leaving the school, it was necessary to gather people to understand the situation in Class A.

Those people were Morishita and Yamamura, but—

The meeting time was set for 10 a.m.

The location was near the dormitory.

In other words, right where I was standing.

However, even after five minutes past the appointed time, then ten minutes, the people I was waiting for were still nowhere to be seen.

Since I had sent a text message just after 8 a.m. as a precaution, and it was indeed read, it was unlikely that they had forgotten.

It was unlikely that both would oversleep at the same time.

After waiting another five minutes without a sign of them, I decided to call Morishita.

The phone rang, but there was no sign of an answer.

"Maybe I should try calling Yamamura then."

I didn't want to put too much mental strain on the extremely shy Yamamura, but it couldn't be helped.

Feeling sorry, I made the call and...

*'Ah, um, sorry I'm late.'*

As soon as the call connected, that voice came through without waiting for my response.

*'Eh, hang up the phone…? But… it's past the time we agreed…'*

Yamamura sounded flustered.

Her words were choppy and hard to hear.

"Is Morishita with you by any chance?"

*‘Ye-yes. Um, please come to the back of the dorm, ah, stop messing with my phone—’*

After a bit of a troubled conversation, the call suddenly cut off.

“...What’s going on?”

I didn’t quite understand, but she mentioned something about the back of the dorm.

Fortunately, I got a hint, so I decided to head there.

It was a two to three-minute walk.

# 1

I arrived at the back of the dorm as Yamamura had mentioned.

Then, without even needing to search the area carefully, I found Yamamura looking flustered.

And for some reason, there was Morishita, crouching on the ground. During the training camp, she was touching a big tree and talking about hearing the voices of the forest—doing things that were utterly mysterious.

*But that time was a lie to tease me. So, it could be a continuation this time too, though I can't completely deny the possibility since Morishita certainly isn't an ordinary student...*

I had no choice but to talk to her directly to find out. As I approached, Yamamura appeared to make an attempt to speak to me, her mouth moving, but no sound came out.

"What are you doing here?"

When I asked, she turned around and glared at me with tremendous force.

"Shh, you're loud. Please be quiet now. I'm in the middle of observing insects."

"...You're doing what?"

I asked again in a voice quiet enough not to anger her.

"I told you, observing insects. Have you become hard of hearing in the short time we haven't met? Maybe you, Ayanokōji Kiyotaka, are—"

Right after my name was called, an utterly unrepeatable remark was thrown at me.

So, it would be better to keep the details to myself and Yamamura, who was urging me to be quiet.

"It's not that I didn't hear... I just couldn't understand..."

Yamamura silently apologized to me, bowing her head repeatedly.

She was sorry for being late—no, for not being able to meet up.

It was clearly Morishita's fault, so I gestured with my hand that it was okay.

For now, I decided to wait until Morishita finished crawling around.

She seemed unconcerned about any appointment, holding a magnifying glass in her hand.

*Going to the trouble of crawling around to observe insects...*

I thought it might've been a joke, but then I was made to wait for at least another ten minutes.

"Phew. Okay, that's it for now."

Morishita stood up, satisfied, her casual clothes completely dirty with soil.

She started to put away her magnifying glass without even trying to dust herself off.

"How long have you been doing that?"

Then Yamamura, seemingly exhausted, let out a heavy sigh without restraint.

"It's been over 30 minutes..."

*That was quite troublesome to be involved in.*

"Whether it's an hour or two hours, it's my freedom. Is that a problem?"

"If there's no appointment, it's not a problem, but if there is an appointment, isn't it a problem?"

"That's a troublesome expression. You should study Japanese more."

Somehow, I ended up being singled out as if I were the one at fault.

"I actually quite like living creatures."

"...Oh...?"

"It's rude to doubt. Last summer vacation, I bought an observation kit and was obsessed with raising shield shrimp. Yes, those were some truly intense days that I remember."

"Eh... really? That's a bit hard to believe..."

Not just me, but Yamamura seemed to feel exactly the same.

"Hard to believe? What do you mean by that, Yamamura Miki? I'd prefer if your presence was the only thing that's faint, not your belief in me too."

"Uh, well, it's not that I doubt you, but more like... surprised..."

"Once you've said something that can be taken that way by the other party, excuses are unnecessary. Alright, if that's your attitude, I'll show you the notes I've made in the past."

*To both me and Yamamura?* Displeased that she was being doubted, Morishita went on her phone.

Then, she thrust the screen in front of Yamamura's eyes.

"Take a good look."

"Th-that's too close—I can't see anything. Or rather, it's too bright...!"

"I set the screen brightness to max. It's a makeshift blinder."

Morishita's actions were unclear whether she wanted to show the screen or not.

*No, rather than being unclear now, she always takes actions that are hard to understand, so perhaps this is normal.*

Seeing Yamamura's almost tearful face, Morishita seemed to show signs of remorse and moved the screen away.

Then, she forcefully showed her notes to Yamamura again.

I wasn't completely uninterested either, so I decided to take a peek.

***Day 1***

*Had to let tap water sit for a day to dechlorinate, which was a setback.*

***Day 2***

*Added about thirty eggs.*
*The fast ones (three of them) hatched in about six hours.*
*Really small.*

***Day 3***

*Another six hatched.*
*Since their bodies are transparent, you can see the chlorella powder they eat moving through their bodies in the larger ones.*

***Day 4***

*Confirmed six total moving individuals.*
*The first three that hatched are still alive. No carcasses found.*

***Day 5***

*Now, two more hatched. Worried they might not be able to eat.*
*From the previous six → five remain.*

***Day 6***

*The two from yesterday are safe, the other five still alive.*

***Day 7***

*Yesterday's two → one, five → four.*

***Day 8***

*Five are alive but two of them are clearly more active, worried they might eat the others.*

***Day 9***

*Verified other three alive.*

***Day 10***

*Found shed skin.*
*Starting to smell like living creatures.*

***Day 11***

*The largest individual is over 1 cm.*
*Three are alive.*

***Day 12***

*Thought one was eaten when it burrowed into the sand.*

*Gave cucumber, not much interest, so I ate it.*

***Day 13***

*Gave carrot, not much interest, but I don't like it so I didn't eat it.*

*Gave rice grains, not much interest, I ate those.*

*Found about four shed skins.*

*Tried changing about a third of the water.*

***Day 14***

*Gave bread, they are really into it.*

*1.5~2 cm now, color is getting darker and they are starting to look quite creepy.*

***Day 15***

*In the morning, one was sluggish. I had a bad feeling.*

*By evening, two were dead.*

***Day 16***

*The last one wasn't moving either. It was sad.*

*As expected, the largest specimen survived the longest.*

*I think it was good that I used water from the water purifier, making sure to remove the chlorine for over half a day.*

*Maybe it was also good that I cleaned up the leftovers every day with a syringe.*

*Maybe the water change and the bread were bad.*

*Maybe it was a mistake to feed them sweet bread with cream.*

*Maybe I should have stuck to simple French bread.*

—The diary ended here.

It turned out she had been taking care of and observing them more seriously than I thought—it wasn't a lie.

In fact, it was clear that she had put more passion into it than I imagined.

However, I couldn't help but question what exactly was being shown to me in such detail here...

"How about it? Don't you two feel like trying to raise shrimps?"

"Well... I might be a bit interested, actually."

"I'll pass..."

“Then, let’s give you the breeding set, Ayanokōji Kiyotaka. I bought two last year, so I don’t mind giving one away. Of course, at the original price.”

“You’re planning to charge for it, huh?”

“Of course.”

“I appreciate the offer, but let me hold off on it. It’s a busy time for me right now.”

“Well, alright. But please give me an answer by this summer. If you don’t want it, I’ll hatch them and observe them myself.”

Despite everything, Morishita was completely unfaltered, always the same.

Normally, you’d expect her to show some cloudiness in her expression like Yamamura, but she didn’t.

“It’s a shame that Sakayanagi’s expulsion was decided just when we had become friends.”

I turned to Yamamura, who seemed despondent, and spoke to her.

“...Honestly, I still can’t quite accept it...”

At first, Sakayanagi had merely used her. However, they later came to understand each other and became friends.

Normally, they could’ve spent a year of school life as friends from here on.

This was a unique accident, typical of this school.

“You wouldn’t dream of such exchanges happening outside this school’s rules.”

I said, trying to console her, and Yamamura gently nodded.

“The class atmosphere has become incredibly heavy...”

I hadn’t actually seen it, but it wasn’t hard to imagine.

“Well, it isn’t surprising. Honestly, because of this mess, it’s fair to say that our chances of graduating from Class A have now become hopeless.”

Morishita, who had been listening silently, interjected calmly.

“Well, I wouldn’t go that far...”

“You have to admit it. Some students talk about showing Class A’s former spirit or making a comeback, but they just don’t see the situation.”

“Aren’t you going to blame the person who created this situation, Sakayanagi, for acting selfishly?”

“Indeed, it’s a bit troubling that she risked her expulsion without consulting the class. But bringing that up would only expose the fact that we were all dependent on her.”

The fact that Class A had been maintained by Sakayanagi was undeniable.

“We have no choice but to accept it.”

“What do you think your class should do now?”

I asked Yamamura first, but she shook her head, completely unable to see what the future would hold.

“I don’t know... maybe we have to give up on Class A...”

"That's right. Given the situation, the only option is to switch to accumulating private points and aim to send a few students to the official Class A by the end of the third year. If the circumstances are favorable, even students like you could be saved, Yamamura Miki."

"Students like me... Well, I can't deny it..."

She accepted it due to her low self-esteem, but it still seemed to hurt a bit.

So far, Class A maintained a high amount of class points, so everyone was likely in a relatively rich state. Moreover, although they'd lost a lot, it was still entirely possible to accumulate private points in the future. It was a very matter-of-fact judgment of the situation, but it was still one of the better options.

"But there will still be some who won't give up easily."

"That's the problem. There's the class's cheap pride from having maintained Class A up to this point too. But we can't keep dreaming forever. The class points we lost due to our defeat and Sakayanagi Arisu's voluntary withdrawal were too painful. We must understand that."

"By the way, what's the penalty for voluntary withdrawal? The other classes haven't been informed."

Sakayanagi's classmates were probably intentionally hiding that information.

It would inevitably come to light in April, but there would be no benefit in exposing it now.

"It seems to vary depending on the circumstances, but this time, we were given the heaviest penalty since Sakayanagi Arisu acted out on her own personal convenience. We lost 300 class points."

It could vary, but it was about what I'd originally anticipated.

Morishita's class had about 800 points now.

It seemed they could still barely fight, but this class had lost its leader.

They had suffered deeper wounds than just losing class points.

"The possibility that we can turn this around with the time we have left is __"

"T-The possibility is?"

"—Durururururururu—"

"Eh?"

"What's that face for?"

"No, that, what's that 'duru, ru'?"

"It's the sound of the Ai-chan computer calculating. Don't you even know that, Yamamura Miki? That's why people around you say you're gloomy, antisocial, and that your presence is more transparent than tissue paper."

"Am... am I really being talked about like that?"

"At least that's what I'd say."

*That seems to be entirely Morishita's personal opinion...*

“Anyway, please don’t interrupt. Dururururururuu—Don!”

Morishita gave a single nod, perhaps having derived the result of the calculation.

“The probability of seizing Class A on our own strength is about 10%.”

Students might be surprised by such a low probability for a class that had defended their position as Class A to the very end, until the special end-of-year exam. However, in reality, even 10% was a somewhat optimistic estimate.

That just showed how few chances Morishita and her classmates had.

“You, Yamamura Miki, the ‘thin paper,’ also mentioned it, but everyone is in a state of vigil.”

“That’s expected. It would be a big problem if they were cheerful under these circumstances.”

“U-Um. ‘Thin paper’...”

“It’s like a nickname. Isn’t it cool?”

“Eh, ehh...? It doesn’t feel like that at all...”

“Do you want me to stop?”

“If possible...”

Yamamura unexpectedly seemed to care about such things.

“But... Ichinose-san’s class has a similar amount of class points, but everyone is smiling... right? They seem positive… Our situations aren’t much different, isn’t it?”

“I see. You mean whether Ichinose Honami is present doesn’t make much difference. You really spit venom.”

Morishita nodded in admiration and gave a thumbs up to Yamamura.

Yamamura, not intending to imply such a thing, hurriedly denied it.

“So what if it’s the same situation? Because they seem positive, there’s a possibility for Class A? Let me be clear—incompetent allies are more terrifying than competent enemies. In this situation, those who still have frivolous thoughts have no tomorrow.”

Morishita’s tone was harsh, and Yamamura was taken aback, but what she said was fundamentally correct.

Someone who could make sound judgments was indispensable in the current class.

“What do we do now?”

“I thought it was unnecessary for me to intervene as long as Sakayanagi Arisu was in command, but...”

Morishita made a grim face as if deeply troubled.

“Could it be... from now on, you will lead the class, Morishita-san...?”

Imagining the words yet to come, Yamamura muttered.

“That’s impossible.”

“Impossible, huh…?”

“Unfortunately, I’m not the type to lead people at the forefront. Therefore, it’ll be troublesome, but we’ll need to select a new leader for the class during spring break. I had hoped to finish all this before Sakayanagi Arisu left school. What I can do is guide us on that front and steer the discussion towards the accumulation of private points.”

Indeed, someone needed to take on the harsh role—the role to make them give up on Class A.

It seemed she was willing to take on that spot.

At this point, Morishita gave me a nasty look.

“Let’s end the small talk here. Shall we hear the reason you called us today?”

It sounded like I’d been the one accused of rambling on, but I feel like observing insects and talking about shrimp took up most of the time...

“You’re not planning to mock our current situation, are you? The new Class A’s Ayanokōji Kiyotaka.”

“I have no intention of mocking you. I was just curious about the situation.”

“Then you might as well ask the traitor. I’m sure they’ll tell you more than you need to know.”

“U-Umm, Morishita-san, what traitor?”

“My apologies. I misspoke. Anyway, the situation is as I just explained.”

“That seems to be the case.”

Morishita might’ve been one to dance to her own tune, but she seemed properly concerned about the class.

However, Sakayanagi didn’t seem to be doing anything for her classmates who were currently lost.

Most of the conversation ended up being irrelevant. However, the minimum goal—-to gather information—was achieved, so it was good enough.

# Chapter 4:
# Getting Ahead

In the days following the conversation with Morishita and Yamamura about shrimps, I was actually quite busy. I got involved in a minor incident relating to the graduates and had to lend a hand here and there to deal with it. Fortunately, it was resolved without any issues, so the effort was worth it.

During that time, someone might've intentionally spread the news about Sakayanagi's voluntary withdrawal. It wasn't just her class, but many other students had heard about it. *I wonder how Sakayanagi currently feels*. I hadn't spoken directly to Sakayanagi recently, though we passed each other by chance on the walkway, so I didn't know her thoughts in detail. However, there was no need to rush. We both understood that now was not the time.

After 10:30, as I left the dormitory and walked towards Keyaki Mall, I saw three girls—Matsushita, Mii-chan, and Onodera—stopping to chat.

"Ah... G-Good morning, Ayanokōji-kun."

Mii-chan, who noticed me first, greeted me.

Despite my hand in expelling a close friend, she somehow still managed to smile while interacting with me.

*I have to accept it, even if only on the outside.* She must be convincing herself in such a way.

Regardless, my attitude remained unchanged regardless of how the other party behaved.

"This is a bit of an unusual combination."

"Mii-chan was about to go to Keyaki Mall, and we were meeting here. So, we thought we might as well join her."

Matsushita explained the situation with a smile, and Onodera nodded several times in agreement.

It seemed that this trio wasn't an intentional arrangement.

"Hey Ayanokōji-kun, did you know that Sakayanagi-san is withdrawing? We were just talking about that."

Acting a bit exaggerated, Matsushita sought agreement from Mii-chan and Onodera.

"Yeah, I heard about it just recently too."

"It's really surprising, isn't it? Ryūen-kun's class winning was unexpected, but to think that such a thing was happening behind the scenes..."

Onodera crossed her arms and glanced vaguely in the direction of the dormitory. It was an exam where the details were hard enough to grasp even within your own class. In such a case, information about the other classes would arrive even later. It wouldn't be surprising if more unknown information that even I didn't know emerged after this.

“Yesterday, on the way back from club activities, I saw Kitō-kun confronting Ryūen-kun in the dorm lobby. The atmosphere was intense.”

“I *had* felt that Class A and Class C were more hostile than usual, but I didn’t think it’d reach a point like this...”

“It felt like a fight could break out at any moment.”

Onodera nodded, recalling the moment with a somewhat excited and amused expression.

Meanwhile, Mii-chan sensed the possibility that it’d get violent and looked anxious.

“It feels like the school atmosphere has been bad lately. I hope nothing strange happens.”

With the class leader gone, the disappointment, or even hostility, would naturally be directed at Ryūen.

If people with a penchant for fighting encountered each other, it’d be quite possible for the worst-case scenarios to occur.

“If I come across a fight, I’m not confident I can stop it...”

“You don’t have to stop it. If it’s between guys, just let them fight it out.”

“That’s right. Actually, if that happens, it would be good news for us.”

If there were troublesome behavior, it was more likely to reach the school’s ears. The fact that it could even have some effect on class points was already established

“Besides, not only did the strongest enemy, Class A, lose in the special exam, but there’s also the bonus of Sakayanagi-san’s withdrawal. The wind is definitely blowing in our favor.”

Matsushita sensed the benefits that she could reap. She felt that everything was moving in a positive direction.

“It’s certain. By being expelled, their class might also receive a significant penalty. There’s a high chance they might even fall to Class C or D.”

A class that had maintained its position in Class A for two years would fall to the bottom.

Few students could take it calmly.

“I see. So it’s natural for them to be upset then.”

Onodera had been enjoying the conversation thus far, but soon showed a slightly conflicted expression.

“Are you not happy?”

“No, I am happy, of course. But, you know, it feels a bit like an accident, doesn’t it? If I were a student in Class A, I think I’d be incredibly stressed.”

For better or worse, the class had been following their leader’s, Sakayanagi’s, unilateral decisions.

“Maybe it would be better if everyone, regardless of gender, had a little fight to clear the air.”

She mentioned what she'd do to relieve the stress in this situation.

"Ehhh? I don't think that's good...!"

"Yeah, it's an extreme example. However, if they don't vent what they're holding in, how can they keep going?"

"I'd rather they keep falling. In terms of sheer ability, Sakayanagi-san's class is scary. Just because the leader got expelled doesn't mean their academic abilities will drop."

That was certainly true. Even if their motivation was affected, if it came to a contest of basic academic abilities, they would still come out on top among the four classes.

"You'd rather they keep falling, huh?"

"Matsushita-san, you're quite harsh, aren't you..."

"I've always been the type to look at things objectively. I have to take advantage of any benefits without hesitating. It isn't an easy task to get to Class A."

Matsushita responded with a deliberately positive attitude. You could easily tell that she wasn't aiming to emphasize her own traits, but rather, to tell Mii-chan not to worry about the details.

Just then, Mii-chan received a phone call from someone.

"Excuse me. It's from Shinohara-san."

She excused herself from us and moved away to talk. Perhaps she was the one Mii-chan was going to be meeting up with.

Watching her actions, Onodera began to speak in a volume that wouldn't disturb the phone call.

"Recently, Sudō-kun has been praising you a lot, Ayanokōji-kun. 'He's amazing,' is what he says."

"Really? Is that so?"

"At first, I only half-listened, but when I saw the impression that Horikita raised the flag to Ichinose-san, I kind of understood. Ah... of course, regarding Maezono-san, it was unfortunate... right?"

"It seems your abilities are finally being recognized, Ayanokōji-kun."

"So, Matsushita-san, you've been paying attention to him for a while?"

"I just had a feeling. Until now, he didn't want to stand out and wasn't showing his true abilities. However, this time, he took on the general's role and delivered results. It feels like he's going full throttle from here."

"Well... something like that."

"Heh, a capable hawk hides its claws? How reassuring."

Saying that, Onodera tapped my chest lightly with her fist.

"Maezono-san's expulsion was a shock, but Mii-chan understands. She's not saying anything bad about you, Ayanokōji-kun, so don't worry."

"It's okay. I'm prepared for it even if she blames me."

“That’s not good. It’s not just your responsibility.”

“We’re here to help too, so just let us know.”

After a while, the three of us concluded our conversation. Then, I informed the group that I had an appointment and headed to Keyaki Mall ahead of them.

# 1

The current time was 12:17 PM.

By the time I arrived at the café for my appointment, Hoshinomiya-sensei was already seated.

She was my meeting partner today, playing with her phone in boredom.

“I’m sorry for being late.”

“You’re really late, Ayanokōji-kun. It’s too impudent of you to be 17 minutes late when you’re meeting with me.”

“I’m sorry.”

Despite my apology, Hoshinomiya-sensei opened her mouth with a look of dissatisfaction, or rather, astonishment.

“Eh, that’s it? You could at least tell me why you were late.”

“I overslept. When I woke up, it was almost noon.”

I gave a vague reason, and she pressed her forehead with her fingertips, furrowing her brows.

“...If this were a date, it would 100% fail here—a complete failure.”

She sighed at the ridiculous reason and pursed her lips even more discontentedly.

“Well, scolding you won’t bring back the time; it just wastes it. So? You said you wanted to meet me. What’s your intention?”

“What if I said I wanted a date?”

“Stop it. I don’t feel like I can get along with someone who oversleeps on the first date.”

While thinking that this didn’t seem like a conversation a teacher would have with a student, I continued.

“I wanted to discuss the end-of-year special exam with you again, Hoshinomiya-sensei.”

Until now, she seemed angry about my morals. However, her attitude shifted significantly upon hearing this remark.

“Huh? At this point?”

*You’ve got to be kidding me*—she didn’t even try to hide such an expression.

“Indeed, it might be too late. Horikita’s class has already won.”

Being late to the meeting and provoking her, it was natural for Hoshinomiya-sensei to be displeased.

“That’s quite a distant way to put it. That class is pretty much like your class, isn’t it?”

While pointing out my subtle words, Hoshinomiya-sensei picked up a paper napkin and wiped the water droplets off the cup that was on the table.

“I was watching the match with Ichinose-san. It’s amazing how you can do something like that to a girl who likes you.”

“It was necessary to win.”

“So anything is fine as long as it leads to victory? Even using the feelings of girls you like would be fine with you?”

“I don’t see what the problem is.”

As I said that, Hoshinomiya-sensei covered her face with her hands and let out a heavy sigh.

“That’s the worst.”

However, I pointed out her hypocritical attitude.

“You’re the same type as me, aren’t you, Sensei?”

“...Quite a rude thing to say.”

“Then deny it.”

Pressing further, Hoshinomiya-sensei stopped moving for a few seconds and fell silent.

Then, removing her hands, she glared at me. However, she eventually nodded as if she was admitting to it.

If it was for victory, she wouldn’t hesitate to use someone else’s romantic feelings.

Regardless of whether she could come up with such a plan or not, it was a strategy she could carry out if she so wished.

“Anyway. You mentally cornered Ichinose-san in the exam, and as a result, our class is a mess both inside and out. Do you understand the situation here? In the first place, I don’t feel like having this sort of talk at length here, okay?”

It was noisy inside Keyaki Mall, but if a student and a teacher were alone together, they would stand out.

Indeed, a few students who were concerned about us had started to appear.

“Then, what kind of conversation did you think I would have?”

“Eh?”

“You didn’t refuse, agreeing when you heard I wanted to talk, Hoshinomiya-sensei. At least, you didn’t think it was a date, did you?”

“I was thinking something like… talking about a student’s worries?”

“Maybe for a homeroom teacher, but not something to bring to a teacher of another class.”

“You don’t know that. If it’s about love, it’s impossible with Sae-chan, right? I didn’t think deeply about what it would concern to begin with. I just thought I’d listen.”

“Is that so?”

Hoshinomiya-sensei and I stared at each other—no, we continued to probe each other’s intentions with our gazes.

“You must’ve anticipated that the conversation would be about the exam. And you considered the possibility that it could be beneficial information for you, which is why you came all the way here.”

“...That is...”

She had deliberately been hostile to avoid her true thoughts being seen through.

Considering her position as a teacher, she had to outwardly maintain a position of denial.

“Let’s both make an effort to move this conversation forward, shall we?”

“Even if you say move forward—”

“You asked me for a certain cooperation before the special exam, didn’t you?”

I said this to the wary Hoshinomiya-sensei.

“...What are you talking about?”

She was still on guard and wasn’t ready to admit it openly.

“I had refused at that time, but I thought there might be room for consideration in the future depending on the conditions.”

However, my infuriating statement would surely provoke her anger.

“Ha? It’s too late now. The special exam is already over and the results are significantly different. And now you want to cooperate? No, no, it’s too late. Are you stupid?”

She probably wanted to say that if I were to cooperate, I should’ve joined hands from the beginning.

“I understand your feelings, but it was right before the special exam, a major event for students. Anyone would be disturbed and confused by such an unexpected proposal, and they wouldn’t be able to make a sound judgment. Moreover, I can’t imagine being instructed by a teacher to betray my class, right?”

“That is...”

She couldn’t argue against the undeniable logic.

“However, I don’t think that what you were aiming for was bad. Now that the exam is over and I’ve calmed down, I thought it might be okay to discuss it again.”

Hoshinomiya-sensei surely wouldn’t be pleased to hear this.

Just as I’d told her that I had calmed down, Hoshinomiya-sensei got her composure back here as well.

It was as unreasonable for a teacher to assist a student in breaking the rules as it was for a student to assist a teacher in doing the same.

“No. Even so, it’s too suspicious. What I proposed to you was for you to lose to me, Ayanokōji-kun. In other words, it meant betraying your class. And

now, you say it's okay to let me win in future special exams? That's too nonsensical."

"You knew that premise when you asked me, right? It's the same thing. If there's a suitable return, it's a different story."

"...Huh? Are you serious? You want to sleep with me so you'll betray your class?"

Hoshinomiya-sensei, with a look of disdain that didn't make it seem like she was the one who had originally proposed it, was astonished.

"Unfortunately, I'm not interested in that. But I might consider other conditions."

"...What other conditions?"

"The most important thing in this school is private points, above all else. If you can arrange something using your authority as a teacher, I might consider it."

"...Are you serious?"

"I didn't originally intend to graduate from Class A. If I can get private points that improve my school life or benefit me after graduation, it wouldn't be bad."

"I know you're not very concerned about Class A, but sorry, I can't believe it. This kind of consultation is too suspicious. After all, what can you even do, Ayanokōji-kun? The final showdown is already over."

"Even if I become a third-year, special exams will continue. If it comes to fighting Horikita's class, it wouldn't be impossible to pass on inside information. That alone could give you an advantage."

"Even so, what you alone can do is limited. Even if your class falls, Sakagami-sensei's class will become the next obstacle. And there's no hope for my class to rise. It's like pouring water on a hot stone."

*(TL Note: Commonly found in traditional hot springs, the phrase refers to when water is poured on hot stones, the water will evaporate/turn to steam, making it pointless to try and cool a hot stone with water. So this just means something bound to fail, or a wasted effort.)*

A sigh of disappointment and a sense of dissatisfaction that never ends.

"I gave you the chance before the end-of-year special exam. That time was the first and last. Understand?"

"Seems like there's no room for negotiation. But then, your class won't be able to rise to Class A."

"That's none of your business. We'll manage somehow on our own."

"How will you manage? Can you rebuild Ichinose's class in time to turn things around?"

"There are ways to rise to Class A without doing that. I won't tell you though."

“So you’ll use any means necessary, using the authority of a teacher to advance your class.”

She directed at me the sharpest and strongest gaze today so far.

“I will absolutely make it to Class A. By any means necessary.”

*Are we done?* She expressed the question as she drank the remaining third of her drink in one gulp.

“Please wait.”

“I have no intention of spending any more of my precious time off with a boring child.”

“That’s fine, but I don’t think the people behind you feel the same.”

“Behind?”

Reluctantly, Hoshinomiya-sensei turned around with a puzzled look and stopped when she saw three people approaching.

“What’s going on…? Why are Sae-chan and the others here?”

The three approaching were Chabashira-sensei, Mashima-sensei, and Sakagami-sensei.

The homeroom teachers of each class for the second-year students.

# 2

This morning, I talked with Mii-chan and the others just after 10:30.

Later, I met with Hoshinomiya-sensei at a cafe just after 12:00. There was a time gap that occurred there.

Actually, last night, while I contacted Hoshinomiya-sensei, I also approached Chabashira-sensei, my homeroom teacher, saying I had a consultation and wanted to meet her at Keyaki Mall at 11:00 today. Initially, Chabashira-sensei's stance was to listen to what I had to say at school, but after insisting on how Keyaki Mall was necessary, she reluctantly agreed. It was understandable to be reluctant about meeting a student at Keyaki Mall, but I was confident she wouldn't refuse me. The consultation might've involved issues like Maezono's expulsion or conflicts with classmates. It wasn't hard to imagine her concern over my mental state.

I changed into casual clothes, left the dorm early to have plenty of time, and headed to Keyaki Mall.

However, I ran into Mii-chan and the others on the way and ended up arriving at 10:50.

"You're quite early."

Chabashira-sensei spotted me from a distance. Perhaps thinking that it wasn't appropriate for a teacher to keep a student waiting, she'd arrived earlier than expected.

"I'm sorry to keep you waiting."

As I approached and called out, Chabashira-sensei checked the time.

"You haven't really kept me waiting. There's still some time before our appointment; no need to worry."

After responding, she looked around somewhat awkwardly.

Since we'd chosen a deserted place to meet, it was unlikely to see other students around, but she couldn't help but be concerned.

"I never thought I'd be meeting a student at Keyaki Mall."

She lightly scratched her cheek with her fingertip, revealing her unease.

"Has this never happened before?"

"Of course not."

A teacher meeting with a student on a day off—I don't know about normal schools, but I think that at this school, it didn't seem particularly unusual.

"Ah, I see. Sensei, in the past, you deliberately kept a distance from students—"

Chabashira-sensei narrowed her eyes sharply at me.

"Ayanokōji. You speak too lightly."

"I apologize."

“An apology is not enough, isn’t it?”

*If you expect to apologize, then you shouldn’t say it.* As an adult, she corrected my casual tone.

“...Was there really a need to meet at Keyaki Mall?”

If this was a matter that required a consultation, surely there would be a more suitable place.

“I understand your sentiment, but I judged that meeting here was the best option.”

“I’d like to know the reason for that decision.”

“I understand. However, it seems that two more people have yet to arrive; could you wait?”

“Two more people?”

Since she hadn’t been informed, Chabashira-sensei was surprised to hear that there were others involved in the meeting.

It was no wonder. I’d deliberately kept it a secret.

“I believe this issue is too difficult to resolve one-on-one.”

Her expression grew even sterner as she responded.

“Horikita... and Hirata too? Is the situation much worse than I imagined?”

She had guessed that it was about a classmate and asked quietly.

There was no longer any need to allude to the Maezono issue. Perhaps it was better to reassure her a bit.

“Unfortunately, no. It has nothing to do with Maezono or the class.”

“Is that so? I thought you were being put on the spot because of that incident...”

“Fortunately, in the discussion after the exam, most students agreed that what was done was necessary to win.”

For now, none of the students were confronting me privately.

“...Then that’s good.”

Chabashira-sensei sighed, truly relieved.

“Since they aren’t here yet, I’m ready to answer any questions you may have for me.”

“Questions from me?”

“Of course. You were watching the end-of-year special exam, weren’t you?”

When I asked the question as a way to pass the time, her relaxed expression turned a bit sterner.

“How students fight within the rules is up to them. I’m pleased that the class won and how it’s likely to move up to Class A.”

“Even if it means a student gets expelled in the process?”

"...It's certainly not pleasant, but as a teacher, getting too involved in student or class issues often leads to trouble. I've learned the hard way from trying to use you before. I'd rather not repeat that."

It was probably about the uninhabited island exam from our first year.

Chabashira-sensei implied that my father's influence was at play, scheming to bring victory to the class.

Of course, she hadn't deviated from the rules of the exam, but it wouldn't have been surprising if it was considered morally out of bounds.

"Come to think of it, that did happen."

Despite the resentful look she gave me, Chabashira-sensei's expression turned into a wry smile as she sighed.

"Well, I'm not sure if I should call it a blessing in disguise, but thanks to that, I was able to wake myself up too... It's because you're a student who doesn't show any mercy, even when going up against teachers, that I was able to do so."

With that in mind, indeed—I would be going up against teachers in today's gathering in a sense.

"I'm not good at considering others' intentions. It looks like one person has arrived."

Chabashira-sensei turned her head to follow the person walking towards us.

"Hmm…? Sakagami-sensei...?"

Instead of a student, it was Sakagami-sensei in plain clothes approaching us.

Almost simultaneously, Mashima-sensei also appeared around the corner.

The male teachers arrived almost at the appointed time.

Excluding me, a student, three class teachers had gathered at this location.

"What's this all about, Ayanokōji? Wasn't I the only one you called?"

Mashima-sensei was the first to voice his doubt.

His words made everyone realize that they'd all thought it was going to be a one-on-one discussion.

"I don't appreciate you calling teachers under false pretenses. It's a problem."

Seeing the situation, Mashima-sensei admonished me with a stern expression.

"Mashima-sensei, I haven't been informed of the details by Ayanokōji either, but perhaps it isn't too late now to hear what he has to say—"

"No, that won't do. There must be an appropriate distance between teachers and students. Above all, there must be no lies between us to maintain trust."

"Well, that's... true, but..."

Chabashira-sensei tried to intervene, but Mashima-sensei ignored her and began to preach.

“Listen, Ayanokōji. As a student of this school—”

“I’ve gathered the information on Akiyama-san properly.”

“I’ll overlook it this time, but be careful next time.”

Mashima-sensei turned around abruptly, interrupting his lecture and forgiving me kindly.

“Mashima-sensei? Is that alright?”

Sakagami-sensei, watching the lecture, couldn’t help but intervene when Mashima-sensei suddenly turned on his heel.

“I thought it would be a waste of the teacher’s time to continue lecturing here.”

“I see. But who is Akiyama-san? I don’t recall such a student.”

“Don’t worry about it. Listen, Ayanokōji, I have something to discuss with you later. Got it?”

I nodded, and Mashima-sensei nodded back deeply.

Akiyama was the name of a female staff member at the Keyaki Mall gym where Mashima-sensei and I went.

And currently, she seemed to be the member of the opposite sex that Mashima-sensei was most interested in.

Her relationship status and preferred type, as well as her hobbies and likes, were things I had promised to find out for him. It was honestly a hassle, but it was good that I’d finished gathering the information.

“What’s going on here? Explain so we can understand.”

“Of course. The reason I didn’t announce the gathering beforehand was to prevent it from leaking out. Actually, today, I gathered you here for a specific purpose.”

My phrasing, which seemed to hint at something, led Sakagami-sensei to fold his arms in interest.

“Please let us hear it.”

Believing that it was best to proceed with the discussion smoothly, he urged me on.

“During the end-of-year special exam the other day, Hoshinomiya-sensei approached me right before the exam. The rules were explained to the representatives, and after we finished forming the groups, I left the classroom to go to the restroom.”

I explained the specific situation, which should help the three present recall the memory.

“...Chie, no, Hoshinomiya-sensei?”

Chabashira-sensei corrected herself, using her last name in front of Mashima-sensei and Sakagami-sensei.

“Indeed. She also left her seat saying she needed to use the restroom. Was it then?”

Sakagami-sensei clearly remembered that moment and responded without hesitation.

"In fact, I think Hoshinomiya-sensei didn't need to use the restroom. After talking to me, she went straight back to the waiting room."

"So it was just an excuse to talk with you, Ayanokōji-kun?"

"That's right."

"But there's no rule that prevents teachers and students from talking."

"I didn't determine her approach as the problem, but the content of the conversation."

Here, I reported my conversation with Hoshinomiya-sensei accurately, without covering anything up.

I conveyed the truth. Mixing lies, misunderstandings, or misconceptions would do me no good.

I was asked to concede victory.

She told me that Chabashira-sensei was the one person she couldn't lose to.

In return, she said that she'd do anything she could, and even suggested that she might provide information about special exams early or even pay using her own body.

By the time I'd finished giving all the details, Chabashira-sensei was clutching her head with a pained expression, and Mashima-sensei sighed heavily without trying to hide his deep disappointment.

"This is a serious problem if it's true..."

"Mashima-sensei, if we leave Chie unchecked, her deviating behavior as a teacher might escalate."

Chabashira-sensei understood that the situation was becoming serious.

Mashima-sensei also had to make a decision accordingly.

"It's a very troublesome matter, but it can't be helped. We absolutely cannot allow unfair interference."

Although his face looked grim, he nodded with determination

"We can still de-escalate the situation now."

"What do you intend to do?"

"If Hoshinomiya-sensei corrects herself, we can keep this matter among ourselves. Ayanokōji has clearly refused any collaboration, so the issue hasn't surfaced."

Whether as old schoolmates or simply because they both were in charge of the second-year students, it wasn't clear, but Mashima-sensei expressed a desire not to escalate the issue.

Chabashira-sensei likely agreed, showing no sign of objection.

However, Sakagami-sensei, who seemed to have no personal connection, wouldn't show any favoritism.

His class was currently in an excellent position to aim for Class A.

“Both of you are being quite lenient, even if it was an attempted issue. If it’s true, it should be reported.”

“That is… however—!”

Chabashira-sensei reacted quickly, but Sakagami-sensei calmly subdued her.

“Don’t jump to conclusions. I’m not saying we need to report this to the school immediately.”

For the two former classmates, Sakagami-sensei would likely be the most troublesome presence here.

Sakagami-sensei continued to speak calmly.

“Wanting to make your class win by any means necessary is unavoidable, given this school’s system. This isn’t something limited to just the students. Even adults sometimes resort to dirty tactics. I myself have taken somewhat biased actions before, thinking it was for my class’s sake.”

It was unclear if he was referring to the incident involving Sudō in the student council during our first year or to something else.

“Whether we report it or settle it among ourselves, we need to be cautious about the situation’s credibility. We don’t know if what Ayanokōji-kun is saying is true. It’s only his testimony so far.”

“Don’t tell me you intend to doubt a student?”

“I’m not saying that, but we still need solid evidence. If it turns out Hoshinomiya-sensei was falsely accused of misconduct, she would be outraged. Then, the people who doubted her, us, would be the ones in trouble. We can’t predict what kind of punishment would be imposed.”

“That is—”

Sakagami-sensei was skeptical, but it was necessary.

The reason I didn’t discuss this with just Hoshinomiya-sensei’s old schoolmates, Mashima-sensei and Chabashira-sensei, was because I judged that it was essential to include the presence of a teacher who could view the situation impartially.

“We can’t say there’s zero possibility that Hoshinomiya-sensei and Ayanokōji-kun have already conspired together, trying to set a trap for us. Isn’t that right, Ayanokōji-kun?”

“I think that’s right. Naturally, you can’t just trust my words alone. Since personal feelings would come into play, my homeroom teacher, Chabashira-sensei, would want to cover for me no matter what. Even if she harbored some doubts about my story in her head, it’s entirely possible that she wouldn’t seek to gather proper evidence.”

Sakagami-sensei touched the frame of his glasses after observing my anticipated reaction.

“Given the way you’re speaking, you have a good idea, don’t you?”

“Yes. I’ve arranged to meet Hoshinomiya-sensei at a cafe at noon. I haven’t told her the reason, but she agreed to come—probably because she has her suspicions. So, I’ll first prove that what I’ve said is true there.”

After saying that, I took out my mobile phone.

“Before I meet Hoshinomiya-sensei at the cafe, I’ll call Chabashira-sensei. Then, listen to my conversation with Hoshinomiya-sensei in real-time, and if you get conclusive evidence, please help.”

“Eavesdropping on the conversation? I can’t say I agree with your approach.”

Mashima-sensei expressed his dissatisfaction with that point, but Sakagami-sensei seemed pleased and calmed him.

“No, that’s the best approach. I think this is the most suitable method to verify whether she’ll reveal the truth from her own mouth. Chabashira-sensei, that’s fine with you, right?”

“...Well... yes.”

Chabashira-sensei seemed more perplexed by the possibility of Hoshinomiya-sensei’s misconduct coming to light than reluctant.

“While I can’t go so far as to tell you to rest assured, if we do catch Hoshinomiya-sensei attempting misconduct, and she decides to stop, I have no intention of escalating the matter.”

“Will you really do that, Sakagami-sensei?”

“Yes. If I play the villain in front of both of you here, it would leave me with concerns for next year. If my class ends up taking fire concentrated from all three classes and loses, it would be my responsibility.”

As the homeroom teacher, he explained that he didn’t want to hinder Ryūen’s class.

Once the plan was settled, I decided to take action from there.

“Can you teachers wait here for a while? Once I meet up with Hoshinomiya-sensei, I’ll connect the call, so please listen. It’s fine to come and make contact once you have conclusive evidence.”

After conveying that, I decided to wait alone near the cafe at Keyaki Mall.

# 3

That was the incident that occurred before meeting with Hoshinomiya-sensei at the cafe.

It was inevitable, not coincidental, that three teachers appeared at this location.

If three homeroom teachers gathered around Hoshinomiya-sensei, attention would inevitably increase.

Initially surprised, Hoshinomiya-sensei responded with a smile.

When told that there was something they needed to discuss, she showed willingness to comply.

However, it was difficult to have a detailed discussion there, so we decided to change locations.

Indeed—when four adults gathered, it stood out, especially with a student involved. Still, we chose to meet at the conspicuous Keyaki Mall to avoid it appearing like Hoshinomiya-sensei was being lured to a secluded place.

In public, there was only so much one could scheme.

On the other hand, holding a private meeting in a secluded location allowed the other party to lay their groundwork without hesitation.

It was also suggested that we could move to the school, but given the nature of the discussion, it would be problematic if other teachers overheard. Therefore, it was safest to discuss this further in the teachers' dormitory. Specifically, in Mashima-sensei's room.

While moving, Hoshinomiya-sensei gave me a look that said, *You've done it now*, but I feigned ignorance and followed. The room seemed a bit larger than the students', over 40 square meters, but otherwise, there was nothing particularly novel about it.

"So? What's this about? Why has it come to this?"

"You know what this is about, Chie."

"I wouldn't be asking if I knew, would I?"

Most likely, she knew the topic of the conversation. However, she wouldn't change her assertive stance until she had concrete confirmation. Chabashira-sensei sent a look to Mashima-sensei and the others, firming up her resolve to delve deeper.

"Using students... No, teachers deviating from the rules to win an exam is not something to overlook."

"Huh? What are you talking about? I don't understand what you mean at all __"

"Sorry, but we were listening to your conversation with Ayanokōji. Any poor excuse will only backfire, Hoshinomiya."

Mashima-sensei continued to press, but Hoshinomiya-sensei still seemed unconcerned.

"Does that mean you were connected to a phone call at the cafe or something??"

"That's right."

"Hmm. But I don't remember having any bad conversations. If you have evidence, let me hear it."

"I didn't record it. But the three of us actually heard it."

"That's not evidence. Aren't the three of you just trying to set me up??"

Far from fearing being the one accused, her tone was as if she was accusing us instead.

"You're quite stubborn, aren't you? We wouldn't mind going ahead and reporting this to the higher-ups, you know."

Unlike Mashima-sensei and Chabashira-sensei, who might relent, Sakagami-sensei's words couldn't be taken lightly.

Such naive thoughts were probably seen through immediately.

"Even if I asked Ayanokōji-kun for help, is that a problem? Isn't it a bit too far to call it misconduct just because of that."

Unfazed, she rebutted Sakagami-sensei. It might've felt like desperation, but it wasn't. She was observing the situation well. She knew the threat to report her was a bluff since Mashima-sensei and Chabashira-sensei wouldn't panic; it truly showed her insight.

"I think it's a significant problem."

"Then report it. If I'm to be punished, I'll gladly accept it."

Hoshinomiya-sensei retorted strongly against Sakagami-sensei.

Indeed, whether this report would result in her being demoted from homeroom teacher was a fine line.

Judging that this would lead to nowhere, the teachers decided to delve deeper.

"It's not just about using Ayanokōji for misconduct. We can't just watch as you continue to engage in it, Chie."

"Oh come on, Sae-chan. I wouldn't do anything improper, you know. I don't know what you overheard in my conversation with Ayanokōji-kun, but that's a misunderstanding. It was just a little threat."

She blatantly denied any wrongdoing.

"I see, so that's your approach. Indeed, if you behave from now on, Hoshinomiya-sensei, maybe there's no need to raise this as an issue."

"Right? You're making too much of it. Well, Ayanokōji-kun is just a kid, right? Maybe he took my joke seriously. Even during the exam, I never seriously intended to have him turn traitor; I just wanted to shock him a bit. As a teacher to a class that seemed likely to lose, I just wanted to help them win."

It was clear she intended to escape by any means necessary.

However, even if the three teachers backed down now, you could say that we achieved a certain effect.

Now that her scheme was known, she couldn't make any careless moves going forward. If they wanted to, considering that this was enough to serve as a deterrent, the teachers were free to withdraw here. My goal was to prevent Hoshinomiya-sensei from being ousted. It wasn't about allowing or preventing misconduct. Having her removed as a homeroom teacher due to foolish actions would adversely affect Ichinose's class. Avoiding that would be ideal.

"You won't do anything foolish. Can you promise that?"

"Isn't it obvious, Sae-chan? Teachers don't take part in battles between students."

"I'm not joking. I'm seriously worried."

Chabashira-sensei closed the distance and pressed down on both of Hoshinomiya-sensei's shoulders, who refused to take the matter seriously. As a former classmate and as a fellow teacher, she strongly appealed to her.

Witnessing the actions born out of concern for an old schoolmate, Hoshinomiya-sensei's expression stiffened for the first time.

Until now, she had only shown a dismissive smile in front of the teachers.

"...What's this? I feel like throwing up, so please stop."

Her voice turned cold, and she gripped Chabashira-sensei's forearm tightly with her own hand.

"Chie...?"

"Are you seriously worried? You don't need to worry. If you're going to worry, I wish you wouldn't aim for that unsuitable Class A spot."

"That is—"

"There's no way I can watch your class graduate from Class A, Sae-chan."

Chabashira-sensei's words seemed to irritate Hoshinomiya-sensei, prompting a candid response.

However, the surrounding three showed no particular surprise.

Rather, they seemed to think, *So that's the reason. That makes sense*.

"I've never forgiven you, Sae-chan. Class A being your goal is something I absolutely won't accept.."

"...It can't be helped that you hate me. But now we aren't students—we're teachers. Is it wrong to aim for Class A for the sake of the students?"

"Of course it's wrong."

Hoshinomiya-sensei said it was wrong even if it was all for the students.

Then, she forcefully brushed off Chabashira-sensei's arms that were gripping her shoulders.

Seeing that determination and will, Sakagami-sensei crossed his arms with interest.

"I know that you two, and actually Mashima-sensei as well, are former students at this school from the same year. I'm aware there were some disputes within the class at the time, although minor. However, as Chabashira-sensei says, that's a story from when you were students. Even if Chabashira-sensei manages to graduate her class from Class A as the homeroom teacher, at most, it will affect her salary and evaluation. Are you bothered by the differences that these evaluations will create?"

"No, it's not that. Certainly, pushing students to Class A affects our evaluations and that's important, but what's most important to me is—"

She hesitated slightly before continuing.

"Sae-chan might selfishly settle her past. That's what I can't stand."

The main reason she was trying to do something, even if it meant going against the school and the students.

"So, it really is just a personal grudge then"

In their student days, Hoshinomiya's class had their dreams cut short due to Chabashira-sensei's actions in a unanimous vote special exam, where she couldn't sacrifice her classmates for the class. That past couldn't be changed. However, that was why the grudge didn't fade, merely growing stronger every day.

At least, she wanted Chabashira-sensei to always regret that. That was why she couldn't accept her graduating from Class A in any form.

Even if Chabashira-sensei said she wouldn't forget the past, Hoshinomiya-sensei wouldn't be satisfied.

Because it wasn't just Chabashira-sensei's problem.

Hoshinomiya-sensei was also trapped by the past. She wanted to continue making Chabashira-sensei feel guilty by preventing her students from reaching Class A. If Chabashira-sensei managed to achieve graduation from Class A, Hoshinomiya-sensei would then lose her only way of coping with the past.

"To think to that extent, you… No, I suppose it's natural… I can't make any excuses."

"That's right, you can't defend yourself. You understand, right? I'm the worst kind of woman. But it's okay, I'm used to being called that. I've lived like this since the beginning, and I'm thoroughly hated by those who dislike me. You know that well, don't you, Sae-chan? We've been together since the first year of high school."

Resigning oneself—that was a strong way to live in its own right.

Because she was confident she could live that way, she was able to boldly express her grievances and bitterness.

"If you want me to stop, give up your dream of reaching Class A."

"There's no way I can do that. Teachers holding back their students' progress—"

“You can. After all, you were like that in the past. You were a cold homeroom teacher and disliked by your students. Even if that’s all you do now, it might help me.”

Indeed, the Chabashira-sensei at the time of enrollment and the current Chabashira-sensei were completely different. It was clear that the personality she had when we met was a false one, unable to express her true feelings due to the sins of her past.

Whether a teacher properly faced their class was an important factor for developing students.

*In the future, as the competition for Class A intensifies, it might determine the outcome.*

“I...”

“Don’t hesitate. Promise me you’ll be cold like before, right now. If you can’t do that, then never interfere again.”

“But if we don’t interfere, we will report any violations we notice to the higher-ups. You might be expelled from your position as a homeroom teacher, you know?”

Sakagami-sensei’s words, indicating that they wouldn’t overlook it, didn’t seem to deter Hoshinomiya-sensei.

“That’s fine. Of course, I won’t commit any violations. But I will struggle to the end in my own way, and if any misconduct ends up being discovered, I will accept being fired.”

This wasn’t a threat. Likely, it was just her true feelings.

I could imagine several reasons.

First of all, Hoshinomiya-sensei didn’t think it was necessary to stick to being a teacher.

She continued to teach simply because she wanted to interfere with Chabashira-sensei, and she didn’t mind being dismissed if she could accomplish that. It meant she could tolerate the risk.

“I see. You seem to be truly resolved, but... I don’t understand. Now that we know your circumstances, any straightforward misconduct will be immediately seen through. In other words, even if you act recklessly, it is very unlikely to benefit the class you’re in charge of. Moreover, if it becomes known that the homeroom teacher committed misconduct, it will undoubtedly disturb the studen—! I see...”

While voicing his doubts, Sakagami-sensei also came to understand Hoshinomiya-sensei’s stance.

Ideally, she’d help the class through improper practices without being detected, but if that wasn’t possible, she was prepared to go out with a bang. If she got involved in misconduct and was removed as the class’s homeroom

teacher, the chances for Ichinose class to rise would disappear, but at the same time, Chabashira-sensei would be burdened with a new, intense sense of guilt.

That might adversely affect Horikita's class.

In fact, just having this conversation was already putting a significant mental strain on Chabashira-sensei.

"Chie..."

"I will never accept you."

It seemed that Hoshinomiya-sensei's determination was stronger than we'd thought.

It'd be impossible to shake that resolve or make her reconsider with half-hearted measures.

"Chabashira-sensei, why don't we give Hoshinomiya-sensei a little more time?"

Mashima-sensei, who'd been mostly listening without interrupting, suggested this.

He emphasized that he was thinking as a homeroom teacher in charge of a class, not just as a schoolmate, by using polite language.

"...Give her time...?"

"Yes. Whether Hoshinomiya-sensei makes her decision now or you change your way of thinking, there's no need to draw a conclusion here. Of course, it would be best if we could resolve it, but given the current situation, it seems difficult. However, fortunately, it's spring break now. There's enough time to organize thoughts and calm down. A third option might emerge during this time."

Even if it was futile, postponing the matter until the new term started wasn't a bad decision.

*Rather, forcing the issue and putting ourselves in a situation where we couldn't back down would really leave us with no way out.* That was his thought.

"Although it might be rude for a student to give an opinion, I agree with Mashima-sensei."

*We managed to create three teachers who can foresee whether Hoshinomiya-sensei starts to act recklessly.*

For today, that should be enough.

"Even if you hold off, I won't change my mind."

"It's okay to decide that you won't change your mind, but please hold off publicly. That should be beneficial from anyone's perspective. Isn't that right?"

For the two parties involved, as well as Mashima-sensei, and certainly for the students who would be greatly affected, holding off was welcomed.

"Well, if that's all..."

"Then our discussion is over. Let's disperse here."

Sakagami-sensei took the lead and headed for the entrance.

With the meeting adjourned, we left the room.

Mashima-sensei probably wanted to know about Akiyama-san, but given the atmosphere, it was hard to bring it up. I decided to tell him another day.

Sakagami-sensei quickly parted ways with Mashima-sensei since they were on the same floor, and I got into the elevator. I pressed the button for the first floor, and Chabashira-sensei followed.

"I'm sorry I couldn't be of more help, even though you confided in me."

"That's not true. You were a great help."

"I couldn't solve it immediately, but I deeply appreciate that you had the courage to tell me."

Chabashira-sensei forced a smile, but it was clear she was physically and mentally exhausted.

"I believe this discussion has shown us a way forward."

"...A way forward?"

She looked incredulous, unable to understand.

"I don't think you'll do something that would disqualify her as a teacher out of consideration for Hoshinomiya-sensei, but please keep your heart strong. It's important to start the new term as the teacher who had overcome the past with the unanimous vote special exam."

"That is… Ah, yes, but—"

The elevator arrived at the first floor, and the doors opened.

As I stepped out, I turned back to Chabashira-sensei, who remained inside.

"Don't worry. I will change Hoshinomiya-sensei's mind by the end of spring break."

As I stepped forward to say this, Chabashira-sensei hurried to exit, so I stopped her.

"You will change...? What are you talking about—"

From a teacher's perspective, I was just caught up in a feud.

She probably thought this wasn't something a mere student could handle.

But the reality was different.

Hoshinomiya-sensei's problem was indeed simple, and its resolution was straightforward.

Even without involving Chabashira-sensei, Mashima-sensei, or Sakagami-sensei, it was possible to resolve it.

However, since that would've been insufficient, I deliberately went through this process.

"By the end of spring break, definitely. Well then, I'll take my leave for today."

The door closed.

"You are—! Who are you really..."

The lingering image of a perplexed Chabashira-sensei remained in my head for a while after the door had closed.

# Chapter 5:
# Illusion

March 30th, a very important day, had arrived.

It was also the day of my promised date with Kei. We'd go watch the movie she wanted to see.

I checked the read/unread status of someone specific on my mobile, then I opened Kei's message.

After, I scrolled back to a previous exchange.

*['I managed to reserve the seats you wanted on March 30th. Is around 10 AM okay?']*

That was the message I'd sent.

*['Of course! I'm super looking forward to it!']*

An innocent message from Kei, who knew nothing about what I had been up to, still remained. The movie itself had been released a bit earlier, on the 26th, but due to the end-of-year special exam, the matter with Hoshinomiya-sensei, and personal thoughts, I had postponed it a bit.

The TV, which had been on since early morning, ended its long morning news program, and some character was playing rock-paper-scissors on the screen.

I casually glanced at it, and soon after, a commercial for the movie we were going to watch started playing. That was the third time today. The effort put into this film was somewhat apparent.

The seats Kei wanted were in the fifth row from the front—two seats right in the middle.

Too close or too far wouldn't be comfortable; she liked watching movies in the middle of the theater.

It would've been simple if we had headed from the dorm together, but Kei, wanting to enjoy our date's atmosphere in detail, had specifically requested to meet in front of the cinema. Perhaps this was what you'd call a maiden's heart?

Typically, this would be a day that'd bring a little bit of extra happiness for a couple.

Today, after watching the movie, I would bid farewell to Kei.

This had been planned since I started dating Karuizawa Kei a year ago.

The severe bullying she'd endured during middle school had cast a large shadow over her life.

Unlike adults, students must survive in the small world of school.

Strictly speaking, one could always run away, but not everyone could make that choice. Many had to face loneliness, despair, and continue fighting.

Kei, who had an arduous past, changed her way of living upon entering high school.

She honed her survival instincts, thinking about how to avoid repeating the same mistakes.

She parasitized herself onto a strong individual to appear bigger and stronger to survive.

She chose to parasitize Hirata Yōsuke, who quickly became revered in the class hierarchy.

For a parasite, a host's existence was crucial.

No matter how strong a potential host would be, if they didn't allow the parasite to latch onto them, they'd be removed from the selection.

It was coincidental that Yōsuke had a compulsive personality that felt obliged to save people, but for Kei, he was the best partner.

However, Kei faced another trial when Manabe, Yabu, Yamashita, and Morofuji, all from Ryūen's class, learned of her past experiences of being bullied.

If left alone, Kei was likely to fall back into the darkness, but I reached out and successfully saved her. Despite the risks, she managed to parasitize herself onto me this time.

To be precise, I guided her to parasitize me.

Being able to manipulate Kei, who was at the top of the social hierarchy in Horikita's class, would be convenient in many aspects of school life going forward.

However, my daily life at school gradually brought changes to my thoughts.

It wasn't just about using those around me; I started thinking about fostering the students' growth in the process. Not just classmates like Horikita and Yōsuke, but also those from other classes like Ryūen's and Ichinose's. And Kei was just one of them. Parasitism isn't the only way to survive. If you could break free and stand alone, you'd be able to grow significantly as a human.

The mutual benefits were clear to everyone.

In exchange for giving Kei a chance to grow, I would also learn from Kei.

That involved understanding the opposite sex, knowing love, and then knowing separation.

The romance textbook I had been reading was soon reaching its final page.

Of course, for Kei, who was safe as long as she was parasitic, it might be an unwelcome favor.

Forcefully being peeled away from her host—there was no guarantee she could survive afterward.

The future was predictable but not absolute.

Whether someone can make the final decision depended on the person.

When you failed, you failed.

Kei had potential, but she couldn't blossom on her own.

That was all there was to it.

Whether she'd stop attending school, choose to voluntarily withdraw, or reject the world altogether.

Several cruel outcomes were conceivable, yet I was curious about each choice.

Dead or alive.

Today, the battle for Kei's survival would begin.

As I tried to approach the entrance, I couldn't take the first step.

Something foreign mixed into my thoughts.

"Just—"

Yes, even so, it wasn't that I wasn't thinking.

The long process of this year-length romance had unexpectedly produced a byproduct.

*I might feel some unknown emotion about breaking up with Karuizawa Kei.*

*Having spent time as lovers—might it transform into something new?*

Even though I had a premonition that nothing would happen, I was hoping for it.

*Maybe at the very last moment, things will change while I'm right before the person involved.*

No, I even wanted things to change.

I had a strong desire to resist my own thoughts and future predictions.

Not everything about the future was set in stone.

*Will I really be able to tell Kei goodbye?*

Even though I was certain I could, was there no possibility that I'd hesitate, and then embrace her?

I was hoping.

I was hoping that there were emotions within me that couldn't be calculated.

Even at this moment, on the day I had decided to be the last, I was praying for it.

I took the step I had stopped at and left the house so I wouldn't be late for the date.

# 1

I was greeted by her bursting smile.

Any regular male student would've spontaneously grinned by now.

"Good morning, Kiyotaka!"

It was 10 AM, right when Keyaki Mall opened.

At the meeting location, Kei, who had arrived earlier, waved and beckoned me in.

She seemed no different than usual. That was to be expected.

I had unilaterally decided to break up, and there was no way Kei could've known.

However, I couldn't completely dismiss the possibility that she sensed something was off.

I had been gradually preparing for the breakup, so I was considering that.

Still, it was unclear whether Kei, now before me, harbored those anxious feelings.

As soon as we met, her smile turned to a gloomy expression as she placed both hands on her stomach.

"I haven't eaten anything since this morning, so I'm really hungry."

"You're always like this. You should've eaten a little."

"I can't help it. I always end up eating too much popcorn during the screening."

We hadn't been to the cinema frequently, but I knew her preferences well enough.

Always salt and caramel half & half, bucket size.

And because Kei would eat too much of the caramel, I would end up eating a lot of the salt-flavored ones.

The half-remaining popcorn would then be put into a clear plastic bag, lightly sealed, and taken home, where we'd agree that it tasted worse as time passed, and eat it while watching TV.

That was our usual routine when we went to see a movie.

Standing side by side, she immediately took my hand.

It was a bit cold, but it soon warmed up.

"Shall we go?"

It wasn't me taking the lead, but Kei, who couldn't wait for the movie. She started to pull me along, feeling as if she was walking half a step ahead.

"Has anyone been blaming me for anything?"

"Huh? Why? Was there something to blame?"

"It's my responsibility that Maezono got expelled. I was worried if there might've been any repercussions for that."

"Not at all. There's nothing like that."

She answered without hesitation, not out of a need to cover for me.

It seemed that indeed, Kei wasn't affected by it.

"But—"

"But?"

After pondering for a moment, Kei spoke up.

"I feel like even those who kind of had the wrong idea about you, or maybe they didn't really understand you at first, are starting to realize that their initial impression might've been wrong. Some even say that Maezono was expelled on purpose as a punishment for betraying us."

It wasn't surprising. Kushida had realized that immediately.

It was just a matter of how far one could read into it; it was natural for some students to imagine such things.

"I see. So, what do you think, Kei?"

"About whether Maezono was expelled on purpose?"

"Yeah."

I asked out of pure curiosity.

"Well, yeah. I'm thinking… that it was intentional."

"On what basis?"

"Because you have the power to win against anyone. Plus, I've learned your way of thinking from observing you up close. If you've expelled Maezono, it means there was a purpose other than just winning, right? It was like making her pay the price for betraying the class. Isn't the impact of having an expulsion huge? What your real abilities or intentions are—things like that would be overshadowed by the impact. I was thinking it might've been like a camouflage to prevent people from realizing the truth."

Without much trouble, Kei summarized her thoughts on the incident.

Like Kushida, she roughly guessed my intentions.

However, just as I was about to acknowledge her insight, Kei looked at my face and then told me to wait.

"Hmm, maybe there's more. I thought I was mostly right, but... for example, if Ichinose-san was a tougher opponent than I thought, maybe you used Maezono as a surefire move to turn a 99% chance of winning into 100%. Or maybe you were looking ahead, not just at this incident, and decided to thoroughly crush her here."

Her initial answer could have scored 70 points, but she added more points with her further insights.

"I was right, yeah?"

I hadn't changed my expression, but Kei looked at me and seemed convinced she was correct.

We had just arrived at the movie theater, so we began printing the tickets we reserved.

"I'm honestly impressed. That was the closest answer anyone in the class could've given."

"Really!? Ehehe, you can be more impressed if you want."

She proudly boasted about getting it right, placing her hands on her hips with a triumphant air.

"Thinking about it that way, yeah. Maybe my worries have vanished."

"Worries?"

"You know, about Ichinose-san. I kind of thought you were being suspicious, Kiyotaka. I wondered if you were going to go easy on her in your battle."

"I see, it's about that. I told you there was nothing."

"Well, it was just my misunderstanding, so I won't probe any deeper. But I did think you took some unusually conspicuous actions this time."

"I did act boldly, but I was grateful that it didn't attract as much attention as I expected."

"Right. It's big that Class A was losing behind the scenes, and Sakayanagi-san's expulsion was at stake. Since it's hard to talk about Maezono's expulsion, the topic shifted entirely to that. Not a single day has passed since the exam ended without me hearing about it."

In that regard, the teachers who cooperated with me on the Hoshinomiya-sensei matter did a great job.

Especially Mashima-sensei, who seemed terribly down about the class demotion and the leader's expulsion, but he never showed it in front of the students.

"Ichinose-san didn't hold back either."

The topic seemed to change, but then it was forcibly brought back.

"Didn't you say you weren't going to probe deeper? What's with that suspicious look?"

"Just kidding?"

She narrowed her eyes teasingly but then showed a grin.

*Seems like she's quite pleased about me making a serious effort and crushing Ichinose.*

"It's only natural to make an effort for the class, right?"

"Wow, that sounds so fake...! I'm sure there's something more behind it because it's you, Kiyotaka."

She's done well.

Although she couldn't specifically tell what it was, as one would expect, she sensed that there were circumstances involved.

After that, we lined up at the kiosk, bought the popcorn as planned, added two sets of oolong tea, and completed the payment.

"I'm looking forward to the movie."

"Yeah."

While having such a conversation, we handed our tickets to the clerk, and the student in front of us turned around.

She must've recognized the voice.

"Ugh, Ayanokōji and Karuizawa!"

The one who made a blatantly unpleasant face was Ibuki.

She walked away as if fleeing, but it soon became clear that we were in the same screening.

"Are we really watching the same movie? The worst..."

*No, there's no reason to be treated as the worst just for sharing the same movie theater...* She just grumbled and quickly opened the door to the theater and disappeared.

"What was that?"

"I don't know. Maybe we shouldn't worry about it too much?"

After exchanging looks with each other, we entered the hall and headed towards the middle of the fifth row...

"Ugh, why out of all places are you guys here!"

Apparently, Ibuki's seat was next to Kei. In other words, the arrangement was Ibuki, Kei, and me.

"We can't help it. We don't know who's sitting next to us, right?"

"Yeah."

Ibuki and I weren't compatible, but Kei and Ibuki had even worse compatibility.

She'd been through a lot of trouble last year, so it was reasonable. Now, she didn't bring it up anymore, probably letting it go with a generous heart.

"You like movies too, Ibuki-san?"

Thinking it would be bad not to talk at all, Kei spoke to her.

"...Not really. Just by chance, totally by chance."

With a *hmph*, she turned away in a direction that had nothing to do with us.

"How about you guys just leave me alone?"

"Well, that's okay. But hey, want some popcorn?"

"No thanks."

She didn't even look at us, let alone the screen. *Her neck must be uncomfortable.*

"Hey, why couldn't Sakayanagi-san find the traitor, Ibuki-san?"

"Huh? What are you talking about all of a sudden? Ask that idiot next to you."

"That's why I'm asking. I'm talking to you..."

"...Are you picking a fight with me?"

At this point, Ibuki, who hadn't been looking at us, turned around angrily.

Kei teased the frantic Ibuki and laughed.

She must've had some unresolved frustration still inside.

However, it was as if she didn't feel it. The way she interacted so naturally was probably because she had gained some inner strength and time had provided her leeway to sort things out.

"There's no way I'd know... So, you have it figured out or something?"

She glared at me, looking over Kei.

"I don't know. It was an exam where we couldn't interfere with other classes, so there's no way I'd know."

"Whatever..."

Since Sakayanagi hadn't told anyone else about the message I had Hashimoto carry, the fact that she couldn't spot the traitor and lost was the only thing others knew.

When I met Morishita and others, I casually asked about the situation. Apparently, Hashimoto continued to remain in the class, acting as if nothing had happened despite classmates pointing their fingers at him.

A traitor acting in a way that prevented the representative from spotting them was within the rules.

In the end, it would purely be Sakayanagi's personal oversight to fail to see through it.

After that, the movie trailers started, so we quietly watched the screen.

# 2

After the screening ended, the two of us left the cinema holding hands, having watched until the end of the credits.

The movie fell short of expectations, largely due to its overly ambitious tagline, “Changing the History of Japanese Cinema,” but it was still fairly interesting.

By the way, the person who had been glaring from beside us throughout everything left in the middle of the credits.

She probably hated the idea of going home at the same time as us.

*If possible, I kind of wanted to hear her thoughts about the movie... But well, I guess it's fine.*

I then glanced at my partner, while walking hand in hand.

A lovely profile.

Their gaze was currently focused on the phone they were holding.

The slow passage of time.

Step by step, walking along, I suddenly found myself pondering.

We had arranged to meet during a day off, sat next to each other, and happily watched a movie together.

It was a common date, one that could be found anywhere in the world.

It was a very standard choice, but when I really thought over it, it did seem a bit mysterious.

The screening lasted for about two hours, and 99% of that time, your eyes would be on the screen, and there would hardly be any conversation between the couple. Occasionally, they might look at each other during a striking scene, catch each other's eyes by chance, or quietly whisper something in the other's ear, but still, they would mostly focus on the film.

Depending on how you looked at it, these two hours weren't spent doing something directly together as a couple.

Yet, it was established as a staple date activity.

For new couples, or those about to start dating, there was no need to force conversation, and it was easy to then create common topics for later.

But for couples who were used to each other, these benefits would seem minimal.

Despite this, they would still stick to this standard date activity.

*I think it’s quite mysterious.*

Despite questioning the classic movie date like this, the true charm comes from all the shared topics you get to talk about thanks to it.

"About the movie, it was generally entertaining, but I think it's better not to set the bar too high after all. What did you think, Kiyotaka?"

"I agree—they set the bar too high. But even considering that, it wasn't bad. No, rather, it was more on the enjoyable side."

The person who invited the recipient to the movie would somewhat be tested in their choice.

Even if the movie wouldn't get full marks, if it was enjoyable, that was enough of a reason to be happy.

"I see, then I'm glad. Which part did you particularly find interesting? For me…"

Within our confined school life, we had spent much of our personal time together.

So, even a trivial topic could expand into any type of conversation.

If we ran out of topics relating to the movie, there were yesterday's events, and then today's events.

Or perhaps things from last month, or from six months ago.

*Or... the future.*

Conversations that you couldn't have with family or friends, but could as a couple.

If I were to say a cheesy line, it would be that it was an "irreplaceable time."

This time would never be a waste.

Still holding hands, we next headed to karaoke inside Keyaki Mall.

This, too, was a common date.

Upon entering, we sat very closely together on a large sofa.

Then, fighting over and pushing the microphone to each other, we sang our favorite songs.

At times, we sang solos, and at times, we sang duets.

We were repeating the date we had gone through many times before.

Undoubtedly, it was a happy time.

As a couple, it was natural to wish it would last forever.

*It should just last forever.*

This wasn't just my selfish emotion.

My partner surely wished the same.

There wasn't supposed to be an end.

It was supposed to be a bright future, one that would continue endlessly.

And yet… we found ourselves in the midst of silence.

Though we were supposed to be feeling each other's body heat from being so close together, there was somehow a sensation of something getting colder.

And that was the signal.

A small distance between us naturally emerged.

That time had come.

The emotions that had long been hidden within.

One that would separate us two.
While following that person's gaze, I thought about it.
The words of farewell that would soon be spoken.
It was something that had been decided a long time ago.
While fighting the urge to deny it, this day had now arrived.
The fated moment.
With that moment now ahead of me, I couldn't help but feel an unpleasant sweat start to form.
A disorienting confusion, one that even I couldn't believe.
Even though I had faced similar difficult situations many times before.
It felt like this was the first time.
My heartbeat, which never wavered even through all those various things—
It was now throbbing violently.
As the moment drew near, I was overcome with an unbelievable sense of regret.
*What exactly could this be?*
I felt embarrassed at myself by how calm I had been just moments ago.
The words of farewell I thought I would easily be able to say.
I realized that it wasn’t easy at all.
*Ah, that's right.*
I was able to realize it now, just before that moment.
My true feelings.
*I don’t want to part.*
And that they too wouldn't want to part with the lover in front of them.
I realized I felt that.
*I love you.*
Without warning, that feeling surged forth from the very bottom of my heart.
Until now, I had hardly noticed these things properly.
Their charm.
Their face, voice, body—everything about them was dear to me.
The cute mannerisms I always looked at without really properly seeing.
My voice, it wouldn't come out.
—Let's break up
Even though I had decided to voice such words here.
——Again.
Once again, I tried to say it out loud.
Looking into their eyes, I tried to pull out those words, ‘Let's break up.’
*I can’t do it.*
And then, I understood.
Without even truly noticing, they had become truly important to me.

*This was love.*

Something I never could say, since the beginning.

*And that's because, in truth, I had known for a long time... that this is the person I love, I knew that…*

*Ah, I'm glad…*

●

"Let's break up."

*Yes.*

Our feelings had been the same.

As long as we both knew that we cared for each other, it would be ok.

*I was thinking about everything properly, Kiyotaka.*

*About everything until yesterday, about today, about tomorrow, and about next year.*

*I was thinking that there would be no such breakup.*

*That it wouldn't come to that...*

'I' had always believed in that.

*But... all those desires were just delusions.*

*They were merely wishes of how I wanted things to be.*

Lifeless eyes were looking at me.

The slow movement of the lips saying, 'Let's break up.'

*I don't know what he's thinking... no, I don't want to know.*

"...That's the only option, right?"

Such words came out of my throat surprisingly calmly.

The karaoke room remained quiet, while someone in the next room was passionately singing an anime song.

"Yeah. Whether it's better this way or not, I'm not looking for such a discussion. Let's end everything here and now."

With an unfaltering expression, Kiyotaka spoke those cruel words.

"So, I see..."

My throat was dry.

I wanted to drink water.

However, my body wouldn't move properly.

All I could manage was a forced smile as if everything was fine.

"Seems like you aren't surprised."

*When did I start liking him?*

*I can't remember a specific time anymore.*

"Kind of... I understand... I can tell that your feelings have drifted away."

*No, that's not it.*

*Maybe Kiyotaka never had feelings for me from the start.*

*Cherishing and loving each other—that feeling has always been one-sided.*

I realized it recently, but I probably knew it a bit earlier.

*Kiyotaka never fell in love with me.*

I kept pretending not to notice.

*So, why did he date me?*

I wouldn't ask that question.

Because I understood what Kiyotaka was thinking.

It was half for me.

And half for Kiyotaka himself.

But it wasn't about choosing right or left; Kiyotaka always considered his own thoughts as absolute.

So this was probably decided from the beginning.

It was when the clock struck midnight, like Cinderella's magic inevitably breaking.

The end of my relationship with Kiyotaka was predetermined from the start.

It was simply time for that moment to come.

I really wanted to cry, cling, and say I'd do anything.

I wanted to plead, 'I'll do anything for you.'

Maybe... a little while ago, I would've done that.

*But I won't.*

*I can't.*

Because resisting would only betray Kiyotaka's expectations.

"Do you need an explanation for the reason?"

Saying that, Kiyotaka took out his cell phone for some reason.

But, unable to think clearly, I shook my head from side to side and maintained a smile.

"No, it's okay."

I answered, trying hard to appear calm, and Kiyotaka put his phone away, saying he understood.

"Sorry I couldn't meet your expectations."

"It's okay. I also felt... that the atmosphere was kind of heavy, actually."

I pretended to be cheerful.

No, my heart was always close to Kiyotaka.

Even today, I was trying my best to enjoy myself without recalling my anxieties.

At that moment, I wanted to be told that it was a lie and be embraced.

But there was a reason I acted tough like this.

"That might be true."

Kiyotaka answered in a tone as if he was talking to someone else, and I kept responding with a forced smile.

“We both, kind of... feel like our romantic feelings have cooled down. Oh, it’s not that I dislike you, you know? I just thought maybe it’d be better if we went back to being friends.”

*Can you imagine how much courage I mustered up to say that?*

No matter how cold Kiyotaka’s emotions felt up close, I pretended not to notice.

“That’s right. Going back to being friends is the most natural thing.”

“Yeah, right? I had a feeling we should do that…”

I nodded repeatedly.

*No... if it keeps going like this...*

“...Thank you for everything until now.”

*It will all be over*.

With a forced smile that I myself couldn’t understand.

The final moments were about to wrap up.

“When asked why we broke up, you can say that you dumped me. I don’t mind.”

“Eh? Really? Wouldn’t that be a bit embarrassing?”

“It’s okay. You can give any reason you like. If someone asks me, I’ll say I was dumped too.”

*Then don’t say we should break up.*

*Stay with me forever and ever...*

*Stay by my side—*

“See you… Karuizawa.”

I was startled for a moment when he called me by my last name.

From friends to lovers. From lovers back to friends.

To go backward meant that everything up until now must be rewound.

*Is that what it meant?*

Holding the payment bill, Kiyotaka stood up and left the room.

Without looking back.

Without showing any hesitation.

Without stopping.

The door that opened soon closed, and I was left alone.

“See you...”

I swallowed my saliva.

Unconsciously.

Words I didn’t want to spit out.

However…

These were words that must be continued.

“See you... see you again... Ayanokōji... kun...”

I smiled and waved at the presence whose figure had disappeared.

*This is fine.*

*After all, Kiyotaka wanted 'that,' right?*

For me, who couldn't live without relying on someone.

To be able to live on my own.

I'm not a very significant person.

But, there were things only I could do.

*Like understanding your emotions, which no one else could comprehend, right?*

*Right?*

*Hey—*

Even if I wished for a miracle, the shut door wouldn't open.

Alone in the silent space, I collapsed.

*I wonder if I managed to do well in front of you until the end?*

*Was I able to show that I could stand on my own?*

*…Kiyotaka…*

*Help me…*

# Chapter 6:
# Even After Graduation

EARLY IN THE MORNING, when I returned to my room in the dormitory and checked my phone, I noticed that there were numerous calls and messages from Satō. This was, of course, an expected development—Karuizawa had informed her that we had broken up. She must've understood that it'd cause trouble later if our reports didn't match, and made it look like the break up was initiated from her end, as I had hoped for.

However, Satō, being a close friend, was convinced that there was no way Karuizawa would've wanted to break up on her own. She thought that I must've been the one to initiate it, so she contacted me seeking to go back on it.

But Satō knew too. The matters of a romantic relationship are fundamentally between the individuals involved to consider and decide. There's very little outsiders can do.

Still, she couldn't be blamed for feeling like she couldn't endure it and tried to interfere.

As I left the dormitory and headed towards the main gate, rather than revisiting yesterday's exchange with Satō, I checked the message sent after the end-of-year special exam.

"Ryūen-kun has given me permission to stay at the school for a while. There's a lot we need to talk about, but I plan on doing it on March 31st—in front of the main gate, the day I leave this school."

In response to Sakayanagi's message, I replied simply, agreeing and asking what time we should meet. I personally speculated that Sakayanagi was using the remaining time to meaningfully address unfinished business, including matters concerning the class.

Sakayanagi was scheduled to leave the school in a taxi booked for 11 AM, but we were to meet before that.

"Good morning, Ayanokōji-kun."

Arriving about ten minutes earlier than planned, there stood Sakayanagi—not Arisu, but her father, Chairman Sakayanagi.

"Good morning. Are you here to see her off?"

I asked, to which Chairman Sakayanagi nodded with his usual calm demeanor.

"It's a new beginning for my daughter. Are you here to see her off too, Ayanokōji-kun?"

"Yes, I have an appointment at 10:30. You don't seem shocked, Chairman."

"Hm? Oh, well, yes. Mashima-sensei had briefed me before the special exam, so I was prepared. It came as a big surprise at the time, but her decision must be respected. Of course, she shouldn't trouble her classmates by

withdrawing on her own accord. But then again, it would be inappropriate for me, in my position as chairman, to personally intervene, right?"

If the chairman exercised his authority, he could certainly ignore the wager. It'd be easy to stop the school, but doing so would break the rules.

"That's commendable."

I genuinely admired his understanding and attitude.

After giving a somewhat embarrassed smile, Chairman Sakayanagi suddenly turned serious.

"Actually, this isn't the place to talk about this, but I hear your father is coming for the three-person meeting."

"It seems so. I wonder what's going on."

"That man doesn't do anything meaningless. He probably wants to see for himself how you've grown and what kind of future you're considering."

Chairman Sakayanagi spoke in a pleased manner, but that likelihood was low. There were plenty of ways to check on me. However, I agreed that he wouldn't do anything meaningless.

"If you ever have any trouble, I hope you'll rely on me."

"That's reassuring. Thank you."

Chairman Sakayanagi sighed.

"Is it about my father?"

"No, I was just reminded of Arisu. Actually, there's been an unexpected complication. It's good that Arisu's transfer to a high school near our home has been decided. However, on a separate note, she's made a troublesome request."

"A troublesome request?"

"If you could persuade her, she might reconsider."

Chairman Sakayanagi said that with a wry smile, just as he was about to discuss the details of the request.

"You mustn't do this, Father. What are you trying to discuss with Ayanokōji-kun without my permission?"

"Uh... Arisu."

The visibly shocked Chairman Sakayanagi broke out in a cold sweat.

Sakayanagi with a cane appeared carrying no luggage.

Next to Sakayanagi were Yamamura and Morishita.

*Seems like they're seeing her off as classmates.*

"No, um, it's nothing."

"If that's the case, please make sure not to make any unauthorized remarks."

Apparently, his daughter had already warned him.

"Haha, well, let's talk about it slowly when I get home today. That'd be better."

"Yes. It seems we'll have a pleasant conversation as a family."

Chairman Sakayanagi smiled wryly. Until then, there had likely been a certain distance between them as chairman and student, but that was no longer necessary.

"I have a simple question—where is Sakayanagi Arisu's home?"

Morishita, without giving it much thought, asked a question that changed the atmosphere.

Indeed, now that it was mentioned, it was a curious point.

The teachers lived in dormitories, but what about the chairman normally?

"It's about a fifteen-minute drive from the school grounds. You can get here with one bus."

"Close."

Morishita immediately commented upon hearing the answer. By distance alone, it was very close. Of course, students enrolled in this school couldn't easily exit the premises except for special circumstances, like club activities.

"There's plenty of time before the taxi arrives. Could I have a moment to talk with Ayanokōji-kun alone?"

After Sakayanagi said this, Chairman Sakayanagi, Yamamura, and Morishita nodded and distanced themselves so that they wouldn't be able to hear our conversation.

"I didn't expect Yamamura and Morishita to see you off."

"Previously, it would've been Masumi-san, Hashimoto-kun, and then Kitō-kun."

Kamuro had withdrawn from school and Hashimoto had betrayed Sakayanagi. Kitō, on the other hand, didn't seem the type to show a melancholic demeanor at farewells, meaning no one close to her had come.

"Even if only for this short time, I've become close to Yamamura-san—in part thanks to you, Ayanokōji-kun."

And it was also because of me that they'd become separated.

"And what about Morishita?"

"It seems she was clinging to Yamamura-san."

That meant she came without being called.

"Morishita-san wasn't someone who usually gets close to specific people, but recently, she seems to be intentionally interacting with Yamamura-san. She's a naturally smart and sharp student, so she's probably worried about the future of the class."

"That might be true."

She had a very unusual personality, but I also sensed her extraordinary talent.

*Seems like me calling Morishita and Yamamura out for a talk a little while ago might've had an impact as well.*

"Well… our conversation today will be the last for now."

"That's right."

While looking at me intently, Sakayanagi spoke without hesitation.

"You seemed dissatisfied with me being your opponent, but it turned out as you wished. Do you feel any guilt for intervening in the match? Please tell me how you feel now."

"I'd like to say that I feel guilty, but such superficial lies wouldn't work on you, would they?"

What she desired here was honesty. Indeed, Sakayanagi happily smiled.

"If I may speak frankly, you were too strong, Sakayanagi. I have no doubts about your abilities, and although I don't know the details of the end-of-year special exam, you definitely surpassed Ryūen. However—"

"Ryūen-kun, Horikita-san, and Ichinose-san too. They all still have clear room for growth. It's unpredictable what changes they will undergo."

"That's right. I want to see that."

"Even knowing the answer, it still hurts to hear it said."

"Sorry."

"It's okay, I've come to understand that's how you are. Besides, my withdrawal was my own decision. I can only blame my own excellence for understanding the message."

Of course, I had no idea what the outcome and conclusion of the exam would turn out to be.

However, after considering whether I wanted Ryūen or Sakayanagi to remain, I entrusted him with the message.

Whether to convey it was Ryūen's freedom—and whether to receive it and then also understand it was all left to Sakayanagi.

Even so... if I analyzed Ryūen's personality and Sakayanagi's way of thinking, I believed there was a good chance this conclusion would be reached.

"Although you've said various mean things, I don't intend to blame you, Ayanokōji-kun. However, I'd like to clarify the matter of our debts."

"That's right. I also want to settle that matter if possible. What do you desire?"

I incurred a significant debt to Sakayanagi that I needed to properly settle.

"Then, may I ask for two favors?"

Since I didn't intend to refuse from the start, I nodded and waited for Sakayanagi's requests.

"The first one, well, I would like a passionate kiss right here."

She voiced a mean wish. It was hard to tell if she was being serious or if she was joking.

"How should I take that?"

Sakayanagi stepped closer, slightly lifted her chin, and closed her eyes.

The three onlookers' faces were honestly too scary to look at.

As I was about to reconfirm if that was really her wish, Sakayanagi slowly opened her eyes.

"Fufu. Just kidding."

"That's a bad joke."

I felt relieved inside.

It was one thing to do it in front of students from the same year, but Sakayanagi's father, the chairman, was also watching.

"My first request is this: I'm asking with the confidence that I'm not being conceited, but my role isn't over yet, is it?"

At those words, I briefly glanced at the chairman.

Then quickly returned my gaze back to Sakayanagi.

"You're someone who thinks ten or twenty steps ahead. Then, there must've been benefits to choosing my voluntary withdrawal other than just keeping Ryūen-kun, right?"

Sakayanagi was indeed adept at strategy and thinking, being able to reach answers on her own without assistance.

"I'd considered it as setting the groundwork. I can't see a future where that's going to happen yet, though."

"That's fine. Just hearing that you've considered it as groundwork is enough for me."

"I might just be using you, you know."

"Even so, I don't wish to lose contact with you. Although our interactions at this school will be severed, I haven't given up on battling you again in the future, Ayanokōji-kun. I intend to impose on myself trials over the next year to become a more suitable opponent. So, promise me that you will meet me again after you leave this school."

"Is that your first wish?"

"Yes."

Sakayanagi answered immediately.

"There are some things that are beyond even my control. Are you really okay with that wish?"

"I will trust you."

With a straightforward look, Sakayanagi answered more firmly than before.

"...I see. If it's with you, a reunion might indeed be possible."

As I'd said earlier, there were many things I couldn't do anything about.

However, someday, when I wish to change the future with my own hands, the promised reunion with Sakayanagi might become a significant help.

"The environment surrounding you—the White Room—I'm of course aware of it. But remember, the way you live your life is for you to decide. Don't forget that."

"That's right. I hope the day comes when I can think that way."

That was all I could answer at the moment, but Sakayanagi nodded in satisfaction.

"What about the second wish?"

"Well... it would be tactless to include the class's future after I leave, so I really struggled with this."

After the preamble, Sakayanagi voiced her wish.

"It's about Hashimoto-kun's future treatment. I haven't told the class in detail about him."

"There might be students who are suspicious of him, but without definitive proof, they're left with presuming his innocence."

As I responded, Sakayanagi agreed.

"However, there must be someone who knows what he did and what he was trying to do—and they'll have to make a decision. May I entrust you with the judgment? There is no deadline."

"So, you're asking me to decide whether he's guilty or innocent in the coming year?"

"Yes. I have both a forgiving and unforgiving heart within me. Ideally, I would've liked to walk together and see its conclusion, but that's no longer possible."

If she was leaving the decision entirely up to me, then I had no problem with it.

"I understand. I will take on the arbitrator role."

"Thank you. Then, with that in mind, I will go meet Masumi-san."

Kamuro probably wouldn't be pleased to meet again; rather, she'd be dumbfounded first.

"Well then, shall we call those people back soon?"

"No, there's something I have to tell you before we part."

Saying that, I took out my phone and displayed a photo of Sakayanagi that was previously taken in my room.

Then, I deleted it right in front of her.

"I'd prepared it just in case, but now there's no need to use it anymore."

"Oh, then she and you—?"

"Karuizawa herself knew the outcome."

"Is that so? If she truly has a strong will, she will surely stand up again."

Even if Karuizawa couldn't stand up on her own, she had reliable friends.

"But is that so? Then that would mean you're now back to being free again, Ayanokōji-kun."

"That's right."

"Then I didn't need to hesitate when I asked for the kiss."

Saying that, Sakayanagi smiled mischievously and gently spread her arms.

"Wouldn't it be alright to give this as a bonus?"

The time was quickly approaching.

I too spread my arms and quietly drew Sakayanagi closer.

“Feeling reluctant to part, wanting to speak more—I still have so many similar emotions, but having these still remain in me is just fine. I look forward to the day we can meet again.”

“Yes—”

My future was currently closed off.

However, the situation could change.

The Sakayanagi I held in my arms was small, giving off a fragile feeling of helplessness.

However, among those I had met, she certainly possessed a strength unlike anyone else.

In the near future, I was certain I would meet Sakayanagi again in the outside world.

I had a strong premonition about it.

# 1

Until the remaining time ran out, Sakayanagi exchanged words with her classmates.

As the time of parting approached, Yamamura earnestly tried holding back her tears. However, when she heard Sakayanagi's renewed apology and her wish to reunite, tears fell at last. She had a true friend for the first time. She wanted to spend another year of school life together.

Yet, in the end, they looked forward and promised to meet again. Morishita neither envied nor felt sad about them; instead, she seemed worried about the future of the class.

After seeing her off at the main gate and parting with the principal, the three of us were now on our way back to the dormitory.

Yamamura still hadn't emotionally settled, but this was the best timing.

I decided to bring up the topic with the two former Class A members.

"Actually, while I was talking with Sakayanagi earlier, she entrusted me with some important advice for the former Class A."

"What kind of... advice?"

A secret message was suddenly mentioned. While students like Yamamura might've been pleased, Morishita reacted differently.

Her expression changed to one of suspicion, searching for the meaning of my words.

"Advice? If it's true, it's very unwelcome. Should we really listen to it?"

"Why not? I want to know."

"It's important advice. Moreover, it's related to the class. Think about it calmly, Yamamura Miki. The right person to convey this advice should be directly related to our class, not Ayanokōji Kiyotaka. Isn't that right? Moreover, it's not something to say at the very end, during one's final moments."

"That is... true..."

*Her phrase, 'one's final moments,' might be too strong, but let's overlook that.*

"Well, there is a traitor in the class, right? If this is to prevent the tiny possibility of a leak, I could reluctantly understand..."

The advice I was about to convey wasn't actually requested by Sakayanagi. It was something I was planning to do on my own. It was sharp of her and normal to be suspicious and distrustful.

"There are various things to consider, but it's advice that I need to convey."

"So there was a need for you to act as an intermediary. Alright, I'm very suspicious, but whether I'll be convinced or not, I won't know unless I listen. Let's hear it."

Morishita crossed her arms and waited for what I was going to say, along with Yamamura, to whom I began to explain.

At first, Morishita listened sternly, but as things unfolded, her pupils dilated and she was genuinely surprised. Meanwhile, Yamamura seemed to be slightly confused. Perhaps it was beyond what she could understand.

"This is the advice Sakayanagi left. It's about how the former Class A should fight next year."

"How we should fight... But, is that even allowed?"

"Allowed or not, there have been similar situations before."

However, those were trivial compared to the advice I currently gave.

Yet, the scale of what we had discussed here would be significant throughout the year.

"I see. We have almost no chance of turning things around now. However, if we can implement that, possibilities start to emerge."

Imagining the unknown future, Morishita gradually came to understand.

"What are the chances of winning... How much does this increase it by?"

"Last time I said 10%, but if this is realized, it will be at least 25%. Including values for latent potential, we might be able to get an even higher number. However, there will be inconvenient cases later on—there are many causes for concerns. Can it really be realized?"

While many people would've pointed things out, I had already devised suggestions to deal with them.

As I added to my explanation, Morishita and Yamamura naturally turned to look at each other.

"Let's assume we can clear those concerns. There's still a major challenge left."

I understood and nodded, presenting the solution to that major challenge.

Of course, a solution is just a solution; whether it could be implemented was another matter.

However, all of this would form a continuous process.

If one step was off, nothing would be realized.

After hearing everything, Morishita's first words were...

"Are you sane?"

It was indeed hard to believe.

"I want to hear your honest opinion."

"Well, if that solution is possible, it's more than we could wish for. It wouldn't be too hard to rally a class that's about to give up, given the current situation."

"Let's do it... It's advice left by none other than Sakayanagi-san..."

As a friend, Yamamura expressed that she wanted to give it a try.

But Morishita thought it over until the very end.

“Ayanokōji Kiyotaka. There’s something I want to ask you.”

“What is it?”

“Is this story really a parting gift from Sakayanagi Arisu? Or is it just your personal idea?”

“I said it was.”

“That was a pointless question. Sakayanagi Arisu has already left this school. There’s no way to verify what is true anymore. Sorry, but let me change my question. Sakayanagi Arisu’s advice, or rather her strategy, that you’ve presented to us, former Class A students—what do you get in return for involving yourself in this matter? It doesn’t seem very beneficial. Unless I’m convinced of that, I won’t accept the proposal.”

It was a very natural doubt to have. Even if I said it was a mere act of goodwill, Morishita would just reject it.

“I have a goal I want to achieve by the time I graduate from this school. That goal is to maintain the balance among the four classes until the very end of our third year, making it possible for any class to achieve victory. Sakayanagi’s advice was simply the best for that purpose. For the sake of that goal, whether I graduate from Class A or who moves up is secondary.”

It would be hard to believe.

For those attending this special school and competing, securing a seat in Class A was definitely desired.

Normally, helping other classes would be considered absurd.

“Very suspicious. I would like to say I’ll pass on cooperating...”

After showing a moment of contemplation, Morishita continued to analyze my words and actions calmly.

“Assuming all of this, including your goal, is true, are you really okay with that, Ayanokōji Kiyotaka? That is to say, before even getting to the topic of Class A and so on, first and foremost, it would mean betraying your comrades.”

“It’s not the first time. I’ve been doing things as I please behind the scenes.”

“I see. So we can’t simply be happy about this. The hand you’re extending might be poisoned.”

Exactly. I was someone who would lend a hand to other classes, ignoring the intentions of my own class. That meant that I, who was now helping Morishita’s class, might also help another class in some unknown place.

“If you judge it to be dangerous, another option is to quit trying.”

Of course, I knew the answer.

Morishita and the others had no other options left. It was either move forward or give up.

“Once you’ve committed a crime, commit to it. Since we’re already pushed to the limit, deciding to act while knowing the risks seems best. The rest is up to our classmates’ choice.”

Morishita was just someone in the class.

She wasn’t recognized as a leader, unlike Sakayanagi and others.

“I’ll start preparing right away—”

“Excuse me!”

As Morishita was about to take action, someone unexpectedly called out to her from a distance.

A female student, a first-year named Negishi, approached us, half-running.

“Ah... Ayanokōji-senpai. I’m a first-year student, Negishi. Could you please accept this?”

With a trembling voice, she took out a letter and handed it over, thrusting it forward.

“What is this?”

I asked back, but Negishi blushed, bowed her head, and ran away as if she was fleeing us.

“Right after hugging Sakayanagi Arisu, you receive a love letter from a kōhai. You are indeed in a fine position, aren’t you?”

“I-Is it a love letter?”

“Nervous expression, plain envelope, and a girl who blushes and runs away... smells fishy.”

“I don’t smell anything though?”

“I wouldn’t know. I’m not familiar with your sense of smell, Ayanokōji Kiyotaka.”

*It’s a harsh retort, but really, what is in this envelope?*

“If she was asked to hand it over, there might be another girl involved. However, even in that case, it might just be a lie she made because of her own shyness.”

I turned it over to check, but nothing was written on it.

“Let’s look. There must be some honest writing inside.”

Encouraged by Morishita, I opened the envelope, and there was a single sheet of white paper inside.

As I unfolded the neatly folded letter, there was—

“A phone number... it seems.”

While looking flustered, Yamamura peered into the letter and muttered those words.

Besides the eleven-digit phone number, there was only one initial, N, written.

“Well, isn’t it fine? Instead of a letter, she wants to deepen the relationship through conversation.”

"...Maybe."

I was able to guess who the letter's sender was by looking at the initial.

Both Morishita and Yamamura seemed to think it was from Neginishi, who handed it over, but it was probably different.

Indeed, the initial N matched. However, right now, there was only one person I could think of that'd go through the trouble of passing a phone number through a letter. Considering it was given to Neginishi, it was also a subtle way of indicating a Romanized Japanese initial.

*Was this meant as a thank you for the recent 'trouble'?*

"Let's call right away. Let's whisper some words of love."

*I can't understand why Morishita is so enthusiastic despite being unrelated...*

"No, I won't call. It's not necessary right now."

"What, are you playing the waiting game? Hmm, how long are you planning on letting it sit?"

"Well, if I were to call, it'd be at least a year from now."

"That's when you graduate, isn't it?"

Thinking that this phone number was *that* kind of thing, I put the letter in my pocket.

# Chapter 7:
# Parent and Child, Child and Parent

THIS YEAR'S SPRING BREAK had more issues to deal with than the previous year.

Most of them were resolved, but one of the remaining issues would likely be settled soon.

That said, there was little I could do about it. For this matter, I had to rely on the passage of time.

It was 4 PM on April 1st. Dressed in my uniform, I left the dormitory and headed for school.

I was going to attend a three-way meeting that started at 4:30 PM. Originally, it was scheduled for the last slot, at 5 PM, but during the spring break, I received a call from Chabashira-sensei, and it was rearranged to swap with Kōenji, one slot earlier. The change in schedule was something that man had been concerned about.

By the way, students had been instructed in advance to wait in their respective classrooms 15 minutes before the scheduled time.

I could afford to walk leisurely and still make it on time. Each family was allotted 15 minutes for their three-way meeting, with 30-minute intervals between each meeting.

*Will that man really come?*

At this point, it felt fifty-fifty, but so far, there had been no notice of his cancellation.

*'At least, we will never meet here again.'*

Those words at that time were directed at Chairman Sakayanagi, not at me. However, it was reasonable to interpret it as essentially meaning that he wouldn't set foot in this school again.

*(TL Note: Refers back to the meeting when Atsuomi first came to the school and told Sakayanagi that if they were to ever meet again, it wouldn't be at the school.)*

Yet, if he retracted his previous statement and attended the three-way meeting, naturally, there must've been something behind it.

I had considered the possibility of Ishigami, who had connections with that man, making contact in some way. However, to this day, no action was taken.

"I suppose thinking about it is pointless after all."

Due to issues that had to be completely separated from school life, things would probably just happen as they would.

While it seems standard practice to hold three-way meetings in classrooms, this school, perhaps out of respect for each family's privacy, used spaces like the reception room, counseling room, and student council room. For Horikita's class,

the counseling room was designated, which was a bit far from the classroom we were waiting in. I sat at my desk in the empty classroom, waiting for the time to come. Ten minutes before the scheduled time, I received a message from Chabashira-sensei. The previous meeting had ended, and she instructed me to move to the counseling room.

*Well… let's face the three-way meeting.*

# 1

As soon as I saw the counseling room, Chabashira-sensei, who was standing in front of the door, noticed me.

There were about five minutes left until the conference time, but that man was nowhere to be seen.

“My father doesn’t seem to have arrived. Is he absent?”

“No, I haven’t received any notification on that end.”

From what it seemed, I wouldn’t get the answer I was anticipating. However, he definitely hadn’t arrived yet, and Chabashira-sensei appeared a bit anxious about whether he would really come.

As a homeroom teacher, she also had an overall schedule to consider.

Since we could only wait, we stared down the hallway as a heavy period passed.

Perhaps disliking the atmosphere, Chabashira-sensei brought up a different topic.

“About Chie—have you met her since then?”

“No, I haven’t contacted her yet.”

“I see. Well, I know it’s not something that I should be expecting from a student but...”

“It’ll take some time, but as I mentioned the other day, I’ll manage something during spring break.”

“You say that, but what exactly do you plan to do? Chie seemed determined to bring me down. She hardly seems like she could be persuaded.”

“I understand what you want to say, but if that’s the case, would you go so far as to step down as the class homeroom teacher?”

If Chabashira-sensei surrendered, Hoshinomiya-sensei would be satisfied.

She would spend the next year without straying from her path as a teacher.

“That’s... something I cannot do. I have a duty to watch over you all as a class.”

“Then it’s also important to wait patiently. Chabashira-sensei, you shouldn’t act recklessly.”

Chabashira-sensei needed patience and the courage to wait now.

I had no choice but to make her understand that simply continuing to observe was the best option.

“...Understood. But if anything happens, contact me immediately.”

“I understand. Besides, I do trust and rely on you, Chabasira-sensei.”

Being told that by a student, she probably couldn’t argue back.

*Now, would that man come or not?*

Looking down the hallway, I heard faint footsteps.

As the appointed time drew closer and closer, that man appeared, looking no different from last year.

He seemed to immediately notice us but closed the distance without showing any reaction.

"I've been waiting for you. I'm the homeroom teacher, Chabashira."

"I'm Ayanokōji. Thank you for today."

He answered with a stern, serious expression. Then, he briefly glanced over at me.

"It's been a while, Kiyotaka. Good to see you're doing well. Is school life going smoothly?"

I almost mistook his behavior as a joke, but it seemed he intended to play the father role in front of my homeroom teacher.

If that was the case, it'd be easier for me to play along to some extent.

For the time being, I would strongly perceive this man as a 'father.'

"Guess so. I've managed to make some good friends."

"Ah, that's good to hear."

Neither of us truly meant what we were saying, but Chabashira-sensei continued.

"Please, come inside."

She smiled, opened the door, and ushered the two of us into the counseling room.

As we sat side by side on the arranged chairs, Chabashira-sensei closed the door and sat down in front of us.

"First, though it'll be brief, I would like to report on Ayanokōji Kiyotaka-kun's grades and school life over the past two years."

Saying that, she slid two copies of my documents she prepared in advance across the desk. My father picked up one of them to review the contents. I followed suit and began to look through it.

"While you go through them, I would appreciate it if you could listen as I explain. Regarding his attitude towards daily life and his approach during classes, he has very few problematic behaviors and he's very responsible, so please rest assured."

Two years of school life had passed. There were written and special exams conducted, and the results were recorded.

The school had evaluated the students, noting their strengths and weaknesses.

"May I ask a question?"

"Yes, of course. What is it?"

"What is this OAA?"

While pretending to be a normal father interested in his child's growth, he pointed at the document.

"This is a new system introduced in our school. You can consider it a simplified report card of the student's performance. It is reviewed monthly, and the evaluation fluctuates based on the overall capabilities at that time."

"That's an interesting initiative."

It wasn't very easy to grasp everything at a glance, even if all the year's performances were written in detail. However, looking at the OAA allowed you to conveniently check a student's general capabilities.

As of the end of March this year, my OAA seemed to be as follows.

***Ayanokōji Kiyotaka:***
*Academic Ability A (87)*
*Physical Ability B (73)*
*Adaptability C (54)*
*Social Contribution B (70)*
*Overall Ability B (71)*

"Could you tell me how this compares to the typical student?"

"He is within the top 5% among the second-year students. I believe this is enough for him to be considered a model student—no, perhaps even something above that. The OAA computes the average of all of a student's results from these past two years, but within the last six months, he has shown a top-class level of growth."

At this time last year, my overall ability was 51. When you thought about it that way, it certainly felt like it had gone up quite a bit.

"That's good to hear. As a parent, this reassures me that I can watch his growth with peace of mind."

My father said this and nodded strongly toward Chabashira-sensei.

The conversation between teacher and parent continued without any issues.

I listened silently during this time, nodding and responding as needed.

After explaining the documents, Chabashira-sensei switched to the next topic.

"So, Ayanokōji-san, what are your thoughts on Kiyotaka-kun's future path?"

"What do you mean?"

"With his academic abilities, I think that he should aim for a higher-level university. Academics are not everything in life. However, in my opinion, providing an environment where he can fully utilize his abilities would be the best choice if it's within reach."

"Most certainly. As a parent, I'd be happy if my child goes to a good university. However, the most important thing is what my son himself thinks. If

he has no intention to pursue further studies, there's no point in discussing it here."

Chabashira-sensei seemed satisfied with my father's response and then turned her gaze toward me.

It appears that a model answer was expected from me here.

"If my parents allow it, I think pursuing further studies wouldn't be a bad choice."

"Is that so? Of course, I have no reason to oppose it. Do you have any preferred university?"

"I'm interested in the university where my senpai who took care of me here has gone."

"The senpai that took care of you? Are you talking about Horikita and Nagumo?"

"Yes, Chabashira-sensei."

"That's a good idea. The hurdles you'd have to overcome aren't low, but there's definitely a possibility."

Chabashira-sensei, pleased as if it were her own matter, mentioned the name of the university and explained it to my father.

"I see. The big three national universities, huh…"

My father showed an exaggerated act, appearing impressed.

"If you wish for it, you should definitely aim for it."

"That's great. If your family says that, I think it's very reassuring."

"Yes, it is."

"But Kiyotaka, while I don't oppose you aiming for university, what do you see beyond that?"

*What kind of turn of events was this?* My father sought my opinion.

*Would this farce of an act continue all the way until the end of the three-way meeting?*

The meeting didn't necessarily have to use up all the allotted time.

Since about half the time had already passed, it'd be fine to wrap it up soon.

Continuing a conversation he wasn't interested in just to appear like a good father probably wasn't his intention.

So, there was a proper meaning behind this prolongation.

"What comes after university, you ask?"

While pretending to think, I reevaluated my father's intentions. He prolonged a meeting that could've ended in five or ten minutes, using the time to see what changes it might bring.

*What would happen if the meeting went over time?* Naturally, the impact would be one thing. The next three-way meeting with Kōenji's family might face issues.

In other words, he was trying to create a pretext to make contact under the guise of coincidence.

"That's right. Going to a prestigious university is wonderful, but what's the purpose of going to university, and what are the prospects? I want to hear this before deciding on a course."

Chabashira-sensei, unaware of my father's scheming, happily listened to the parent-child conversation.

"I'm sorry, I haven't decided anything yet. Would it be too late to decide during university?"

"No, if nothing is decided, that's fine. However, if you're considering university just to appease your parents and drifting away from what you truly want to pursue, then that's a problem."

"If I say I want to work, will you accept that, Father?"

"As a parent, that's only natural."

"Thank you."

It was easy to just go along, but the atmosphere was far from comfortable.

Even if it was an act, watching my father up close was not a pleasant experience.

Afterward, my father continued to engage in meaningless conversation with Chabashira-sensei, ultimately using up all of the allotted time and even going a bit over.

# 2

The tormenting three-way meeting ended, and the three of us stood up.

It had been a painfully long 15 minutes.

“Thank you for today.”

My father bowed politely to Chabashira-sensei, who hurriedly took a deep bow in return.

“No, thank you for coming despite your busy schedule.”

*With this, his role was over.* Such hopeful thoughts vanished in an instant.

“By the way, Sensei. This has nothing to do with my son, but may I have another moment with you?”

Right after leaving the counseling room, my father spoke to Chabashira-sensei, who was about to see us off.

“Of course. Is there something on your mind?”

Truthfully, she would’ve wanted to contact Kōenji next, but since she couldn’t dismiss him outright, she continued to respond earnestly without showing any reluctance.

Fortunately, the conversation that started had nothing to do with me, so I listened passively, emptying my mind.

Looking out the window, I just wanted to go home. I couldn’t use my phone, so I didn’t know the exact time, but they probably talked for about five minutes.

Just as impatience began to show on Chabashira-sensei’s face, my father gave a big nod.

“You’ve answered my questions.”

“That’s good to hear.”

This period, mixed with tension and relaxation, came to an end as Chabashira-sensei let out a sigh of relief.

“Thank you for taking the time today.”

“Thank you as well for coming all the way to the school. I think Kiyotaka-kun is also pleased.”

*No, I’m not pleased at all.*

However… to show a mature response, I gave a firm nod.

My father thanked Chabashira-sensei once again, and at the very end, he looked over to me.

“Take care not to overdo it for your remaining school life.”

“Yeah...”

Though there was a delay, a completely normal three-way meeting had ended.

Without lingering any longer, my father quickly turned his back and walked away.

"He seems like a good father. Quite different from what I imagined."

As expected, Chabashira-sensei saw us as just a normal parent and child.

"That might be true."

There was absolutely no point in explaining otherwise to Chabashira-sensei.

"Well… one hurdle's crossed, but there's one more to go. Once that's over, I can also relax."

"Kōenji, was it? I hope it ends without trouble, just like ours."

"Exactly. You were obedient, but it's hard to imagine what will happen with Kōenji."

She probably wanted him to act meek like a borrowed cat in front of his parents, but that was unlikely.

*(TL Note: The Japanese idiom "借りてきた猫" (borrowed cat) refers to someone acting unusually quiet and well-behaved - like how a cat might act timid in a new environment.)*

Suddenly, Chabashira-sensei looked down the hallway.

Following her gaze, I saw that my father had stopped and was staring at us.

*Seems like he's waiting for me...*

"Your father is waiting. You should talk about whatever you want to talk about now, while you have the chance."

"I'll go do that."

*There's no way we haven't spoken enough. Is he planning to extend this delay tactic just between the two of us?*

*Or is he about to take some kind of action against me now?*

Either way, it was impossible to avoid. I just had to get through it.

I bowed my head and left, and Chabashira-sensei quickly returned to the counseling room.

Reluctantly, I slowly walked towards my father... no, that man.

I stopped beside him, but that man didn't proceed to speak.

"There was no need for you to wait, right?"

I could ignore him, but I decided to speak to find out the reason.

Even if there was an expected goal, it wouldn't be easy to get him to talk about it.

"We are father and son, after all. I thought we should at least have a light conversation."

"Father and son, huh? Unfortunately, I've never thought of it that way."

"I suppose not."

One thing was for certain, I didn't particularly have any grudges against this man.

Our relationship was closer to that of a teacher and student than that of a parent and child.

No, even that expression might be incorrect.

It was a more distant, insurmountable hierarchical relationship.

"For the past year, I've been racking my brain over what course of action to take with you after your graduation."

"You don't need to explain—I understand. And I have no intention of opposing it."

"I will appoint you as the White Room's new leader and create the next generation that will surpass you."

I said I understood, but the man deliberately mentioned it.

"If you're looking at the long run, that would be the safest choice. If you become the leader and manage the White Room, in 20 years, I might have the highest quality personnel I desire."

Imagining that future, the man spoke indifferently.

"But that safe choice is a tremendously distant future, and frankly, it's a dreamless tale. Just like the world's situation changes moment by moment, my environment has changed quite a bit in just one year."

"I'm not interested in your environment."

"I don't care about your interests either. What's important is how to use that talent."

"What do you want me to do?"

"You probably have some idea, don't you?"

His gaze clung to me. Whether it was this man's intuition or something else, he was skillfully casting doubt on my hidden inner thoughts.

"Who knows."

"Either way, preparation will take time. You should do as you like for another year. I won't interfere at all."

From what it seemed, my remaining school life was guaranteed, but I had no trust in him. It wouldn't have surprised me if he changed his mind tomorrow and shamelessly sent another assassin.

"Have you not considered that I might change my mind during that time and oppose you?"

"Oppose? That's unlikely. You should be able to understand everything. To fully demonstrate your value and purpose, my cooperation is essential. But if, by any chance, you decide to confront me… there would only be one outcome."

It wasn't just about freedom or lack thereof. It was a matter of life or death.

Whether I was his real child or not—it was completely irrelevant to this man.

"No matter how confident you are in your physical strength, an unexpected stray bullet can end it all."

24 hours a day, 365 days a year; there's no way to completely protect oneself.

In fact, in the White Room, I've been killed numerous times in simulations.

Attacks during sleep. Shots from blind spots. Or traps in food.

Although I've been trained to sharpen my mind to the utmost degree and increase my survival rate, I've also been thoroughly taught that life isn't absolute.

"Don't think about anything unnecessary, Kiyotaka."

Anything unnecessary, including the nonsense about further studies we talked about earlier.

"If you wish so, you need to keep convincing me that you are beneficial to me."

"Ho? Then, do you have any desires?"

He spoke as if he couldn't imagine me having any desires.

Indeed, I had no materialistic desires.

"What happened to Yagami, who was sent to expel me—no, to check my status?"

"Is that what you want to know?"

Honestly, it didn't matter to me. However, it wasn't the same for Amasawa.

"Of course, I disposed of him. Well, that's what I would've said up until last year."

The man paused for a moment, maintaining an unreadable expression, and continued.

"Even so, he was one of the more outstanding students in the White Room. Now, he's being re-educated."

"Re-education, huh?"

"Unlike you, I gave him too much emotion. You can also call it a test to remove that."

"Then, will Amasawa eventually follow in Yagami's footsteps?"

"That's right. But I will leave her as is for another two years. After graduation or expulsion, I'll retrieve her and examine the differences with Yagami."

"I hope she'll do as she's told obediently."

"We train them to do as they're told. Just like how you, despite your talent, can't easily rebel against me. If by some chance she won't obey, we'll deal with her accordingly."

Normally, it wasn't so simple to easily influence how someone else would live their life, or whether they'd live or die, but this man could do it. At least for the children who were destined to enter the White Room even before they were born, he must've known their detailed backgrounds. Even if she developed a

rebellious spirit during her school life, ultimately, using Yagami as a shield would be enough.

Amasawa couldn't abandon Yagami.

It was precisely because she was planted with so many emotions that it would end up backfiring.

No, regardless of the emotions' presence, the outcome might be the same.

Objectively, it seemed that Amasawa could easily ignore this man's orders.

Unless the opponent was an exceptionally skilled pursuer, she would handle it.

It was also possible to expose the White Room to the public and forcibly disrupt the plan.

*Though, I don't think Amasawa would do such a thing.* At the moment, even I hadn't considered it.

It would be better to say it was unthinkable.

The education from a young age was deeply ingrained, too deep to wash away.

"You care about Yagami and Amasawa, huh?"

"Even though I didn't know them personally, they are like younger siblings to me."

"It's amusing. Seems like these past two years spent as a normal student definitely left a mark on you."

There was absolutely no fun involved in the White Room's education.

"To you, is this change in me welcomed? Or is it the opposite?"

"If anything, it's welcomed. You were a complete machine in the White Room, for better or worse. The fact that even a semblance of humanity has emerged will be an asset later on."

If he could ultimately control it, it wasn't something to worry about.

"You should be done checking up on me already. Can I go back now?"

"Don't rush. Opportunities to talk with me aren't frequent."

"It's not that I want them anyway."

Disturbingly, the man continued to linger.

"Just now, your homeroom teacher mentioned in the conversation that the class has grown thanks to your efforts. It's just a small world of a classroom, but promoting it to Class A isn't bad. Well done."

"It's surprising that you'd praise such a trivial matter."

"Considering your abilities, moving up shouldn't be an issue. I praised you not for that, but for your attitude to take the top spot. Before entering this school, you wouldn't have cared about such things."

"Maybe. But if that's the case, your hopes are misguided. I'm not doing this to take the top. As proof, I'm planning to move to a lower class afterward."

“Ho? You’re deliberately going down again? Pulling a class up to the top and then dragging it down from the bottom?”

“Who knows? That might be it, or it might not be.”

Regarding that, I myself hold the view of letting things go in whichever direction the wind blows.

By deliberately not looking at the results, I think it makes things more enjoyable.

“That in and of itself is an interesting sign.”

I had no intention of wasting time chatting here, but he still didn’t seem to be letting me go.

“Your aim is—”

I’d had enough, so I was about to speak up directly when I heard footsteps coming up the stairs. It was about time for the Kōenji family to arrive.

The moment the owner of the footsteps appeared, that man’s expression changed drastically.

It was Kōenji’s father. He was tall and quite well-built. Spotting us standing still at the end of his gaze, Kōenji’s father finished climbing the stairs and then stopped for a moment.

Seizing the timing, that man started moving and spoke.

“Could it be Company President Kōenji?”

The man who forcefully blocked the path and stepped forward feigned surprise and bowed his head.

At the location for the three-way meeting, an encounter with some fathers and sons had indeed been staged as a coincidence.

The other party stared down at the man without uttering a word. His presence and intimidating aura were quite something.

“Excuse me for asking, but who might you be?”

He immediately took out a business card and handed it to Kōenji’s father.

“I apologize for the late introduction. I am Ayanokōji Atsuomi, a member of the Kyōei Party. I have long wished to meet Company President Kōenji. To think that I’d meet you here at your son’s meeting... Coincidences can be quite unthinkable sometimes.”

“It’s my principle to decline unnecessary business cards.”

“Is that so? Then I will strive to make it acceptable to you, and if possible, could I have a little of your time after the meeting with your son? I promise you won’t regret it.”

The man bowed again. I didn’t know why he was interested in Kōenji’s father, nor did I care, but I wanted him to handle the hassle on his own.

“I’m sorry, but I have an appointment after the three-way meeting. I’ll have to decline.”

The man had approached under the guise of coincidence, but it seemed that Kōenji's father had seen through him.

It was unlikely that he'd back down easily, but it remained to be seen how he'd respond.

"...I see. I'm very interested in this appointment that you're mentioning, Company President Kōenji."

That man spoke as he raised his face, seeming to have already done his research and grasped the internal situation, making a veiled threat.

By now, the supposedly coincidental meeting was practically exposed as a lie. He knew full well that this wouldn't leave a good impression. If he could force a conversation, he believed he could drag it onto his own grounds.

"Looks like it's time, so if you'll excuse me."

As Kōenji's father said this, that man slowly made way.

As they passed each other, for a moment, my eyes met with Kōenji's father's.

The sharpness and intensity of his gaze were even stronger than Ayanokōji Atsuomi's. You could say that it was a manifestation of confidence emanating from a perfected physique, not just mere status or title.

Though he should be past his physical prime in his 40s or 50s, I could sense that he was an immeasurably formidable person. Kōenji's talent was undoubtedly inherited from this man.

"For a child, you seem—"

It seemed like he was about to say something to me, but he didn't continue. Without stopping, he headed straight to the counseling room down the hall.

"It won't be easy to catch hold of him. Well, it shouldn't be."

"I knew from the start that you weren't interested in my three-way meeting, but it looks like your goal was to meet Kōenji's father."

Having noticed that my name was scheduled next to Kōenji's, he decided to come to school on short notice.

The timing of the meeting had shifted, though it was unlikely due to this man's instructions. However, if the date or time of Kōenji's three-way meeting had been significantly different, he might not have come.

"That man is arguably the biggest supporter of the Citizen's Party. He doesn't show his face or speak out, but he contributes money. He's a major client for the Citizen's Party."

This meant that, for that man, he was supporting an enemy.

"If we could get him to switch sides, the situation would change significantly."

"Then it wouldn't have to be at a school, right?"

“That wouldn’t work. His private life is shrouded in secrecy, and he spends most of his time abroad. Even if someone really tried to catch hold of him, it couldn’t easily be done.”

*So that’s why he came flying*. He knew this elusive man would show up here.

“Still, he brushed me off pretty easily.”

That man seemed unconcerned and took a call.

“...Yes. I’ll adjust to that.”

He finished a brief exchange and hung up.

Then, without saying anything to me, he started descending the stairs.

Having successfully made contact, it was evident that any more time spent with me had now become nothing but a waste.

I had no intention of walking down the stairs by his side, so I just watched him go.

# 3

As I watched his back descend the stairs, Kōenji Rokusuke, the son, appeared as if to replace him. He advanced down the hallway where I was, humming a tune.

I thought he would just pass by, but as the humming stopped, so did his long legs.

"Ayanokōji boy, could I have a little of your time?"

"Yeah. It's rare for you to approach me first."

"Is it inconvenient for you to be speaking with me?"

"No. I just didn't think you were that type of person, so I was surprised."

Kōenji smirked and brushed his hair back.

"I thought I'd give you a little warning. Lately, you've been taking some conspicuous moves."

"Conspicuous moves? I don't know what you're talking about."

"There's no need to play dumb, right? For example, the end-of-year special exam."

From his tone, it seemed that this one case wasn't the only thing he had in mind.

"The matter with Maezono? That was a choice I had to make to win for the class. I explained the circumstances after the exam, didn't I?"

Kōenji continued with a fearless smile.

"Do you remember when I told you before that I couldn't see either truth or lies in you?"

"Well, I wonder about that."

"Your words are often mixed with impurities. You claim that you just had to deal with the traitor for the sake of the class's victory. However, isn't this just an excuse for you to do as you please?"

"It seems I'm being terribly misunderstood."

This was his unique perspective on me—different from that of Kushida's or Karuizawa's.

"You might deceive the masses, but it won't work on me."

For some reason, Kōenji took out a hand mirror and held it up in front of me.

"Take a look at your expression in this mirror. Doesn't it clearly reflect the truth?"

In the mirror, I just saw my usual self.

"Sorry, but I don't understand. A mirror is just a mirror. It only reflects what's in front of it."

“It appears that what we see is different. No, maybe you see it but pretend not to.”

“In the first place, you didn’t have any interest in the class, right Kōenji? It shouldn’t matter to you what happens to anyone. So why bother giving a warning?”

“If flies and mosquitoes keep buzzing around in front of your eyes, wouldn’t you try to wave them away with your hand, even if you had no interest in them? It’s just like that.”

“In that case, there’s no need to hold back. If it’s an eyesore, the quickest way is to knock them down.”

I suggested that he handle it himself rather than bothering to give warnings.

“But you won’t do that, will you? Even if it’s a bit annoying, there’s no direct harm.”

Kōenji had never been one to initiate action himself.

Unless it was a situation similar to when Yamauchi or Hirata went on a rampage and physically attacked someone, he wouldn’t bother.

“I’ll take your advice. However, I will act solely on my own thoughts.”

Trying to forcibly push through the thicket yielded no significant change in Kōenji’s attitude.

“You can do as you like from now on. Whether you dissect someone’s mind and heart, when and where you do it, and how you pursue your desires is all up to you. If you lack power, you will be trampled by the strong. That’s the fate of the weak. In that world, neither morals nor common sense apply. Those who cannot stop it have no right to complain.”

That’s right. Kōenji Rokusuke was that kind of person.

That was why I had doubts about why he stopped here.

The three-way meeting was about to start. It wasn’t the time for leisurely discussion.

Yet, he had deliberately given a warning.

Since he made a point of comparing me to an annoying, buzzing presence, I must’ve been affecting him somehow.

“If you’re holding back your true intentions, then don’t hesitate to say them. I’m already taking the time to be here.”

I decided to probe Kōenji’s reaction further.

Among the class, handling this man remained a source of trouble until the very end.

I needed to confirm whether he should be eliminated for Horikita’s sake.

“It seems you really intend to become the villain.”

“Do you understand my intentions?”

“I can see it as if I’m holding it in my hand. I’m a bit intuitive, you know?”

Intuitive or not, the real reason didn't matter at this point. Further discussion would hardly cause any inconvenience. It was too late for any problems to arise now.

"When I first entered this school, I thought being a normal student was enough. I thought it'd be fine to just complete the three years as an ordinary student. However, as school life repeated, I found something I wanted to do. Now, I'm thinking of pursuing it. I don't want the competition for Class A to end with just one or two contenders. I want to continue it into an endless game among three or four classes. That's all there is to it."

"So you're transferring classes to forcibly balance things out."

As expected, it seemed Kōenji knew that I was considering a plan to leave the class.

"I won't deny it. Whether it can be realized depends on what happens next. But aside from transferring, I'm willing to do anything to maintain the balance among the classes."

"You can do as you like. But I hope you're satisfied just playing with your Little Girl and Dragon Boy."

"I apologize, but I can't guarantee that things will stay within those limits. Just as with Sakura and Maezono, if I judge it necessary, I won't hesitate to expel Wan Mei-Yui as well."

For Kōenji, who embodied absolute egoism, Mii-chan's existence stood as perhaps the only exception.

Kōenji, who had maintained an unchanged expression throughout, slightly moved his eyebrows.

"Huhuhu."

Kōenji was the only one who laughed as if he was amused.

"I've indicated many times that I'm not interested—do you want me that badly?"

It seemed that the provocation was well received.

"Who knows? I never once told you that you had to do anything."

Our gazes crossed.

I knew very well that he wasn't fixated on Class A.

I couldn't do anything from the inside, but once I was out, the situation would change drastically.

If I left Horikita's class, the situation would change significantly for Kōenji.

"Stop it. I acknowledge your unusual resourcefulness to some extent, but it's not a level that would work on me. Even the numbers and letters that dance on paper will embarrass you if I get serious."

In other words, he was saying that he could surpass me even in a battle of academics.

"If it's just empty words, even Ike or Hondō could say them. Can you actually prove it?"

"I don't feel like proving it. I intentionally learn only the minimum necessary from conventional studies. If I perfect my thoughts based solely on the knowledge the world has produced, my thinking would become rigid. That would be uninteresting and I'd lack individuality. It's obvious when I look at you."

Indeed, I absorbed a lot of the knowledge accumulated in this world.

I used that knowledge as a basis to think and construct everything.

"Because I remain ignorant, I can reach my own unique answers."

He seemed to have a very unique way of thinking, but what he said probably wasn't a lie.

Indeed. Kōenji, despite having high learning capabilities, seemed to deliberately refrain from absorbing everything.

Kōenji put away the mirror into his pocket and started walking.

It'd be interesting if he started acting in a way that was actually helpful to Horikita instead of acting like a hindrance, but whether that day would come was still unknown.

*For now, it remains unclear.*

# 4

In the chairman's office, standing with a proper posture and tense expression was Sakayanagi, who usually presided over this room.

After greeting Kijima, the first visitor, a heavy silence continued in the room.

After a period of tension so thick you couldn't even sigh, there was a knock, followed by a door opening.

It was the signal that Sakayanagi's eagerly awaited second visitor had arrived.

"Prime Minister Kijima, your guest has arrived."

Upon receiving word from the man in black, Kijima signaled with his fingertips to let them into the room.

Immediately after, a tall man, Kōenji, appeared.

Kijima stood up immediately and extended his hand towards Kōenji, who approached with strong strides.

"It's been a while, Kōenji-san. I've been looking forward to meeting you."

"Good. Me too, Prime Minister Kijima. It's been three years, hasn't it?"

"Yes, it has."

Both smiled and exchanged a firm handshake before taking their seats.

"It seems your efforts are going well, Prime Minister Kijima."

"All thanks to your efforts, Kōenji-san. I can do as I like without worrying about what's behind me."

"The higher your position, the more you are attacked by both friends and foes."

"Yes, I understand that's how the world of politics is. The troubles are unavoidable."

"I'm truly glad that a leader capable of competing with the world has emerged."

*They respect each other.*

Even Sakayanagi, who merely intended to listen closely, quickly understood that.

"Please wait, sir! You can't do that!"

Just as the voice of a flustered man in black was heard from outside the chairman's office, the door opened forcefully.

"Excuse me."

Ayanokōji Atsuomi barged in shortly after both parties had taken their seats.

Sakayanagi was surprised, but Kijima and Kōenji showed no signs of being disturbed.

"Ah, Ayanokōji-sens—!"

He paused, correcting himself.

"… Ayanokōji-san, we are currently handling a guest—"

Sakayanagi reluctantly made up his mind to turn him away. He took a step forward, but Kijima subtly raised his hand to stop him. Then, showing his straight white teeth, he gently spread his arms as if to welcome him.

"I don't mind at all. We should enjoy these unexpected occurrences once in a while."

Saying this, Kijima sought Kōenji's approval with his gaze.

"My, my... Prime Minister Kijima. I never dreamed I'd find you visiting such a place."

Ayanokōji feigned surprise, and Kijima continued with a calm expression.

"There's nothing particularly shocking. I have experience as the Minister of Education, Culture, Sports, Science and Technology. I've also contributed to the Advanced Nurturing High School quite modestly. Besides, it's well-known that I'm close with Company President Kōenji. As a member of the Diet, you should know that, Ayanokōji-san."

*(TL Note: A "Diet" is a formal assembly for deliberation.)*

Kijima asked Ayanokōji, seemingly wanting to gauge his reaction.

"I'm honored that you remember me."

Ayanokōji, once a key figure in the Citizens' Party and labeled as the right-hand man of the now-deceased Naoe, had been ousted from the political world. However, he changed parties and returned to the public stage. He had a certain pride in his notoriety.

"Is he a famous man?"

Kōenji asked Kijima, who then briefly closed his eyes and smiled softly.

"Whether he's famous doesn't matter. Remembering the names and faces of all the Diet members is natural for a prime minister entrusted with a country."

He emphasized that he remembered Ayanokōji merely as an individual, not for his achievements or contributions.

Kijima was well aware that such a statement alone could internally irritate a politician with a strong desire to promote themselves.

"You have quite a sense of humor, Prime Minister Kijima. You remember the names and faces of all the members?"

"Of course."

Kijima answered as if it were obvious, though the number of Diet members well exceeded 700.

*Was it true or false?* While Ayanokōji immediately judged it a lie, he had no means to verify whether this statement was true in his current situation.

"Well then. Shall we hear what your business here might be, Ayanokōji-san?"

“I’ve taken the liberty to come here as I wished to speak with Company President Kōenji. I heard he’d be here.”

“From whom?”

Resting his chin on his arm propped on the armrest, Kōenji spoke in an intimidating manner.

“Well, I don’t know the details, but I think they’re an employee at this school. They must’ve seen you here by chance.”

Of course, this wasn’t true at all. He had simply caught wind that Kijima and Kōenji would be meeting at this location and at this time after the end-of-year special exam. This exchange was nothing more than a pretense.

In this small space, and with so few people, it was unusual to have a chance to speak with Kijima.

For Ayanokōji, who didn’t mind being disliked, it was a good opportunity to assess them.

Compared to his younger days, Kijima’s appearance gave off a weaker impression—he didn’t feel particularly threatening. So much so that some might be inclined to believe they could easily crush him.

Many would think that Kōenji, sitting next to him, emitted a far more overwhelming presence.

However, Ayanokōji simultaneously sensed that such naive thinking could be fatal.

With an air of innocence to him, this Kijima had accomplished everything.

“However, *Mister* Ayanokōji. I thought I declined your proposal?”

“I’m quite persistent. I came to ask if you could somehow make time.”

“By pushing past the security and barging in forcefully?”

“That’s just my nature.”

At this point, Kōenji also began to reassess the brazen man before him.

And Ayanokōji did the same. This was a valuable time to determine whether they were worth recruiting as allies, or if they needed to be eliminated as enemies.

“I wouldn’t advise it, Ayanokōji-san. It’d be better to find another opportunity...”

Sakayanagi intervened, trying to help Ayanokōji. He felt that he couldn’t stay silent any longer.

But far from backing down, Ayanokōji pressed further.

If there was no goodwill to lose, then it’d be a loss not to step forward.

“Perhaps you two were in the middle of an important business discussion?”

“No, no. I just came to see an old friend, that’s all.”

Seeing Kijima gently deny it, Ayanokōji nodded in understanding.

“Then, I’d like to join in the conversation here, if I may.”

“A bold man—you must have many enemies.”

Kōenji was adversed to people like Ayanokōji, but he began to appreciate his fearless courage.

"Yes. Regardless of whether someone's friend or foe, I speak my mind."

"It must be tough for the prime minister with many politicians like this."

"He once worked under Naoe-san, whom I respect more than anyone. I'm not surprised he has this much courage."

Kijima smiled slyly and showed a positive attitude towards Ayanokōji's stance.

At the same time, Ayanokōji tightened his focus again.

Indeed, this man knew him. He didn't just recognize him as some low-ranking politician.

"If Company President Kōenji agrees, shall we continue our conversation a bit longer? I'm interested in you, Ayanokōji-san. Please, have a seat."

Kijima invited him to sit, but Ayanokōji declined.

"I'm fine standing. Considering my position, this suits me better."

After politely refusing, Kijima checked with Kōenji.

He didn't seem welcoming, but Kōenji consented to Ayanokōji staying.

"Your son attends this school, I believe... His name is Kiyotaka-kun, right?"

"To think that you'd know my son's name."

"I remember more than just the names of politicians."

Ayanokōji listened to Kijima's words without a flicker of emotion, but Sakayanagi showed a slight disturbance.

He hadn't thought Kijima was paying that much attention, even though he observed the entire exam.

"Actually, I visited the school recently. At that time, I wanted to see Company President Kōenji's son, so I watched the special exam for second-year students—I remember your son because he was quite a standout student."

Internally, Ayanokōji replied saying that he knew everything. However, he didn't show it. The fact that Kijima had been watching the special exam was supposed to be known only to Kijima and school officials.

Even the chairman, Sakayanagi, had no idea that Ayanokōji knew the details of the exam.

But Ayanokōji saw this as an opportunity.

"How did my son appear to you, Prime Minister Kijima?"

It was just a one-time, seemingly playful exam among children.

Yet, having recognized Kiyotaka's existence, he was genuinely interested in his impressions.

And what kind of evaluation he would give.

"He seemed like he could become a better politician than you currently are."

Kijima promptly expressed his evaluation of Kiyotaka.

It seemed like a compliment to his son, but in reality, it was the opposite. He implied that Ayanokōji was less of a politician than a child.

"To receive such high regard from the prime minister himself. As a parent, nothing could make me happier."

Ayanokōji deliberately took the words at face value and expressed his gratitude and joy.

"Your efforts must've played a part. Did you provide him with special education?"

"Nothing special. It's all thanks to the education at this school."

Kijima had hinted at the White Room, but since the topic had shifted to his son, he wasn't caught off guard.

"I understand you want to talk, but unfortunately, I support the Citizen's Party. You said you're from the Kōei Party?"

"Yes. However, I was once a member of the Citizen's Party, like Prime Minister Kijima."

Since Kijima became prime minister, despite some fluctuations, the Citizen's Party has maintained consistently high approval ratings, suggesting the possibility of a long-term administration. Meanwhile, Ayanokōji's Kōei Party was in an extremely weak position, reduced to a party that does little more than heckle from the sidelines.

"From the flow of the conversation, I think I can guess, but why did you leave the party?"

"There seemed to be people who would find it inconvenient if I remained with the Citizen's Party."

Even with the leader of the Citizen's Party right in front of him, Ayanokōji held nothing back.

"Ayanokōji-san, you seem capable of speaking your mind. Naoe-sensei praised that about you, but he was also concerned. Regardless of the party, if you return to politics, you should avoid saying anything that could lead to misunderstandings."

"I'm honored to be receiving advice directly from the prime minister. However, I'm recognized and supported for my blunt speech. I intend to continue speaking and acting on my thoughts without resorting to sophistry or convenience."

"I see. Then, if I may ask one thing—if it were possible, would you wish to rejoin the Citizen's Party?"

"No, I'm not considering it at this time."

Even if Ayanokōji expressed interest, Kijima wouldn't say yes to his request. At most, he would suggest proceeding with the paperwork, but it was clear he'd be rejected by the executive committee.

Changing parties as a district representative was technically allowed, but for Ayanokōji, switching back to the Citizen's Party wasn't easy. If it were, he wouldn't have run under the Kōei Party in the first place.

"So, you plan to change Japanese politics from the Kōei Party?"

"That's right. It might seem impossible to someone affiliated with a major party like you, Prime Minister Kijima. However, are you aware of the pendulum law? Currently, the political world is heavily leaning in the direction you aim for. Whether it's to the right or left doesn't matter here. What's certain is that I stand exactly opposite to you."

The next time the political world were to make a drastic shift, the pendulum would sing decisively in his direction.

Ayanokōji answered with such conviction.

"You're quite bold to be speaking as an equal in front of the sitting prime minister, *Mister* Ayanokōji."

"I am in a situation where I have nothing to fear. I have no intention whatsoever of simply being wary of others' reactions and clinging to my seat as a member of Diet after all."

"Ayanokōji-san. I trust that you understand that you are currently a member of the Kyōei Party, right?"

The difference between the Shimin Party and the Kyōei Party stood as a large gap.

He warned Ayanokōji that there was no place for him to curry favor with Kōenji.

"I'm not sure what you mean. Could you be more specific?"

"That's enough. Prime Minister Kijima may have been considerate, but I do not judge people by good or evil, nor solely by their political party. I judge only by whether a person is competent. And at least at this point, it can be said that you have no advantages over Prime Minister Kijima, *Mister* Ayanokōji. Not only will I not lend a hand, but you're also not worth even listening to."

"Your harsh words are painful to hear."

"Ayanokōji-san, Company President Kōenji is a capable man. However, do you know why such a man doesn't do dealings with you? It isn't because he's close to me. You were once ousted but were re-elected by the people. That means you are trusted by a certain layer of society. The direction and manner of the country can naturally differ regardless of whether the parties are the same. However, the people are not fools. It would be wise not to think they would meaninglessly support someone whose ambition is transparent."

Kijima broke down Kōenji's words and explained.

"I gave you some time thinking this might turn interesting, but any more would be a waste. Perhaps you should leave now, *Mister* Ayanokōji. You're a boring man."

"I apologize for disappointing your expectations."

Although no tangible results were achieved, he managed to establish his presence.

"It seems better to excuse myself now."

The door was something he had forced open to begin with. Considering it was the right time, he began to retreat.

"Your son led his class to victory in the recent special exam. He will undoubtedly become someone excellent. Let's talk about this again sometime."

"Thank you, Prime Minister Kijima. I look forward to that opportunity."

Saying this, he bowed and turned back towards the door he had been facing.

Kōenji, who had found Ayanokōji dull from start to finish, showed interest for the first time.

"You're saying that much, Prime Minister Kijima? As a parent, this isn't something I can ignore."

"Company President Kōenji, your son is also very talented."

Hearing this, Ayanokōji, who had just turned around, stopped.

"Earlier, when the three-way meetings took place, Kiyotaka said he would be moving classes. That means he'll be in a different class from your son from now on, Company President Kōenji. It seems they will be competing."

This fact was something that, at present, only Ayanokōji knew. Even Chairman Sakayanagi was surprised.

"I-Is that so, Ayanokōji-san?"

"Yes. I heard it directly from my son, so there's no mistake."

"Even though he could've moved up to Class A, he's moving to a lower class...?"

"My son is very talented. And he creates and executes ideas that ordinary people cannot fathom. There's no one in this school who can match him, so he is setting challenges for himself."

If Kōenji saw his son as capable, this would be a clever provocation.

Ayanokōji's aim had a much greater effect than imagined.

"I see. I did feel something interesting in him at that time… *Mister* Sakayanagi."

"Y-Yes?"

"If it's true that *Mister* Ayanokōji's son will transfer classes, then when the time comes, I would like you to pass a message to my son, if you don't mind?"

"Of course. What should I convey?"

"Tell him that maintaining his current status as Class A until graduation is the condition for approving his true freedom. He will understand. This will inadvertently make your son and my son compete, *Mister* Ayanokōji."

"U-Understood. But why do you want such a thing?"

"I don't know which class *Mister* Ayanokōji's son will transfer to, but the idea of restarting from a disadvantageous situation is interesting. It's worth paying attention to at least. Besides, it's good to give my son some challenges. Whether he will be a match, I don't know."

"Is it fine to interpret this as you using my son? To have your own learn by training against a more skilled opponent, Company President Kōenji? Showing him an insurmountable wall isn't bad."

Receiving a greater provocation, one of Kōenji's eyebrows slightly twitched.

"Though he's still a chick, Rokusuke is receiving appropriate education."

"I see. So the positions are reversed, after all? It's natural to value your beloved son highly, but the same applies here. However, we lack the material to judge who's more talented."

Before anyone else could speak, Ayanokōji continued.

"May I propose a bet here? If Kiyotaka prevents your son's class from graduating as Class A, I would like to meet with you again. And this time, in a one-on-one situation without any interferences."

Regardless of their titles as politician and company president, they would compete over their sons' excellence.

Kōenji, for the first time, smiled.

"*Mister* Ayanokōji seems unexpectedly interesting. Very well, but if that doesn't happen, are you willing to permanently resign from your position as a Diet member?"

Upon hearing those words, Ayanokōji's expression momentarily turned stern.

As silence followed, Kōenji smiled again, raising the corners of his mouth.

"It's a joke—you don't need to take it so seriously. No, rather, the fact that you didn't answer right away was a mature and rational decision, let's say."

Kōenji repeated a dry applause two or three times.

Although Ayanokōji's brain intuitively felt he should answer yes, he actually judged things calmly. He believed that there was no chance Kiyotaka would lose in terms of individual ability, but it was clear that he wasn't particularly attached to Class A, and it wasn't clear what he was trying to achieve at school. Moreover, he was concerned about Kiyotaka taking Kōenji's side on the off chance that his careless decision were to be leaked.

"You're quite tolerant, aren't you, Kōenji-san?"

Without paying any mind to the fact that his greatest supporter might be taken by hostile forces, Kijima, rather as an observer, asked with interest.

"Enjoyment is necessary in life."

"Indeed."

“I will be leaving Japan again. Let me know when the results are clear. If your son wins, I will gladly return to the country.”

“I will contact you with the results myself, Company President Kōenji.”

Kijima declared that he stood as a witness to this occasion.

# 5

After leaving the school, Ayanokōji got into the back seat of the black sedan waiting outside the main gate.

"Good work. How was Prime Minister Kijima?"

Tsukishiro asked, looking back at Ayanokōji from the driver's seat.

"He's a shrewd man. His capabilities were certainly conveyed."

However, he wasn't able to measure it completely—solely because he couldn't see the bottom of it.

Still, for Ayanokōji, this was undoubtedly worthwhile.

"He is, after all, the leader of the Citizen's Party, where monsters nest."

Tsukishiro, who long had connections with the Citizen's Party, understood this well.

"I thought meeting him directly would stir things up a bit more."

"Many are deceived by his ordinary appearance, but he's undoubtedly the real deal. Still, you managed to forcibly impose your presence, didn't you?"

Ayanokōji crossed his arms and gave instructions to drive.

"Politicians are full of pride. He must've thought that breaking mine would tame me."

Despite indirect attempts to provoke him, Ayanokōji remained unperturbed.

"That must've been somewhat of a miscalculation on Prime Minister Kijima's part. After all, you have no pride to protect. By the way, while you were visiting the school, I also watched the footage of the recent special exam. Your son seems to be developing well. His ruthless manipulation of women's emotions—perhaps he takes after you in that regard."

Tsukishiro had secretly contacted school officials beforehand and obtained the exam video.

Ayanokōji had also watched the video before facing today's situation, so he could handle even the information known only to Kijima without being disturbed.

"He'll use any means to survive. It's just as he was taught."

"It was hard to obtain the data, but keeping it would bring us no benefit. Shall we dispose of it?"

At a traffic signal, Tsukishiro took a flash drive and showed it to Ayanokōji in the back seat. Then, he snapped it in two and threw it as trash in the center cup holder.

"How about Company President Kōenji?"

"He seems more invested in Kijima than I imagined. It's clear that their relationship wasn't built overnight."

*And Kōenji's personal instincts aren't to be underestimated.*

“With the prime minister’s capabilities and strong backing, the Citizen’s Party will be safe for the decade”

“If nothing happens. But in this world, no matter how high your position or how capable you are, you can’t defy reason. Sometimes, you fall before unexpected circumstances…”

“There’s always a shadow where there’s light. That is very much like you, Ayanokōji-san.”

“And there was an unexpected return.”

“Oh? A return?”

If Kiyotaka were to defeat the class where Kōenji’s son resided in, Ayanokōji could meet Kōenji.

It was a playful bet, but if realized, there was no doubt that he was a man who kept his promises.

An opportunity to converse without interferences would be an unparalleled chance for Ayanokōji to win him over.

“To think that there might be a chance for Kiyotaka to be useful from here on out. Indeed, you never know anything that’ll happen unless you take action.”

Ayanokōji didn’t have excessive expectations, but if luck came his way, he wouldn’t miss seizing it.

# Chapter 8:
# Celebration

After changing clothes and checking the news on my phone, the sound of the rice cooker signaling that rice was ready echoed through the room. For the past week, I had been taking shortcuts with my meals, either eating out or getting convenience store food. However, starting today, I would revitalize my home cooking lifestyle.

When I opened the rice cooker lid, the aroma of freshly cooked rice softly permeated the air.

The aroma that stirred up my appetite was caused by compounds called carbonyl, produced when amino acids, created from the breakdown of proteins in rice, reacted with sugars, created from the breakdown of starches.

I picked up a bowl with my left hand and held a rice paddle in my right.

Then, I prepared a regular serving of rice in my bowl and placed it on the tray.

Next, I subconsciously reached out with my left hand for another bowl to get a smaller serving of rice… but grabbed at empty air.

"Right, that's no longer necessary."

It seemed that remnants of a habit I had developed over the past few months had surfaced.

I added side dishes and miso soup to the tray and carried it to the living room table.

Looking back, the room had become considerably more barren compared to a few days ago.

From the time we started dating up until the other day, Karuizawa's belongings had gradually been increasing.

Unsurprisingly, it all disappeared at once and my room returned to its original state.

Incidentally, several of Karuizawa's friends came to pick up the accumulated belongings.

Satō, Sonoda, and Ishikura. The person herself probably still couldn't face me, but it was good that she had friends to help her.

Among them, Satō still seemed concerned about whether Karuizawa had really been the one to break up with me, but on the outside, the apparent fact remained unchanged.

I ended up repeatedly explaining that I was the one who'd been dumped.

I was aware that continuing to deny it so firmly would be tactless.

That was the best choice. Karuizawa Kei, while clumsy, was blessed with good looks, friends, and a position in the class. On the other hand, I was more on the shadowy side. It would only be a stain on her future to make it seem like I

was the one to initiate the breakup with Karuizawa, especially since she wasn't at fault.

While eating breakfast with the TV on, my phone screen lit up.

*['Good morning. If you have some time today, can we meet?']*

That message appeared.

As I thought about marking it as read after finishing my meal, another message followed.

*['You must have some free time now that you've been dumped, right?']*

"So the news has reached Horikita's ears too."

*I thought it'd take a little longer to spread since it's spring break, considering there's no school...*

Perhaps the speed of the girls' network was indeed comparable to the speed of light.

Reluctantly, I picked up my phone to reply.

*['I can meet anytime after 10 o'clock.']*

*['Let's meet at 11 at the café in Keyaki Mall.']*

After this kind of back-and-forth exchange happened twice, we arranged to meet up.

# 1

I met up with Horikita at the entrance of Keyaki Mall, and we arrived at the café.

However, the café was bustling today, fully occupied, and there were several groups of people waiting.

“That’s troublesome.”

“Should we wait or should we relocate? I’m fine with either.”

I left the decision of whether to write our names on the waiting list to Horikita, who slightly hesitated.

“...Alright, let’s change the location. Maybe just find a bench or something?”

Since I had no particular issue with that, I followed Horikita’s suggestion, and we moved.

A bench near the vending machines by the second-floor restroom was available, so we sat there.

“I’ll treat you.”

“Really? If that’s the case, I would’ve preferred being treated at the café. Shall we go back?”

“If we were at the café, I wouldn’t be treating you. Shall we go back?”

“...I see.”

“So, what will you do? I won’t stop you if you want to buy with your own money.”

“Then, an unsweetened coffee, hot.”

Since talking back would mean not getting treated, I decided to request her politely.

Honestly, I could see myself becoming strapped for cash in the future, so I wanted to save every penny.

Horikita bought two of the same drinks from the vending machine and handed one to me.

“Enjoy it while it’s warm. It should hit the spot for someone that’s single.”

“Is that meant to comfort or provoke me? Which is it?”

“Which one could it be?”

She was probably—no, definitely, provoking.

After intently staring at me, Horikita tilted her head curiously.

“Is it true that you and Karuizawa-san have broken up? I honestly can’t believe it.”

“There’s nothing to hide, so I’ll answer. It’s true. Where did you hear that from?”

“Kushida-san was quite excited to tell me, saying you were dumped pretty badly. Should I give you the details?”

For future reference, I wanted to confirm how the story had spread.

“I’d appreciate it if you did.”

“While crying and screaming that you didn’t want to break up, you desperately clung to Karuizawa-san’s legs or something.”

*That seems a bit, no, tremendously exaggerated...*

“I can’t imagine someone as calm as you doing such a thing, but maybe it’s true?”

“Ahh—”

“Just kidding. Even Kushida-san didn’t know exactly how the breakup went.”

I chose a karaoke room, mindful of the public eye.

Of course, if Karuizawa had explained it that way, I would’ve had no choice but to resign and accept it.

Still, I naturally would’ve wanted to deny the rumor if it went that far, so I was relieved for now.

I had been prepared to some extent, but there were limits. It was indeed a great learning experience.

“Anyway, I guess I wasn’t a good match for her.”

“Really? It didn’t seem like that. I thought Karuizawa-san cared about you a lot.”

“Women are actors, I guess. Or maybe she found someone better.”

At my casual explanation, Horikita made a troubled expression.

“I can’t deny that possibility...”

“What’s with that meaningful look?”

“I thought you’d be down, and I was kind of looking forward to seeing it, but you seem fine.”

*If it’s a minor matter, you could’ve settled with a message or a phone call.*

“Did you say you wanted to meet just to check how I was doing?”

“That’s right.”

*What a nasty personality.*

“It’s not my place to comment on matters of love, so let’s leave it at that.”

“Please do.”

At this point, Horikita finally got to the main topic.

“After the special exam ended, there was the issue with Maezono-san, so the mood wasn’t exactly celebratory, right? Even now, everyone seems a bit unsettled.”

“Well, maybe you’re right. Everyone just focused on the chaotic situations in the other classes.”

Under normal circumstances, considering this kind of result, it would've made sense for us to be happy and celebrate our victory.

But now, the talk was all about how the lower classes were shifting.

"Yes. That's why I thought, before we become third years, we should have a small celebration for our promotion with everyone in class."

"A celebration for our promotion?"

"Nothing fancy. Just getting everyone together for a toast."

She wanted to hear what I thought about it.

"It's hard for other students to initiate something like this, isn't it?"

"That's true."

This time, Maezono had been expelled as a cost of winning.

Until spring break, a tense atmosphere continued to linger in the class.

Horikita thought that alleviating it, even a little, would be best.

"Not a bad idea—no, it's a rather good one. But where would we do it?"

"If nearly 40 people gather, we might bother others if we choose a poor location, right? So, I was thinking about using a classroom at school on a day off. It won't cost much, just drinks. How about next Friday?"

Since all club activities would be on break that day, it was the perfect date.

Now, it was just a matter of getting the school's approval.

"Agreed."

"Will you also participate?"

"There's no reason to refuse."

"Good, that's settled then."

She seemed happy and relieved, but her expression gradually darkened.

"There's another reason I called you here. You might think it's presumptuous of me to say this."

Horikita started to speak but fell silent for a few seconds, seeming to struggle with her words.

"I was a little worried about whether you were doing okay emotionally."

"Emotionally?"

"You prioritized winning for the sake of the class. As a result, Maezono-san was expelled. That decision puts a lot of burden on you."

"I was the one who wanted to take on the role of the general. There's no need for you to worry about it, Horikita."

"It's not just this time. It was the same with Sakura-san's case. You took on roles nobody else wanted to bear to help the class, right?"

Horikita looked at me, her eyes faintly trembling.

"Because I'm weak, I've forced an incredible burden on you..."

"I did all those things on my own. You absolutely don't need to feel responsible."

“I can feel it. I can’t help but feel it. But I also understand my own inability. I want to at least support you emotionally. If you’re feeling the strain, I want you to talk to me honestly and let me be of help to you.”

I understood what Horikita wanted to say.

Indeed, if other students had taken the same actions as me, many of them would’ve been emotionally hurt.

Unfortunately, I didn’t possess such emotions.

What was efficient and what wasn’t.

Who to eliminate and who to keep.

I judged like a machine.

There was no need to make Horikita understand that emotion, nor did I want her to.

No, even if I told her the truth here, it might just look like I’m putting a brave front to her.

“I understand what you’re saying, but I’m still okay. If it becomes too much, I’ll definitely consult with you.”

“...Really?”

“Sorry to make you worry.”

“That’s not it at all... I just wanted to be of help to you.”

“What you’re saying could be misleading.”

“...Misleading?”

Not understanding the implication, Horikita tilted her head.

“It sounded somewhat like a confession.”

“...What?”

“Since I’m officially single now, are we putting your name forward as a potential girlfriend candidate?”

By touching on this specifically, Horikita seemed to understand what I was implying.

“...Hah, you’ve started to say some rather ridiculous things, haven’t you?”

She glared at me, accompanied by a sigh.

“Rather than the expulsion matter, I’m just putting on a brave front to hide my heartbreak from being dumped. Forgive me.”

“That’s the part I just can’t understand—you don’t seem that way at all.”

After that, we continued to chat for a while even after our cans were empty.

# 2

On the way home, Horikita parted with Ayanokōji, who stopped by a bookstore, and headed to the dormitory alone.

The warm spring breeze blew softly, swaying her long hair through the wind.

"A girlfriend candidate, huh?"

She thought it to be quite a silly joke, but upon reflection, she realized it had already been two years since she met Ayanokōji.

It was no wonder that they naturally became close enough to joke around with each other.

Still, there were things that bothered her.

"But he's the only one I've become able to talk that way with."

It was because Horikita couldn't talk to everyone the way she talked to Ayanokōji.

Not to Kushida, not to Ibuki, nor to anyone else.

There was a part of her that couldn't fully trust them.

She realized that Ayanokōji had something that didn't apply to classmates or friends.

He was closer than anyone else and had continued to watch over her.

Those certain two years had removed the barriers she had towards Ayanokōji.

"But still, being his girlfriend…"

*Ridiculous.*

While thinking that, Horikita faintly felt her heartbeat quicken.

A trivial bodily signal that she wouldn't have noticed if her surroundings were noisy.

"...What was that just now...?"

An unfamiliar discomfort in her heart.

*Nervousness?*

She immediately dismissed that thought, realizing it was different.

*Then, what was causing my heartbeat to speed up?*

She recalled the pompous words Ayanokōji left, who was no longer in sight.

*'Since I'm officially single now, are we putting your name forward as a potential girlfriend candidate?'*

*What an incomprehensible, condescending attitude.*

*Moreover, why should I declare myself a girlfriend candidate to someone I don't even like?*

*What does it mean to like someone?*

*What does it mean not to like someone?*

Could she, who had never been conscious of the opposite sex, understand that?

"No, it's just a joke anyway, so it's silly to take it seriously."

Even though she tried to shake off such distracting thoughts, she was unsuccessful.

An indescribable, murky emotion.

"...No good, I should stop thinking."

Horikita decided to empty her mind.

She understood that thinking further would only end up getting her bogged down deeper in her thoughts.

# Chapter 9:
# The Promised Night

GOING BRIEFLY BACK IN TIME, from the beginning of April to the end of March.

That day, I had been active since before 7 AM. There were time-consuming matters that required my attention.

As 8 AM approached, the news program started on the TV that I turned on earlier.

While using it as background noise in my room, I sent a message to Ichinose.

*['I'll be out until about 3 PM today, but come to my room at any time you like after that.']*

The message didn't contain anything detailed.

There was a promise that had been reiterated repeatedly from last year until recently.

There wasn't a need to explain in depth now.

Of course, it was true that the situation had changed substantially when comparing how things were like before and after the end-of-year special exam.

Ichinose had apparently developed a fever after it, missed the closing ceremony, and hadn't shown herself outside at all during spring break.

The damage I inflicted was significant. Instead of being recovered, she was still deeply wounded.

The message I sent remained unread.

Whether she was sleeping, pretending not to notice despite being awake, or something else.

I decided to try calling her, but there was no ring.

Only her standard voicemail played, indicating the phone was either turned off or out of signal range.

*['Contact me when you notice.']*

I sent a brief message with that addition.

Ichinose undoubtedly understood that today was the day.

With that in mind, if I didn't hear from Ichinose on this day, I would have to decide on this matter's conclusion on my own.

The TV I was watching was broadcasting the weather forecast, announcing that it'd be clear during the day. However, we were to expect heavy rain from night till dawn.

As I was busy cleaning my room for a while, the phone rang.

For a moment, I thought that it might've been Ichinose calling back, but it seemed to be someone else.

"Hello?"

*'Hey Ayanokōji! Come out now, let's meet up!'*

Ishizaki's voice was so loud that I inadvertently pulled my phone away a bit.

"...Now? It's just past 8 in the morning, you know?"

*'It doesn't matter what time it is, it's spring break. I've got something I want to talk about.'*

"That's true, but... I can spare about an hour. Where should I go?"

When I asked, there was a pause on the other end of the line, as if Ishizaki hadn't decided on a meeting location yet.

*'An hour is fine. The place is, um, outside for now, outside.'*

The invitation was so vague that I felt suspicious that there wasn't a real reason to meet after all.

"Decide on a place at least."

*'What, okay then... outside the dorm... Oh, no, right, let's go to Keyaki Mall.'*

*Keyaki Mall?* It was closed at this hour, so it was obviously impossible to enter. However, because of this, there weren't any students around, making it a surprisingly suitable place when talking about something confidential.

"Got it."

*'Alright. I think I'll be there in about ten minutes. Talk to you later then.'*

With that, Ishizaki hung up the phone.

He seemed to be in high spirits since the morning, which was a bit frightening.

*Well, I'll understand once I go there.*

# 1

Since there wasn't much time until the appointed hour, I immediately left the dorm and headed to Keyaki Mall, as Ishizaki had suggested.

"Well…"

Holding my phone, I tried looking around for Ishizaki, but there was no sign of anyone yet.

Even after another five minutes, there was still no sign of the person who had called me.

I wondered whether to contact him again or just wait silently when—

"Ayanokōji-kun."

I was approached by Shiina Hiyori. The only thing she had in common with Ishizaki was that they shared the same class.

"Good morning. This is a coincidence, isn't it?"

"Indeed."

She responded, but I wondered if it really was a coincidence.

Coming across someone at Keyaki Mall at this time, someone who's classmates with the one who invited me here—that possibility seemed very low.

"Actually, I just got a call from Ishizaki-kun... I came out without understanding much, but are you in the same situation, Ayanokōji-kun?"

It seemed Hiyori was internally harboring the same thoughts as me.

"That's right. Ishizaki called me out too. He didn't tell me what this was going to be about."

Hiyori looked slightly pleased or relieved as she clasped her hands together.

"Me too. But really, what could it be?"

"I'd like to think it's nothing bad..."

"Hey, what's up guys, you're early~"

As Hiyori and I exchanged glances, Ishizaki approached with a carefree tone.

"You're the one who said you'd be here in ten minutes, Ishizaki."

"I went out with just a shirt and it was quite cold. Went back to get more clothes. Then, on the way, I met a friend and… well, don't sweat the small stuff. I'm here now, right?"

"'Small stuff'... well, they are indeed just minor details."

I was usually accustomed to the people I meet arriving on time or even earlier.

*Maybe I'm so used to it that I've become a bit too sensitive about it.*

"Right?"

Watching Ishizaki nodding with a laugh, I found myself thinking.

*Relationships between people change every day, but I feel like he's become quite familiar—no, rather friendly.*

I had experienced a similar feeling with Ishizaki in the past. However, I found my surprise when recalling the changes in our relationship interesting. Whether this was common to everyone or unique to me, who hadn't built social relationships before, I didn't know.

"Good morning, Ishizaki-kun."

After warmly watching our conversation, Hiyori properly greeted Ishizaki too.

"Hey hey, good morning."

"So, why did you call us here?"

When I urged him to continue the conversation, he deliberately paused his words and then gave an exaggerated laugh.

Afterwards, he tightly clenched his fist and held it up in front of me.

"Let's become comrades now!!"

Such a voice echoed around Keyaki Mall early in the morning.

Perhaps due to his echoing voice's volume, a bird perched on a tree flew away.

"Sorry, I might not understand the situation's vibes yet. What is this all about?"

Since there wasn't a proper explanation, I couldn't understand Ishizaki's words and actions.

"Come on! Being comrades means transferring classes—transferring!"

"That's what you wanted to talk about? Without giving any prior notice, this early in the morning?"

"Yeah. It's almost April, so I thought I'd invite you again today."

Ishizaki nodded, crossing his arms and snorting with satisfaction.

"Your invitation is a wonderful idea, Ishizaki-kun. However, Ayanokōji-kun has already moved up to Class A. Unfortunately, I don't think it's possible for him to move down to a lower class now."

Hiyori gently conveyed the current situation to Ishizaki.

It was a straightforward explanation, but Ishizaki wasn't convinced.

"But the class points aren't that far apart. From here, Ryūen-san will surge ahead with tremendous force. Besides, if our class overtakes their class later, and he transfers then, it'll ruin Ayanokōji's reputation, right? It's better if we're still lower now—"

He spoke casually, but Ishizaki's view wasn't bad.

Normally, it was standard to transfer to the established Class A, but if you were to prioritize your future reputation, this timing wouldn't be a poor choice. In fact, I had planned on transferring to another class, just not Ryūen's.

"If we don't invite him now, someone else might take him."

*Seems like Ishizaki's instincts might've sensed the transfer.*

Faced with such a rebuttal, even Hiyori seemed somewhat convinced and showed an impressed expression.

"See? That's why I'm asking you to transfer to our class now, Ayanokōji. I might be repeating myself, but if you and Ryūen-san team up, wouldn't we be the strongest? Right? Right?"

Even if Ishizaki pressured me, there was nothing I could do.

"Sorry, but it's impossible. Or rather, there's no need."

"What do you mean 'no need'?"

When I thought about how to make him obediently accept it, the best method would probably be…

"Recently, Ryūen has defeated Sakayanagi, and he's come much closer to Class A. Even without my power, there's a good chance you can win. Besides, as you've said yourself, Ishizaki, Ryūen will advance even more from here. Then there's no need for reinforcements. Or are you saying Ryūen can't win without me in the future?"

If Ryūen heard this, he would undoubtedly be angry. That was something Ishizaki could easily imagine.

"No, that's not...!"

"That's how it is. You, as his close aide, shouldn't doubt Ryūen. Just believe in his abilities. Since Katsuragi was brought in, the class's gaps have been practically filled."

With this, Ishizaki couldn't push any harder.

"But... but I..."

He showed resistance and stumbled over his words, but he realized that he couldn't continue his poor recruitment.

Since it was unthinkable for Ryūen to choose to team up with me in the future, Ishizaki's invitation could also be said to go against the class leader's will.

"But it's not just that..."

Yet, Ishizaki showed a stern expression while still insisting.

"I simply like you. If our classes are different and we end up fighting in close battles, we'll become complete enemies. There will be zero chance to join hands. But if it's now, with Ryūen-san, Albert, Shiina, and you, Ayanokōji... we can all become comrades. And, I want us all to have a good time. If you nod yes, I'm prepared to get punched by Ryūen-san!"

Now, Ishizaki, who supported Ryūen more than anyone, explained his feelings, risking getting scolded just to keep inviting me, and it wasn't just about abilities.

“It doesn’t feel bad to have you say it like that. I don’t dislike spending time with you and Hiyori. In fact, in some ways, it’s more relaxing than with Horikita’s class.”

“Right!?”

Ishizaki’s eyes sparkled, but I couldn’t keep his hopes up for long.

“However, I can’t transfer classes just for the sake of friendship. Besides, providing the necessary private points is a high hurdle, not to mention whether other classmates besides Ryūen would accept it. Naturally, there would be opposition. Ibuki would definitely oppose it.”

“If it’s just Ibuki, I can shut her up!”

“Ibuki is just one example. If the story suddenly came out, there would be suspicious eyes everywhere. If things went poorly, there might even be students who think I was sent from Horikita’s class to Ryūen’s class in order to sabotage it from within after my transfer.”

Because they were so close to achieving Class A, it was easy to provoke a strong rejection.

“And as Hiyori first mentioned, Horikita’s class is now about to move up to Class A. I’m strongly against taking the risk to move down to a lower class.”

“That is...! Well then! Let’s do this!”

“Do this?”

I intended to steer the conversation towards giving up, but it seemed he still persisted.

I didn’t know what kind of idea he had come up with, but it was pointless. Because of some prior concerns, I had no plans to transfer to Ryūen’s class.

“If you come to our class, you can date Shiina! How about that?”

Saying this, Ishizaki grabbed my hand and Hiyori’s hand and forcibly made us shake hands.

“Eh, eh...?”

Hiyori, who had been smiling at Ishizaki’s reckless proposal, was clearly taken aback by the surprise.

“What kind of proposal is that…?”

Neither of our feelings were considered at all, which was quite bold.

“It’s an aspect your class doesn’t have, but ours does!”

“I already have a girlfriend, you know?”

“So what, just break up with Karuizawa when you change classes!”

“That’s absurd.”

“So you don’t like Shiina then?”

“I don’t dislike her.”

I could assert that point clearly.

“Then there’s no problem, right? You like Ayanokōji too, don’t you, Shiina?”

“Eh...!?”

“It’s better not to say things that’ll trouble others, Ishizaki.”

“No, no, I’m not troubling anyone. Rather, it’s better to say these things outright. If the love is mutual, then the matter’s simple. It’s a win-win relationship.”

His interpretation was forced, but it clearly wasn’t something for Ishizaki to intervene in.

“...I think it’s wrong to trouble Ayanokōji-kun.”

Hiyori tried to calm Ishizaki down while our hands were still forcibly joined.

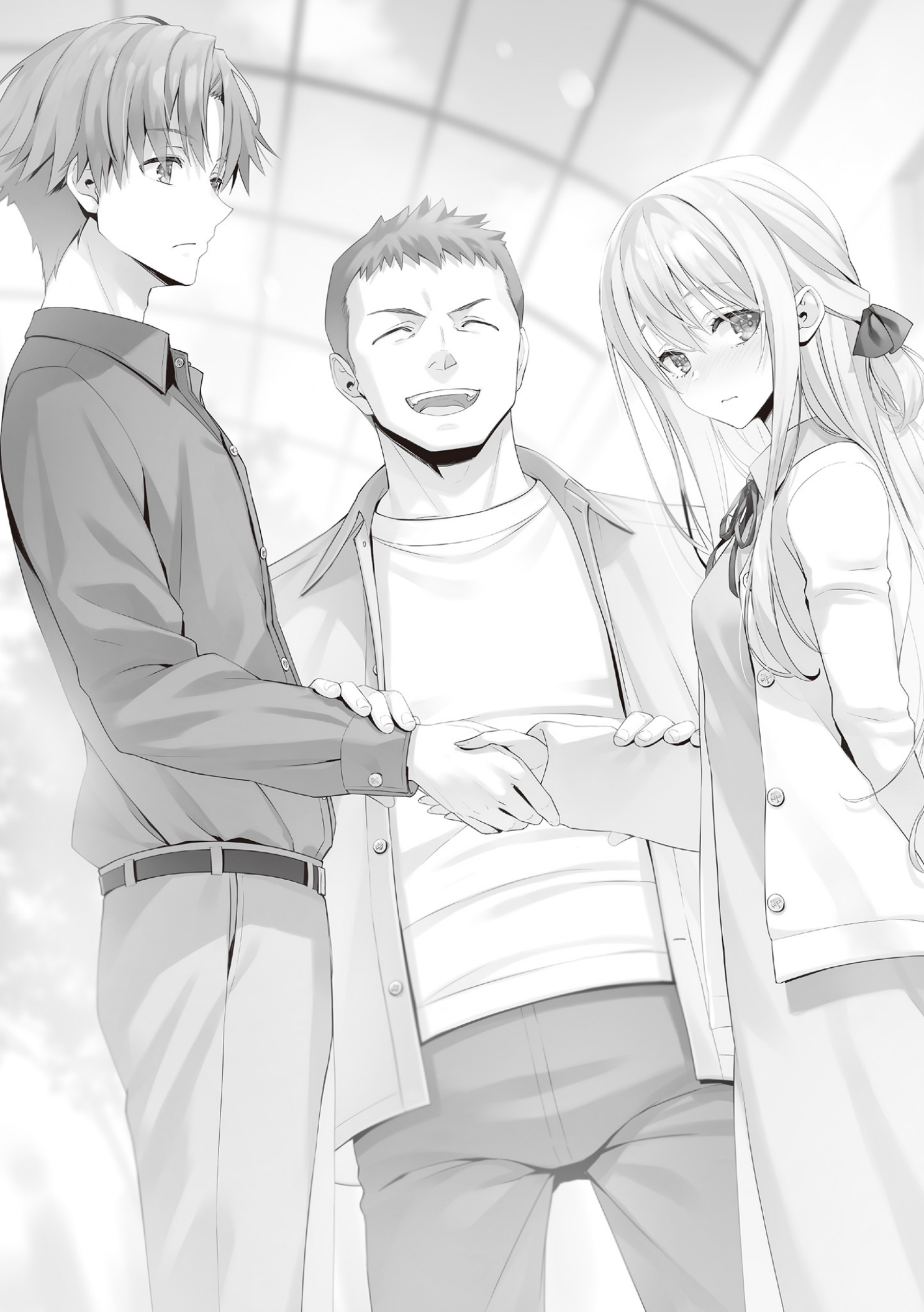
“I’m the type who goes all out when I like a girl. Let’s go for it!”

“No, you see... Ayanokōji-kun already has a wonderful girlfriend.”

“In that case, what will you do if he breaks up with Karuizawa?”

“Eh...?”

“Isn’t that what it means? You’re not going after him because he has a girlfriend, right?”



"Give it a rest, Ishizaki. It's better not to trouble Hiyori. It's cruel to make someone express their feelings in front of the person concerned, whether she likes them or not. Only a few people can say they don't like someone to their face."

"But, you know, Shiina is quite straightforward about what she wants to say..."

Hiyori, who usually didn't show much expression on her face, continued to look perplexed by the continued insensitive remarks. I could feel from the hand I was clasping that it was becoming quite warm.

Indeed, Hiyori seemed somewhat different now compared to when I first met her.

"Um... this is troubling."

She seemed to be trying to escape from Ishizaki's grasp on our hands, but she couldn't shake him off. It didn't seem like he was exerting much force, but forcibly shaking it off would be too aggressive for Hiyori to do.

So after giving a small heads up, I forcibly separated Ishizaki's hand.

This removed the obstacle necessary for Hiyori's hands to part from mine. I began to loosen my grip on Hiyori's hand, but for some reason, she tightened her grip slightly more than when it was forcibly joined.

"...Hiyori?"

"May I say just one thing, even if it's hopeless...?"

She looked up at me with a determined face.

"Could it be a confession!?"

Ignoring Ishizaki's teasing, Hiyori took a deep breath and spoke.

"If you could come to our class, Ayanokōji-kun, I would really welcome it... but it's impossible, isn't it?"

"That is—"

I explained the reasons why it wasn't possible so that even Ishizaki could understand. Hiyori probably understood without needing the explanation. Yet, she had courageously tried to invite me.

"Oh, that's great, Shiina. You seem more effective at recruiting!"

*Now that I think about it, both Ishizaki and Hiyori here, in addition to Albert, have been trying to welcome me warmly; and now it's being conveyed to me more than ever before.*

"It's too good for someone like me."

Yes, if I didn't have to think about anything, transferring to Ryūen's class would be the most fun.

I would spend the last year surrounded by close friends, not involved in the class competitions.

That was what I originally wanted most when I enrolled in this school.

That reality was probably right in front of me.

If I asked for their help, Ishizaki and the others would surely support me fully.

"I appreciate the sentiment, but I really can't accept the invitation."

"So... I see. I'm sorry. It was too much to ask, wasn't it?"

Hiyori loosened her grip on my hand, seeming reluctant to let go.

"Damn, no good, huh? You must really be attached to your current class. I thought you weren't the type to be held back by that kind of thing."

Even Hiyori's persuasion, which he'd thought of as a last resort, had failed, and it seemed Ishizaki had no choice but to give up.

"I'm grateful that you invited me again. Maybe this time next year, I'll regret not taking up your offer."

In one more year, no one knew which class would win.

Ishizaki, Hiyori, and their classmates certainly had a chance to win.

The same goes for Horikita's class.

And hopefully, the remaining two classes, which had been left behind, would be the same.

I wanted to keep the fight going with chances left for every class.

For that, hope was necessary.

If there was hope, the students would follow through with all their might until the end.

That was why I had to build what was necessary to keep the competition going.

And the answer to how I could do that would probably come soon.

# 2

After politely declining the invitation from Ishizaki and Hiyori, instead of just disbanding, we continued on talking for a while. Although they must've been shocked by the refusal, they didn't touch on the subject of transferring afterward and seemed to genuinely enjoy the casual conversation.

I was invited to meet again for tea once Keyaki Mall opened, but I had to decline due to prior commitments.

I returned to the dormitory by 9 AM, but Ichinose still hadn't made contact.

Then, according to my schedule, I went to Keyaki Mall at 10 AM, met the person I had promised to meet, and spent some time together.

When I returned to my room, it was just past 2 PM.

Time continued to pass uneventfully, hour by hour.

I didn't send any additional messages or make phone calls. I just waited in my room for a reply.

How she'd spend her time was up to Ichinose—it could be a decisive day for her.

I wanted the final move to be for Ichinose herself to decide, rather than just me.

I cleaned my room and rearranged some things.

Then, I prepared dinner and quietly finished eating alone.

As the curfew, 8 PM, approached, there still weren't any signs of a message being delivered.

The message was still unread.

However, the final decision wouldn't be made just because the curfew arrived.

Technically, it was only prohibited to enter the girls' floors, and it was possible for Ichinose to come to my room according to the rules. Of course, if caught visiting the opposite sex's room at night, she'd be given a warning.

Well, in some areas, the rules pertaining to the ban on entering the opposite sex's floors and self-restraint had been reduced to basically a formality. Those rules had become somewhat vague. This was something I had come to understand since I started dating Karuizawa.

There were four more hours until the promised day ended.

I leisurely took a shower and then watched TV.

The morning news was quite interesting, but I still couldn't get into the vibe of the variety shows that aired at night and wasn't able to enjoy them easily.

By the time I finished brushing my teeth, it was just past 9 PM.

"Less than three hours left."

Early risers might've been going to bed soon. However, the possibility that Ichinose was already asleep was extremely close to zero. She must've been awake, pondering her thoughts.

The night deepened, and time passed without stopping.

By the time it was past 9:30 PM, you could hear the sound of raindrops hitting the window.

When I cracked them open, heavy rain began to fall instantly.

I remembered that the forecast had mentioned heavy rain, lasting from tonight until dawn.

Even after I closed the window, the sound of the rain was quite loud inside the room.

It seemed the rain would only get harder.

And it was almost 10 PM.

Today, everything I needed to do in my room was completed.

Only two hours were left until today ended.

I opened my phone to check the status of the message I sent to Ichinose.

There was no reply. However, there had been a significant change since earlier.

It was regarding the message I had sent.

*['I'll be out until about 3 PM today, but come to my room at any time you like after that.']*

*['Contact me when you notice.']*

The consecutive messages I had sent now had been read.

Indeed, Ichinose was awake, and she had definitely seen my messages.

Another 10, then 20 minutes passed as I waited for a reply.

However… there was no contact.

Ichinose was free to miss the promised day.

*And her answer is silence, huh…?*

Both possibilities existed, but honestly, I had expected some kind of reaction.

Maybe I expected too much.

If she had chosen silence, then the decision I'd make was already clear.

*I should consider that I've given Ichinose enough time to think.*

However...

I slowly raised myself where I was sitting on the bed.

I still wanted to check directly.

For the past year, I continued to influence Ichinose Honami for my own sake.

So it was only natural to want to see the result.

*It's fine being rejected, but I want to know the state she's in.*

Such a desire naturally arose within me.

At the very end, even if I had to concede—*I might as well go and confirm the answer.*

# 3

At 10:30 PM, I decided to go out and check—a risky venture given the time.

Fortunately, due to the heavy rain, there was no sign of anyone in the hallway.

I headed from the hallway to the emergency stairs and made my way to Ichinose's room.

Then, I pressed the doorbell, trying to call out to Ichinose, who should've been inside.

The sound of the doorbell echoed faintly from the other side of the door.

But no matter how long I waited, there was no response.

There was no way for her to be sure that the one visiting was me. However, it seemed she was showing her intention not to meet anyone right now, regardless of their identity.

I took out my phone from my pocket and pressed the call button.

The call tone started ringing, indicating that her phone hadn't been turned off since it was last read.

Five times, six times—

Even after the call rang more than ten times, Ichinose did not answer the phone.

I pressed the end call button and quietly knocked.

"It's me. The deadline for our promise is about to end, that's why I came here."

I conveyed this with my own voice, not through the phone.

Even considering the heavy rain, speaking out like this was naturally a big risk.

I was visiting when other girls could've spotted me. It wouldn't immediately cause a commotion, but the one to find me would be obliged to report the offender, and I would be held responsible.

Therefore, I wouldn't repeat myself indefinitely.

If Ichinose still wouldn't respond, I had no intention of pursuing it further.

I certainly wanted to know the answer, but I couldn't take that high of a risk.

I would just have to accept it as Ichinose's answer.

The other side of the door remained silent.

"I'll wait just three more minutes. If there's no response, I'll leave, so don't worry."

I quietly began counting down 180 seconds.

During that time, I looked back at the heavy rain.

50 seconds, 40 seconds... the remaining time decreased.

When the final 30 seconds were just about to start, something changed.

My phone vibrated faintly. It was because I received a message.

*['Why did you come?']*

It was none other than Ichinose—the person on the other side of the door.

If sending a message was all she could manage, then I could just reply to her on my phone.

*['I told you. Today was the promised day.']*

*['It's already late at night. It's past curfew.']*

After that message arrived, while I was replying, another message from Ichinose came.

*['I don't have the courage to go to your room right now, Ayanokōji-kun. Sorry.']*

*['I understand that. That's why I came here.']*

This reply was read immediately, but no more messages came back.

I continued to send another message

*['I'll wait one more minute. If the door doesn't open by then, let's pretend the promise never happened.']*

This message was also properly read.

Now it was up to Ichinose to decide.

She could dislike or doubt me—if she chose to continue fighting through the next year despite that, that was her choice to make.

She might even feel disgusted with the school and choose to leave voluntarily.

Or, she could do something I couldn't predict. Naturally, Ichinose had the option.

After getting an answer, it would be fine if she showed herself then.

Soon, the time limit was less than 10 seconds away.

I was about to change my mind and leave when my phone vibrated again.

*['The door is unlocked, come in.']*

That message was from Ichinose.

*Unlocked?* I read those words over and over. Something felt out of place.

Recently, I knew without having to look into things that Ichinose hadn't been going out, and she was avoiding meeting with anyone.

Then, this door, the only connection between the inside and out, should naturally be locked.

*Had a classmate that visited Ichinose been invited in after I looked into things?*

Of course, all possibilities were possible, but... the probability seemed low.

*Had she considered the possibility that I would be the one to visit her today instead?*

It was hard to determine.

If this had been a phone call or face-to-face conversation, I could've fished for the answers, but unfortunately, it was difficult to discern intentions through impersonal messages.

The unexpected message surprised me a bit, but I decided to move forward.

I cautiously reached for the doorknob.

Indeed, the door was unlocked and opened smoothly.

However, no light awaited beyond the opened door; the room was enveloped in silence and darkness.

"Ichinose, are you there?"

I muttered, but no voice returned.

I quietly closed the door I had opened.

The lights were off inside the room, making it nearly impossible to see anything, and sound was similarly absent.

The only audible noise was a faint hum from the refrigerator's compressor.

"Ichinose?"

I called out again, but still no reply came back.

Since I couldn't just take off my shoes and enter, I decided to take my time.

As I couldn't grasp the situation any further, I quietly waited for my eyes to adjust to the darkness.

As my eyes gradually adapted to the dark, I was able to spot Ichinose in the corner of the room, hugging her knees with her face down.

"Even though curfew passed, you don't care?"

"That's my line as well. Since you invited me in, Ichinose, you also bear some responsibility."

"...That's true."

I heard Ichinose's voice for the first time in a while.

She seemed more energetic than I had expected, and she didn't appear to be in poor health.

"Ayanokōji-kun, you value this day more than I imagined."

Ichinose murmured, referencing how I had gone out of my way to risk visiting.

"But that isn't for my sake—it's for your own… right, Ayanokōji-kun?"

Ichinose must've understood that much by now.

"Yes."

So I nodded without hesitation and continued speaking.

"I decided a year ago. Today is the day to enact the student Ichinose Honami's *kaishaku*."

*(TL Note: "Kaishaku (介錯人) is a term historically associated with ritual suicide (seppuku), where a second person would deliver a final blow.")*

If someone heard this, they might angrily question what I meant by *kaishaku*.

"*Kaishaku*... In which sense do you mean that?"

Ichinose muttered briefly, neither angry nor flustered.

Generally, when people heard *'kaishaku*,' most would only imagine the negative meaning. This was because they'd interpret it as delivering the final blow to cause instant death during *seppuku*. However, *kaishaku* had another meaning. It could mean the opposite—to attend to someone and take care of them.

"That's what you'll soon come to understand."

"Is that so... "

"If it's okay with you, may I come in?"

"...Please do. Just make sure to lock the door."

It was unlikely that anyone would visit at this hour, but it was better to be cautious.

Following her request, I locked the door and removed my shoes before stepping inside. The room was dark, making it hard to see where I was stepping, but it was neatly arranged and seemed free of any tripping hazards.

Despite the darkness, I stopped walking once I reached a position where I could clearly see Ichinose's state.

"You might not want to see me—maybe you never want to see my face again—however, I wanted to talk today. This might be the last chance we have to talk at leisure."

"Cutting off all ties... we won't even be able to remain as friends. Is that what this means, I wonder."

"I won't deny it. If we both decide that's best, it's necessary."

Ichinose could've dismissed me from the start, saying she didn't even want to be friends.

If that was the worst-case scenario for Ichinose, it was because she regretted her lack of judgment.

What I was about to tell her was nothing short of cruel.

"Is there anything you want to tell me first? If not, I'm ready to give my answer."

If unnecessary chatter was unwelcome, it was best to get to the point.

"...Yes. Tell me."

Without turning her face, Ichinose gave an affirmation, perhaps prepared.

"The result of the end-of-year special exam was a crossroads of fate. If your class lost, it would be nearly impossible to recover from the current situation. You could say that it was a battle you absolutely couldn't lose to. However, the result was Horikita's class's victory. In other words, the path to Class A was cut off."

“That’s right. I think there are still many in the class who haven’t given up, but it’s impossible... because I couldn’t beat you, Ayanokōji-kun. Because of that, I crushed everyone’s dreams.”

“That’s right. The class was defeated because its leader, you, was weak. The responsibility you hold is significant. But anyone can blame that part on you. There would be no need for me to come here to enact the *kaishaku* if that was all.”

Ichinose didn’t move. Whether she was prepared or not, she kept her head down, looking at the ground.

“However, surprisingly, there’s still a chance to put your class back on its feet.”

“That’s a strange thing to say. Isn’t the path to Class A cut off...?”

“Only as long as you remain the leader of the class, that is.”

For the first time, Ichinose’s shoulders jolted.

“…So… are you telling me to step down as the leader?”

“If you want to win for the sake of the class, then do it as soon as possible.”

“I see… But if that’s the case, it won’t be long before it happens. I no longer have the qualifications or confidence to lead the class...”

I could feel the strength being poured into the hands that clutched her knees.

“I’m sorry, but that alone isn’t enough. While stepping down as leader is a given, beyond that, someone who can lead the class to victory needs to take that empty role. Only then can your class regain the potential to be Class A.”

“A leader who can guide us? Who are you thinking of...? Kanzaki-kun?”

“Nobody in particular. Currently, there’s no one in your class capable of making a comeback.”

“If that’s the case, it’s an impossible tale from the start...”

“If there’s no one in your class, then we should bring someone from another class.”

“…What do you mean...?”

“I will transfer to your class and become the new leader.”

This was one of the strategies I had been developing.

Here, I confessed the strategy to Ichinose.

“Ayanokōji-kun, you...?”

“You should understand my abilities by now, whether for better or worse. The 500-points gap with Horikita’s class isn’t an easy fight, but I can easily overtake them within a year.”

“After finally moving up to Class A, you would throw that away to come to a lower class...?”

"It might be an idea that's hard to understand normally. But rest assured, if this is achieved, I can graduate your current class from Class A, just as you wish."

For the first time, Ichinose, who had continued hugging her knees, looked up.

*I thought she might've been crying, but it doesn't seem like it.*

"Ah... I see. That's what it is..."

She seemed to have realized something, showing a deep understanding.

Then Ichinose slowly looked at me.

Perhaps in her eyes, I appeared as an executioner who had come to end her life.

"The predetermined plan was for you to defeat me in the end-of-year special exam, Ayanokōji-kun. If I had won, this proposal wouldn't have been made—"

If Ichinose won, the class points would have remained nearly balanced.

In that case, there would be no need for me to transfer classes.

That view, that way of thinking, was half correct.

"I won't deny that it was one of the options. Still, if you had defeated me and shown the strength that made me unnecessary, I would've welcomed that too."

It meant that I had honestly intended to go with *kaishaku's* 'helping' definition.

"I see... But that's not a bad deal for our class, right? If you fight in my place and aim for Class A, Ayanokōji-kun, we should be happy about it."

"That's right. But you might've guessed, right?"

"Yes... There has to be a condition, correct?"

Just having Ichinose step down as leader and taking that position myself wouldn't constitute '*kaishaku*.'

"I'll transfer to your class and graduate from Class A, but I require that you, Ichinose Honami, get expelled from this school."

That was the only requirement I sought.

If she agreed to this, the deal would be done.

"...My expulsion..."

*Considering that condition, what would Ichinose think?*

*How would she act?*

Since this morning, I had been intrigued by her answer.

We were at the crossroads of many strategies I had set up. Regardless of where we would end up, I predicted the patterns of answers, but which path we'd take was up to Ichinose herself to decide.

"Sorry. I don't have enough private points..."

"Don't worry. The transfer itself isn't difficult. We'll gather all the private points you have, of course, and we'll gather from all your classmates as well. If that's still not enough, we can borrow from the first-years. If we promise to repay with interest, there will be students willing to lend. With the trust you possess, it won't be difficult to gather the missing points when promising to return it with interest. Even if we can't gather all 20 million, it isn't hard to come up with how we'll acquire the remainder."

And with that, the simple class transfer would be completed.

Just 20 million private points guaranteed Class A.

"Even if this can be realized... what's your purpose in doing all this, Ayanokōji-kun?"

"A certain graduate once told me to become a memorable student. At least, each classes' leaders are now strongly aware of my presence. Not just the leaders, but other class members are gradually becoming aware as well."

Whether that awareness was right or wrong didn't matter.

"Once this transfer is completed, it will definitely make me a memorable student."

"...Right."

"Do you remember what I told you a year ago—to stay true to yourself?"

'*During that year, you'll push forward with your classmates, as far as you can go. There will be happy times and sad times along the way. And I think there will be times when you feel crushed and disheartened. But even so, don't ever stop.*'

*That message I conveyed a year ago—this is the true meaning.*

"It was also to avoid damaging the class's value. By doing so, we could maintain the initial 40 student count given by the school, so even if you leave, someone else could enter the class, allowing us to start the third year with 40 students."

I was controlling and managing the initial state of the class with my own hands.

"This is because I consider starting from the base to be ideal."

"If I stay, there will be 41 people... it would be distorted."

"Of course, that's not the only reason. Your existence is an obstacle for the class. It's your character—you have a power that I can't control."

If Ichinose were to show resistance to me, those who would follow her wouldn't just stop at one or two students.

This would hinder the normal operation of the class.

"I see... Amazing, Ayanokōji-kun. You really think of every possible scenario..."

However, this divergence slightly differed from the future I originally envisioned.

Since Sakayanagi left, things didn't go as planned, resulting in me correcting the course.

"If I voluntarily withdraw, the class points will drop even further. Can you still win?"

"Normally, it would be tough to fight. Whether we can accumulate over 800 class points purely depends on the rewards offered by the school. But the words you just said are key to the strategy. If we can force other class' students to drop out through unofficial means, not only can we close the gap with the points we receive, but we can also do so by taking points from others."

She couldn't get her friends to Class A with her own abilities.

If she took responsibility and voluntarily withdrew, she could make sure her friends graduate from Class A.

Ichinose, feeling a great responsibility for the loss, had two possible options.

This was indeed the last crossroad.

"If I really withdraw... will you take them to Class A?"

"I promise."

This was the truth.

I was negotiating with the intent of leading Ichinose's class to Class A.

"Then, I will—"

"But Ichinose, let me tell you something important first. I will definitely lead your class to Class A, but I can't guarantee the graduation of all 39 classmates excluding me."

"Eh...?"

"Of course. We can't afford to carry any dead weight for the comeback. If I feel a student is unnecessary, I will naturally cut them off. To make up for the significant gap in class points, eliminating weaknesses is one of the top priorities. If there's a chance to force someone out through special exams, I'll use it without hesitation. Whether it's Amikura, Norihito, or someone close to you, I won't make any distinctions. It's the same as what I did with Maezono in Horikita's class."

In fact, I had already set a precedent with Maezono. I had used her and forced her to withdraw.

Ichinose was experiencing firsthand a reality that didn't allow for dreaming.

"However, it won't be 10 or 20 people withdrawing. At most, a few will disappear."

The answer narrowed down to two choices.

One is to accept my current proposal, bring me into her class, and then voluntarily withdraw.

The other is to reject my proposal, continue as the class leader fueled by hatred.

No, in reality, there was only one option left.

Ichinose Honami could not abandon her classmates.

It was a 99% chance—Ichinose would rise again as the class leader and start fighting.

From there, I would have no choice but to forcibly arrange the battle between the four classes.

However, it was unlikely that the balance among the four classes would be correctly maintained.

That couldn't be helped.

But neither of those answers were what I wanted.

I was actually seeking a third answer.

I found myself hoping for a third answer, one that even I didn't have.

"That's cruel, isn't it…?"

"Indeed."

It was a futile wish.

Ichinose would soon stand up in anger and reach the conclusion to fight.

Even so… I still desired it.

It was something I had instilled in her a year ago, on the day I decided to enact the *kaishaku* on Ichinose Honami—the seeds to controlling both the positive and negative romantic emotions from within a human.

No, it wasn't limited to love.

Being helped and betrayed, receiving goodwill and hostility.

I had interacted with her with the purpose of mixing these contradictory emotions.

In a short period, a multitude of positives and negatives tumultuously stirred inside of Ichinose.

It had reached its peak.

Undoubtedly, Ichinose's goodwill had flipped due to my betrayal.

In psychological terms, this state was called ambivalence.

Ambivalence particularly amplified the influence of the less desirable feelings.

When I was in the White Room, I learned of its existence during my studies.

Therefore, it was highly likely that Ichinose, fueled by hatred, would oppose me afterward.

I just wanted to closely observe what kind of changes she'd undergo as a new experiment.

And Ichinose was indeed the perfect test subject for this.

Now, she harbored hatred for me that surpassed her feelings of affection.

The deeper the love, the stronger the hatred would become.

Sometimes, this could lead to a psychological state significant enough to cause neurosis, one that couldn't be taken lightly.

However, you couldn't call this a new experiment.

Increasing hatred and breaking the spirit—this had been done in past experiments with results that were already known.

What I truly wanted to see was a different outcome.

The 1% unknown.

*Is that too much to hope for?*

"I... definitely don't want to hurt my friends."

"Then you have no choice but to keep fighting on your own."

"But, that surely won't get us to Class A."

What awaited was just a futile year.

"Then, will you choose to drop out and entrust it to me?"

"Whether I drop out or not, maybe that's the answer you're waiting for, Ayanokōji-kun."

*That's right.*

I didn't deny anything.

"But… I feel like neither of those is the real answer."

Words I hadn't expected to hear so soon came out of her mouth.

I couldn't hide the strong stimulation flowing through my brain.

"Both are wrong? Then, what do you think is the right choice?"

"I don't want to lose any of my friends. I can't afford to lose them."

"That's just an ideal, and it's selfish."

"Yes, it's probably impossible with my abilities alone. But with you, Ayanokōji-kun, it can be realized."

"You're not dropping out, yet you still want me to transfer to your class—is that what you mean to say?"

When I asked, Ichinose smiled for the first time today, shaking her head from side to side in denial.

Then, she articulated the path she had imagined: a path without a path.

She presented a method to achieve balance among the four classes, conceived through her own thoughts.

She reached the 1% answer I had hoped for.

"So that's... that's the solution you've thought of."

"Could it be that I'm wrong?"

"...No."

I lost my words and couldn't immediately continue.

Ichinose's classmates admired her and aimed for Class A together with her.

It was the only possibility that didn't picture anyone missing upon graduation.

She had now grasped the elements she lacked as a leader.

If we were only talking about Ichinose's potential, she might've surpassed Horikita and Ryūen.

If she was able to completely overcome her mental weakness and discard her naivety, it was really uncertain how the next year would turn out.

I approached Ichinose and offered my hand.

"In order to make that choice a reality, we need to keep each other at a proper distance. Nothing can start without communication. Of course, the driving force can be hatred. There's no need for you to like me—"

"That's not right, Ayanokōji-kun."

Ichinose, who stood up while taking my hand, immediately denied it.

"This whole time I was shut away, I tried many times to dislike you. But I couldn't do it. Even though I know it's stupid, I couldn't change my affectionate feelings. And even today, no matter how cruel the words you showered onto me, that still hasn't changed."

A citrus scent wafted through the air—

From Ichinose, who had been shut away, such a smell reached me.

In the darkness, I noticed her glossy hair color.

*Perhaps, I've made a big misunderstanding.*

*I thought that I led and guided everything today.*

But actually...

"Did you know I'd come here?"

"Yes, I knew. You would definitely come to check what state I'm in, what feelings I have. You wouldn't be able to suppress that impulse."

Ichinose was certain that I would visit her today, no matter how late it got.

The emotionless messages on the phone. The door that wasn't locked.

The room that was cleaned and the fact that she was dressed as if expecting someone.

It meant she prepared everything.

I didn't think she could predict my proposal, but then again, I wasn't sure.

It wasn't unlikely for Ichinose to have sensed everything, even if she didn't know it all.

"It's already past curfew. If you leave the room now, someone might find you. That might interfere with our plans."

"That's true…"

"...So, I'll have to make you an accomplice, okay...?"

She exceeded my imagination, not just once but twice.

Indeed, Ichinose was excellent.

"How do you plan to make me an accomplice?"

"I won't allow any more unnecessary secrets between me and you, Ayanokōji-kun. I don't want to."

Ichinose grabbed my hand.

She didn't say anything, yet she pulled forcefully.

Then, as if drawing me closer to her, she then pushed strongly against my chest.

*Sit on the bed*—I felt such an intention from her and sat down. No, I was made to sit.

Ichinose, standing in front of me, looked down at me.

"I think I understand Karuizawa-san better now."

"...What do you mean?"

"She probably touched your darkness, was saved, and then saw hell again. And you think that's necessary for her."

"Maybe."

"That's quite one-sided, isn't it? Even if it ends up being salvation, no one can say that the method is right. You hurt and break the other person on your own, then fix them."

Ichinose didn't know that I had broken up with Karuizawa.

However, she understood from the course of events that I was intending to break up with her.

"I'm the same, right? Just like Karuizawa-san—no, like the other students. We're all being made to dance in the palm of your hand."

Ichinose's eyes were beautiful. Clear, yet somehow dark, strong, weak, and sharp.

Her eyes, showing various changes, were now shining even more intensely.

They were a color that exceeded my calculations, indeterminate, neither light nor dark.

"You are—"

Both my shoulders were grabbed, and with weight applied, I was pushed backward.

"Ayanokōji-kun, you're using me, so I have the right to use you too, don't I?"

"At the very least, I have no right to deny that."

"My feelings for you cannot be changed. I can't forget them. Rather, I wanted to see you so badly. More than any of my classmates, more than any of my family, I can only think about you. But Ayanokōji-kun, you are different. You don't look at me. You think more broadly, and only about yourself."

Seeing through my true feelings, Ichinose smiled.

"I think that's okay, but I won't forgive you. Just as you've deeply engraved your existence into my heart without permission, I also want to deeply engrave my existence into your heart by my own will."

Weight was placed on my hands atop Ichinose's bed, and it faintly creaked.

Her hands grabbed mine and moved them.

Ichinose's heartbeat, which I shouldn't have been able to hear directly, was transmitted through my hands.

It was clear that she was in an extremely tense state—it was very fast, far from calm.

Outside the window, the rain struck the glass and danced wildly.

"You're doing something terrible to Karuizawa-san. If she found out... she'd definitely be troubled, right?"

"Sorry, but I broke up with Karuizawa before coming here. I'm visiting a girl's room at night, so I've already taken care of the risk management."

However, it originally stemmed from the consideration that she might've trapped me out of hatred.

"I see. I've been shut in my room lately, so I didn't know."

It wasn't surprising. This fact didn't pop up last week or yesterday.

It happened today—March 30th.

"So even doing this won't make it a tool for threats."

Ichinose's presence completely blocked my field of vision, and it was shrouded in darkness.

"I don't intend to threaten you."

Whispering in my ear, Ichinose blushed, but she didn't change her assertive stance.

She pressed her lips against mine.

The momentum was fast, and our teeth slightly collided, causing Ichinose to flinch a bit.

"Sorry, I'm not good at this. It's my first kiss—"

Saying that, she then laid her lips on mine, slowly and carefully.

"Is this right...? Is this the way to do it?"

"Yeah..."

"Aren't you going to run away?"

"There's no option for that. Escaping by force here would be riskier."

Ichinose had decided with firm conviction to ensure I couldn't escape.

If I tried to forcibly pull away, it would lead to a scuffle at worst.

The fate of a boy who entered the forbidden girls' floor late at night.

A mere warning wouldn't suffice.

Such was Ichinose's resolve.

*Then, I too must reciprocate that resolve.*

I reached for Ichinose's clothes and began to take them off.

Hesitating for a moment, her body stiffened, but soon relaxed, and she removed her top herself.

This was already beyond the realm of reason.

I had been entangled.

From the moment I stepped into that room, my retreat had already been cut off.

Yet at the same time, I was being drawn in by her unknown charm.

I thought I had finished needing to learn.

But perhaps, it had just been the beginning.

In that room, just the two of us, the night continued to darken.

It wasn't a ritual to become lovers.

If it were, it wouldn't have worked from the start.

It was an absolute contract, to be needed and to need the other.

And so, we were being bound together with that contract, sinking deeper and deeper, as we devoured each other endlessly.

# 4

A few days after that rainy night, Ayanokōji and Ichinose promised to significantly close the distance between them.

At the beginning of April, as spring break was nearing its end, six students from Ichinose's class gathered near a cafe entrance at Keyaki Mall with solemn expressions.

Ichinose, who had been shut in her room, refusing to meet or contact anyone, suddenly sent a message of her return. It was sent to the group chat that the whole class belonged in, and her classmates, who'd been hoping for her recovery, quickly sent warm messages in response.

Ichinose first apologized for not returning any messages, and then she said that she'd organized her thoughts about future policies and wanted to discuss them.

Many students wanted to participate, but it was Kanzaki who immediately took control of the situation.

Considering the current situation where it was hard to grasp everything, he suggested that it'd be better to discuss with a smaller group.

Kanzaki then made the selection of participants, and no one, including Ichinose, objected.

For better or worse, the class readily accepted the suggestion.

The participants Kanzaki called were Shibata, Hamaguchi, Amikura, Himeno, Shiranami, and Norihito.

The selection included seven people, some of whom caused others in the class to feel a sense of discomfort. They were left wondering why they were chosen.

Some central figures were included, but there were also those who weren't.

It was a selection Kanzaki made, choosing people close to Ichinose while also mixing in Hamaguchi and Himeno, who agreed with his views, as a way to disguise his intentions.

Even if the discussion turned to something like a majority vote, Kanzaki was confident that he could secure at least three votes for his ideas.

Given that Ichinose's current state was unknown, Kanzaki intended to approach the situation with full readiness.

Kanzaki met Shibata halfway there and arrived at the cafe.

"Shibata-kun and Kanzaki-kun, good morning,"

Amikura was someone who often spent time with Ichinose, both on weekdays and on days off—she was considered her closest friend. Amikura was the first to arrive and greeted them as they joined.

“Hey Amikura, good morning. It’s a relief, right? Ichinose finally contacted us.”

“Yeah, for real. I was almost crying when I got the message.”

Since the time she lost the end-of-year special exam until today, Ichinose hadn’t met with anyone. Even her best friend Amikura, who tried visiting her directly, was turned away, which made it difficult to meet.

Everyone continued to encourage her through their messages, but Amikura was wondering if it was counterproductive and if there was a better way to help Ichinose recover, yet she couldn’t think of a solution.

“But we haven’t seen her face yet, so we can’t be relieved... It looks like she attended the three-way meeting, but can she come out in front of everyone? Honami-chan will be okay, right...?”

Amikura feared that the gathering might end up bearing no fruit.

The memory of Ichinose taking the blame for their defeat in the end-of-year special exam was still fresh.

“No, she will come. Ichinose isn’t that irresponsible.”

Shibata confidently answered without hesitation.

“That’s true, but still... she hasn’t been going out much.”

It was understandable if she didn’t have the courage to face everyone, so Shibata preemptively defended her.

“If it comes to that, we should just be more forgiving,”

“It’s not a problem that can be solved that easily,”

Right after Amikura and Shibata made optimistic remarks, Kanzaki spoke angrily.

“What do you mean by that?”

“Our defeat in the end-of-year special exam was the final nail in the coffin for our class. It’s been more than two weeks, and we haven’t come up with a single new strategy. We can’t afford to waste any more time.”

Kanzaki pointed out that it would be problematic if, after calling her classmates, Ichinose couldn’t show her face.

“It’s not just Ichinose’s fault we lost. You were a representative and lost too, and we participants could’ve contributed more. It’s the responsibility of the entire class.”

“It’s not about where the responsibility lies. I’m saying it’s far too late to be discussing what to do next.”

Spring break was almost over, and they were soon to become third-year students.

The time to prepare was dwindling as they spoke.

“What do you mean, what to do? We just need to unite more than ever and work hard, that’s all.”

“It’s different... our class no longer has a chance to win.”

Kanzaki spoke, ready to face Shibata and the others' backlash.

Of course, many of the others, starting with Shibata, didn't welcome his weak and pessimistic statement.

"What are you talking about, Kanzaki? That's not true."

"Shibata, do you still not see the situation?"

"Hey, hey, both of you, let's calm down for a moment. Look, Norihito-kun and the others have arrived."

Amikura pointed in the direction where Norihito was happily waving.

Afterwards, Himeno, Hamaguchi, and Shiranami joined, and with the necessary seven members gathered, they entered the cafe.

"What was the commotion about?"

As soon as they sat down, Norihito asked Kanzaki and Shibata, who'd been glaring at each other earlier, the reason for their attitude.

"Kanzaki was saying that I can't see the situation."

"Can't see the situation?"

Kanzaki then reiterated his point about how their class should proceed in the coming year.

"Get real, Shibata. Even our homeroom teacher, Hoshinomiya-sensei, said something similar."

"It's you who isn't seeing reality. We still have a year. Just like how Horikita's class accumulated class points, we should do something similar."

Shibata, who didn't want to give up, opposed Kanzaki, who suggested giving up.

It seemed that Norihito and the others fully understood the situation they were arguing about.

"Have you analyzed how that class accumulated points? They have many below-average students, but also several with outstanding abilities. However, we don't have someone like Kōenji who can fight alone and take first place in the deserted island exam."

"That's—"

Kanzaki continued to press on.

It was as if he was venting the frustration he'd accumulated during the spring break.

"We also don't have someone like Ayanokōji who completely shut down Ichinose in the end-of-year special exam. There's no way we can win."

"Wait, the thing about Kōenji might be true, but Ayanokōji might've just gotten lucky. We don't even know the details of the exam."

"...That's exactly why it's hopeless, because you're still saying things like that."

Unable to hide his irritation with Shibata's thinking, Kanzaki raised his voice without allowing for rebuttal.

“Our class is already sinking. We should shift our focus to how many can escape.”

“Wait, Kanzaki-kun, that’s a bit too much...!”

Amikura, who had been somewhat listening and accepting things as they went, couldn’t help but interject.

“It’s not too much. It’s the truth.”

“Even if we were on a sinking ship like you said, that’s all the more reason for us to bail out the water together and aim to resurface without leaving anyone behind!”

“Hey Shibata-kun. Can we really do that...?”

“Huh?”

Himeno, though timid, spoke up against Shibata, who had been arguing against Kanzaki.

“It’s not easy to move up to Class A from here...”

“I know it’s not easy. That’s exactly why we need to unite as a class. If we keep thinking negatively like Kanzaki, we won’t be able to turn things around.”

Shibata always tried to think positively.

On the other hand, Kanzaki always tended to think negatively.

It was inevitable that their opinions didn’t align.

“That’s enough. This isn’t going anywhere.”

Deciding he could no longer deal with his positivity, Kanzaki tried to end the conversation.

“What, you want to stop the discussion? I’m in the mood to argue this through.”

“There’s no point in a discussion when you refuse to accept anything except the answer you want. Your optimistic attitude is coming across poorly.”

“No, no, it’s not optimism. Seriously, Kanzaki, you’re just too negative.”

“I’d rather hear you say that you’re finally starting to look at reality. In the first place—”

As the two continued to clash with their opposing views, a shadow suddenly fell between them.

“Both of you. Fighting isn’t good, okay?”

Amid the heated exchange of opinions, an eagerly awaited student unexpectedly arrived.

Shibata, who’d been glaring a bit at Kanzaki, widened his mouth in surprise.

“...Ichinose. You came.”

Kanzaki had been half-doubting whether she’d really come.

Meanwhile, Shiranami looked worried, almost on the verge of tears.

“Are you okay? Honami-chan...”

“Yes. I’m sorry for worrying everyone. I’m fine now.”

Her classmates were worried that no matter how positive her words might've been, they would end up seeming like a mere facade.

However, regardless of such worries, Ichinose, who appeared before them, truly seemed well. Especially Shibata, who had Ichinose's hand on his shoulder, felt the brightness in her eyes was as strong, if not stronger, than before.

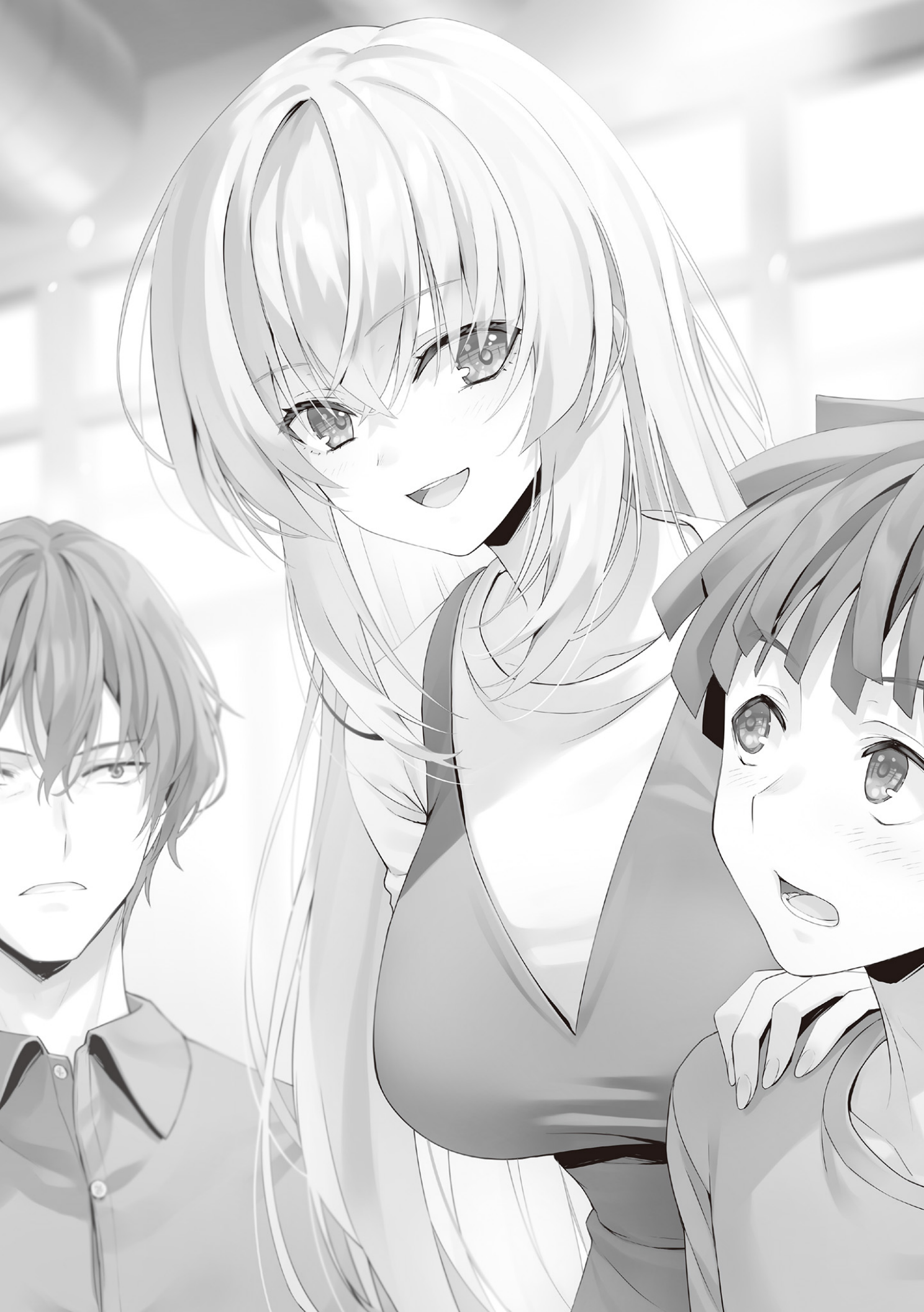
"Ah, you're okay, Ichinose. I'm really glad..."

As her scent reached his nostrils, Shibata blushed and answered involuntarily.

"I made you worry, didn't I?"

"No, not at all. I've always believed you were okay... haha."

Influenced by a somewhat more mature aura than the Ichinose he'd seen until now, Shibata felt embarrassed being stared at so closely and inadvertently averted his gaze.



Her hand gently left his shoulder, and Ichinose looked at everyone.

"I'm really sorry for not being able to give a proper response until now, everyone."

"That's totally fine... but are you really okay now?"

Amikura asked, and Shiranami repeatedly nodded, showing his concern.

"I'm okay. But, yeah. Considering that, I'd like to have a proper talk."

Ichinose smiled softly and sat down in the vacant seat between Amikura and Shiranami.

Then, all eyes inevitably turned towards Ichinose.

They wondered if this smile was just superficial, how much of the wounds from the end-of-year special exam remained, and most importantly, what would happen in the future.

Before she took a break from school due to a cold, Ichinose showed signs of her stepping down as the class leader.

Hoshinomiya stopped her just before she could say more, but it wouldn't have been strange if she'd retired right then—everyone sensed it.

"...Um, Honami-chan?"

Before Ichinose could start speaking, Amikura decided to voice her thoughts, unable to hold back any longer.

"Yes, what is it?"

"You're not going to say that you're quitting school, are you?"

Whether she would step down as class leader wasn't a big deal for her best friend Amikura. Since Ichinose was under so much pressure and responsibility, Amikura had no right to stop her if she wished to step down.

What mattered to Amikura was whether Ichinose had grown to hate this school.

She thought that Ichinose might've been announcing her voluntary withdrawal to take responsibility.

"You don't have to worry about that. I found out about Sakayanagi-san's voluntary withdrawal, and with that, her class points will drop by 300."

Ichinose, who hated troubling the class more than anyone else, reassured Amikura.

However, seeing Ichinose's attitude, Kanzaki tried to confirm her true intentions.

"So, if it was guaranteed that we wouldn't lose class points, would you consider voluntarily withdrawing?"

"Ka-Kanzaki-kun, that's not a nice way to put it!"

Amikura got angry at his words, words that would seemingly break Ichinose's spirit, especially after she had just spoken about staying.

"That's right, Kanzaki. You need to be more careful about how you say things."

Seeing this, Norihito strongly agreed.

"Don't worry, Mako-chan. Even if there's no penalty for voluntary withdrawal, I won't quit."

Relieved from the bottom of her heart, Amikura heaved a sigh of relief.

"Then, would you be prepared to accept a beneficial withdrawal for the class? In the scenario that we gain 300 class points if you withdraw, Ichinose, what would you do?"

Kanzaki was trying to extract an answer to an unlikely and unreasonable decision.

"The conditions are different, but if my withdrawal meant everyone in this class could definitely graduate as Class A, I would choose to withdraw without hesitation."

"No, you can't do that, Honami-chan!"

"I know. But don't worry. I won't actually be forced to make such a choice. So, I intend to fight alongside everyone until the moment we graduate as Class A."

"So, I can take it that you're mentally okay now?"

Shibata asked eagerly, leaning forward.

"Yes. Having time to think helped me organize all the issues. If you all still accept me as your leader, I'll continue with you."

"Of course, Honami-chan. Our class leader can only be you—"

*Bang*. Kanzaki slammed the table, stopping the conversation.

"Let's not talk about whether to continue as leader just yet, shall we?"

Kanzaki interrupted the jubilant Shibata and Amikura as he questioned.

"I'm sorry, but I can't even believe she's recovered. What's changed between yesterday, when she was shut away and depressed, and today? If it's just a brave front, it's nothing but a drawback for the class."

"Hey, Kanza—"

Shibata hurried to caution Kanzaki, but Ichinose calmly stopped him.

"Indeed, the days I spent cooped up were truly hellish. Losing the end-of-year special exam was a big blow to the class, and the feeling that we might've been able to win the exam made it even more painful. I thought about quitting school many times. It was painful and frustrating, and I cried many times, however—"

Ichinose took a breather, and her large eyes turned towards Kanzaki and then to everyone.

"I'm different from how I was before. I'm completely back on my feet."

"You certainly seem energetic, but what's the basis for that?"

"Do I have to say?"

"Of course. If you're claiming that you're back on your feet, there must've been a significant trigger."

*This wasn't a wound that would just heal on its own*, Kanzaki pointed out.

If she were to say that time solved it, he was determined to dismiss it as a lie.

"That's right—all the doubts I had were resolved."

"The doubts you had?"

"Yeah. How to keep fighting from now on, how to reach Class A without losing any comrades, whether it's okay for me to be the class leader—all those doubts have been cleared."

"...How?"

"It's because I was saved by someone—"

Someone.

Kanzaki was the only person present who immediately thought of Ayanokōji when hearing that expression.

After all, Ayanokōji defeated Ichinose in the end-of-year special exam.

The fact that Ichinose liked Ayanokōji and that Ayanokōji seemed to be concerned about the class seemed trivial now.

Therefore, other students thought of teachers or other friends rather than Ayanokōji.

"That's amazing. Who helped you?"

Shibata, simply curious, asked without any doubt.

As if engraving that question in her heart, Ichinose gave her warmest look of the day.

"It was Ayanokōji-kun."

Right after hearing the anticipated name, Kanzaki immediately showed his anger.

"Ayanokōji is a clear enemy. He defeated you in the end-of-year special exam, and yet you were saved by him?"

"Yes. I was saved by Ayanokōji-kun. This is an undeniable fact."

Kanzaki took a deep breath, trying to calm himself down and not let anger dominate his emotions.

Kanzaki himself had been saved by Ayanokōji a few times.

Indeed, as long as he was an ally, he was a dependable presence.

However, in the end-of-year special exam, he naturally stood as an enemy.

And he defeated Ichinose, plunging this class into despair.

Being half-hearted about a friendship brought no good. He knew that.

"Saved by Ayanokōji, huh? I wish it were a lie, but if it's not, that's a big problem. It's even suspicious whether you were really saved."

Kanzaki's thoroughly blaming Ichinose made Shibata and the others beyond angry and dismayed at this point.

"Hey, Kanzaki, if Ichinose says she was saved by Ayanokōji, we should at least be thankful."

"You don't understand. You don't know how dangerous Ayanokōji is."

"What do you mean dangerous? Ayanokōji isn't a bad guy, right?"

Here, Kanzaki hesitated whether to expose all the information he had.

The son of the respected Ayanokōji Atsuomi.

There was no way he wouldn't be capable, but he couldn't fervently convey that to the others.

Specifically here, right now—

"Kanzaki-kun."

"—What?"

"Before you talk about that, could you listen to my story for a bit?"

As if anticipating his thoughts, Ichinose's words momentarily overpowered Kanzaki.

It was neither intimidating nor threatening.

Just her usual tone of voice and expression somehow made him lose his voice.

"The reason I lost the end-of-year special exam was due to my mental weakness. Regardless of the content of the exam or who the opponent was, I had to at least match them evenly, or even above that."

First, Ichinose explained to her comrades the reflection she couldn't make at the end of the exam.

"I lost to Ayanokōji-kun because I lost sight of the essence of the game. I want everyone to know what psychological state I was in at that time."

These were feelings she had never spoken aloud before.

"I've… liked Ayanokōji-kun for some time now."

She let her classmates hear her feelings without blushing or panicking.

Shibata was the most surprised. He gaped his mouth wide and couldn't find the words.

Ichinose continued, paying no attention to his reaction.

"I believed without a doubt that Ayanokōji-kun was thinking of me at that time. But as soon as the exam started, such naive assumptions were shattered."

She had been approached to use the traitor rights to avoid expulsions.

By agreeing to this, Ayanokōji had implicated Ichinose in Maezono's expulsion.

The classmates listened intently to this first revelation during the representative battle.

At the same time, it touched upon Ayanokōji's true nature, which Kanzaki wanted them to know about.

A student who didn't stand out much.

That was simply deception; he was extremely calm and capable of making accurate judgments.

Ichinose wanted to convey his superiority with her own words, not through Kanzaki.

"Is Ayanokōji-kun really... such an amazing student?"

Himeno was struggling to comprehend, and as if she herself was being praised, Ichinose narrowed her eyes happily towards her. Himeno sensed that he was no ordinary student, but there was a significant gap in their understanding.

"I, too… only truly understood him during that exam. It wasn't the only factor, but if Ayanokōji-kun hadn't been there, Horikita-san's class wouldn't have made it to Class A."

Essentially, it wasn't Horikita's class but Ayanokōji's class.

"Wow, no, wow... wow, Ayanokōji, he's that amazing, huh? Wow... I haven't had much contact with him, so I never thought about it. I mean, isn't that more like you respect him rather than you liking him?"

Shibata, in a panic, prayed that Ichinose was merely expressing herself incorrectly or misunderstanding.

"I certainly respect him. But more than that, I like Ayanokōji-kun."

Ichinose answered confidently, feeling her body heat up. It wasn't because their skin made contact, but probably because she had momentarily touched a side of Ayanokōji's heart that even Karuizawa couldn't see.

"Wow… to make Ichinose say so much… What's going on…?"

Norihito was stunned by Ichinose's words, which seemed more than just a one-sided crush. He glanced at Amikura, whom he had feelings for. Amikura was pleased with Ichinose's newfound ability to express her feelings clearly, sensing that something happened during their consultations. Perhaps a relationship beyond imagination developed between them.

"Yeah, but, you know. Ayanokōji has a girlfriend, right?"

"Shibata-kun... Um, it's hard to say, but... I heard that Ayanokōji-kun and Karuizawa-san recently broke up."

Amikura didn't want to crush his hopes, but she decided to quickly inform him.

Immediately after, Shibata slumped over the desk and ceased moving.

"Anyway... you should now fully understand. We have no chance of winning."

Kanzaki had been partially listening to the small talk up until this point, but he saw this as the time to make everyone agree to a change of strategy for the class, looking to correct the course of the conversation.

"Now is the time to switch to collecting private points."

A complete shift to accumulating private points instead of aiming for Class A.

Ichinose had once used up the funds pooled by her classmates for their sake, but she was starting to save again. If she maximized the rate at which she's saving, they might get several tickets to Class A.

"Kanzaki, you really think it's better to give up on winning..."

"Sorry, but I'm not asking for your opinion right now, Norihito. Answer me, Ichinose."

His optimistic statement was just a delaying tactic in that situation.

"Indeed, if reaching Class A is difficult, relying on private points isn't a bad idea. Even the former Class A must've considered this option several times."

By their third year, it would be a showdown between Horikita's class and Ryūen's class.

Some students were beginning to accept that situation.

"But I still think this class can fight. We can aim for Class A."

"That's impossible. I can't believe you've done any analysis of our fighting potential."

"Hey, Kanzaki. Even if it's difficult to catch up as you say, aiming for it isn't bad, right? Having a goal to strive for makes a huge difference in motivation."

Norihito, perhaps influenced by Ichinose, moved to persuade Kanzaki despite being told to be quiet.

Still, without any basis, he couldn't accept it.

"It's inefficient. Sure, you're free to aim for it, and you're also free to aspire towards that goal. However, naturally, that freedom comes with a cost."

"I don't know, is there really a cost?"

"Plenty. If it's an exam where you need to increase your forces to win, spending private points could be key to victory. And it's not just limited to that situation. Gathering information or avoiding some penalty would also cost points. Or what if… our class faces an expulsion crisis? Will you prepare another 20 million points each time?"

Kanzaki's strategy implied not wasting resources. If they gave up most of the battles, they could save on private point consumption.

"Are you planning to give up on Class A and abandon your friends too?"

"It's not just me, we need everyone in the class to think this way."

"No, not everyone..."

Norihito tried to forcibly silence him, but Kanzaki seized the moment to press on.

"Himeno, and Hamaguchi too, what do you think about this?"

He reached out to the two, hoping to gather more allies.

"Well... yeah. To be honest, I think it's something we should consider."

"I think so too... Saving private points isn't a bad idea at all."

“See? It’s not just me. There are other students in the class who think the same way.”

“No, wait, are you guys out of your mind? Don’t be ridiculous. Sacrificing our friends to transfer just one or two people to Class A as a goal? No way, that’s absolutely not happening. We have to stick to the policy that we either win or lose as a whole class.”

Lying face down until then, Shibata raised his head and spoke. His eyes were slightly moist with sadness, but he felt he couldn’t overlook Kanzaki’s idea.

“I think so too.”

“R-Right…? Ichinose…?”

Seeing Ichinose’s agreeing smile, Shibata felt his heart torn again and buried his face in the desk.

“Enough with the idealism.”

“It certainly is idealism.”

Responding to Kanzaki’s remark, Ichinose immediately agreed.

“We have fought so far without expelling a single person. That’s undoubtedly a strength, but we can’t deny that we’ve continued to lose class points as a consequence. However… sometimes, these idealisms do bear fruit.”

She answered confidently, but of course, Kanzaki couldn’t see any clear vision.

It sounded like nothing more than dreams and ideals.

“Once again, I want to graduate from Class A without losing a single classmate.”

“Even though you know it’s impossible?”

“No, it’s not impossible.”

“I can’t trust that at all. I acknowledge that you’ve mentally recovered since the exam, but I can’t accept being told that we can move up to Class A lightly.”

“That’s right. We need to stop just saying that it’s okay and start conveying it with something other than words. Over the past two years, we’ve indeed fallen from Class B to Class D.”

Taking in Kanzaki’s pointed remarks, Ichinose nodded as if it were only natural.

“But could you wait until the day after spring break ends?”

“Are you trying to say that you’ll prove it by then?”

“Yes. If you’re not satisfied with the answer at that time, then I’ll seriously consider your proposal, Kanzaki-kun.”

The strategy would shift from winning in class rankings to accumulating private points.

If Ichinose agreed, their classmates would follow, albeit reluctantly.

Just a few more days. Time was precious, but it was worth accepting the conditions.

"You won't retract your words just now?"

"I won't retract them. I don't have the right or qualification to guarantee that I can make everyone graduate in Class A. But I promise, I'll bring our class to a state where we can have a fair fight for Class A."

Ichinose looked around at the gathered classmates, seeking confirmation.

While everyone was confused, they nodded, putting off the conclusion for the moment.

From there, it was the usual Ichinose.

She happily and sadly shared the events of the past two weeks.

Shibata wanted to ask about Ayanokōji the whole time. However, perhaps thinking it was difficult to ask sensitive questions in front of the others, he ended up not saying anything.

Nothing had progressed yet. Holding onto that hope, he decided to wait.

The warm moments within Ichinose's class had returned.

Kanzaki watched with cold eyes but endured, having promised to wait a few more days.

Then, as he stood up to wash his hands, Ichinose followed him.

"Kanzaki-kun."

"...What?"

"Don't you have something to report to me?"

"Something to report?"

Stopping in his tracks and turning around, Kanzaki couldn't predict where the conversation was going and looked at Ichinose suspiciously.

"I believe that the results of the end-of-year special exam are my responsibility. However,  Kanzaki-kun, don't you think there should be an explanation about whether you fought appropriately for a representative? Or is there no explanation for that?"

"Fought appropriately? I fought seriously and lost to Horikita. It's frustrating, but that's the truth."

"Had you decided to beg your opponent to give up their victory before the exam?"

"That's..."

"You've given up on winning from the start. I wish you had consulted us."

"Did you… hear this from Horikita…? Or—"

"Who told me isn't important."

"R-Right. However... that was the only strategy I thought I could win with. I don't care about appearances—it can't be helped. At that time, I judged that it was the only thing I could do—"

Kanzaki tried to continue his explanation confidently while looking into Ichinose's eyes. However, he gasped immediately after.

It was completely different from the figure who'd been listening to their classmates' words until just a moment ago.

"In front of Shibata and the others... Saying in front of them that I actually begged to be given the win—revealing such a thing would definitely lower morale. That's the only reason I didn't speak up."

He ended up desperately making excuses, even though he wasn't deeply pressed.

"You concluded that I couldn't beat Ayanokōji-kun, right?"

"That is—"

Deep eyes grasped Kanzaki's true intentions.

"I understand that anxiety well. I know how hard it is to feel like no one understands you. But, it's okay now."

*What was okay?* Kanzaki didn't have the courage to ask back.

"I'm sorry. Indeed, my way of fighting wasn't praiseworthy..."

"If you ever have trouble, feel free to consult me anytime. I'll be there to support you when you feel alone."

Those were kind words. However, Kanzaki felt a chill down his spine.

It felt like a warning—never act selfishly again.

Ichinose turned around and went back down to her classmates.

And when she sat down, her expression looked no different than usual.

"Was that really Ichinose...?"

It was different from the confidence shown just before the end-of-year special exam and from the exhaustion shown right after it. There was a strange, eerie feeling about her.

# Chapter 10:
# Goals

At long last, with the new semester starting on Monday, we would be facing our final year as third-year students.

Horikita and I were the first to arrive at the 2-B classroom, and students adorning their uniforms began to gather one after another. Under the condition that no one would dirty or trash it, it looked like we were allowed to use the classroom for just one hour. The number of seats here was adjusted to 39, one less due to Yagami's expulsion, tailored to the new second-year Class B. While each person was responsible for bringing their own drinks, Sudō managed to borrow a tea-filled, tank-style insulated container from the basketball club. Or in other words, he borrowed a water jug. Additionally, several girls brought pots, offering hot cocoa and cold tea out of goodwill.

Soon, I caught the eye of girls like Satō, who were close to Karuizawa, but they didn't confront me here. It seemed they didn't want to dampen the celebratory mood.

However, it was clear that my relationship with them had significantly regressed.

It showed how deeply they cared for their friend and empathized with her emotions. A commendable trait indeed.

In addition, I noticed several classmates casting wary glances my way. Those who had now experienced a glimpse of my abilities were feeling a strange unease I had never sensed previously, all the way from the entrance ceremony up until now. Eventually, as the scheduled time arrived, a total of 35 people gathered. Karuizawa and Kōenji didn't show up.

The celebration began without all classmates present.

"Karuizawa-san doesn't seem to be participating... Was she really the one who dumped you, like you said?"

Horikita speculated that if Karuizawa had been the one who initiated the break-up, she would've been participating today without a worry.

She must've noticed Satō and others looking at me with somewhat cold glances.

"Maybe she simply had other plans or wasn't feeling well?"

"...Right, that's true."

Hearing Karuizawa's name, Yōsuke approached, concerned.

"Can I talk for a moment? About Karuizawa-san... I've heard the story."

Horikita immediately stepped back, silently showing that she wouldn't interfere with our conversation.

"I'm sorry I couldn't meet your expectations, Yōsuke, after all the help you gave me."

“That’s nothing to apologize for. It’s unfortunate that your relationship ended, but that’s just how it is. Besides, I’m not in a position to judge others either.”

In front of Horikita, Yōsuke also had to play the role of someone who Karuizawa had broken up with, even if their relationship was fake.

“Have you heard about Karuizawa’s condition, Yōsuke?”

“Looks like Satō-san invited her here, but it didn’t work out. I don’t know what I can do for her in the future, but I intend to help when she’s in trouble. And not just Karuizawa-san, I’ll take care of our class so everyone can move forward with confidence. So, don’t worry.”

Even setting aside Karuizawa’s situation, Yōsuke must have a grievance or two he wanted to voice.

His words revealed that he wasn’t satisfied with Maezono’s expulsion.

But he already understood that he couldn’t just complain.

That was why he’d resolved, once again, to protect the class.

‘Don’t worry.’ Yōsuke referred to his own condition in those words as well.

“If you ever feel lost, Ayanokōji-kun... I want you to talk to me.”

“Horikita told me something similar. Thank you, Yōsuke.”

“...Yeah. Well then, I’ll go talk with everyone for a bit.”

Though it wasn’t his usual, Yōsuke showed his characteristic smile and headed down to his classmates.

“Deep down, he understands it too—that the choice you made was actually the right one.”

“Horikita, is there really a need to force ourselves to think it was right? However, the world doesn’t just revolve around idealism. And people don’t grow easily. Things aren’t that simple. That’s why it’s fine for him to struggle all he wants with it.”

It would be good if, within this class, after struggling and struggling, we could find an answer that was closer to the correct one.

“You really are strong, Ayanokōji-kun.”

“I’m just thick-skinned, that’s all. Just as I don’t mind being blamed, I don’t care about the lack of praise either.”

There was no need for others to acknowledge my achievements.

I understood and analyzed myself as a person superior to anyone else.

“I see... but I am grateful to you. I wanted to express that to you properly.”

“Even though it led to Maezono being expelled?”

“It was an exam where we couldn’t have won without someone’s expulsion. Besides, in the end, it’s not your problem—it’s mine. I need to grow more. And I don’t just need one option, but I need to be able to choose from two or three of them. I need to gain enough strength to win without having to expel anyone anymore.”

After answering, Horikita showed a small, wry smile.

"I've thought that way many times, but I never quite seem to get there."

"That's true. Even though time has passed, it's just a small fraction of our lives. We still don't have nearly enough time to develop the skills to handle everything perfectly."

Horikita agreed and headed to the podium as her classmates called out to her.

# 1

The victory celebration had begun, and it was now nearing its end.

I, Horikita, watched the final moments of excitement from the back of the classroom a small distance away.

Then, Ayanokōji-kun came over and handed me a paper cup. It smelled of sweet cocoa.

"Thank you."

Then we stood side by side, watching our classmates.

Now, the people here each stated their goals for next year.

In the midst of this, it was Ike-kun's turn.

I thought he'd do something silly again to draw attention, but it didn't seem so.

"...You know, I've been thinking all spring break—Maezono, who's expelled now… can she really manage from now on?"

"Hey, Kanji. Are you planning to bring down the mood here?"

Sudō-kun tried to stop him, seemingly thinking that he was trying to bring up the topic again.

But Ike-kun shook his head, denying it, and continued speaking.

"No, that's not it. But it was sudden, right? It means that it wouldn't be strange if any of us were next... Truthfully, I began to realize it's wrong to just live carelessly every day."

"Well, it's important to be prepared for whatever may happen."

Yukimura-kun agreed, responding to Ike-kun.

"I've never seriously thought about my own future. Not even once."

Beyond the fuss about expulsions, their own futures were at stake.

Always looking ahead and acting so that it'd be okay even if they were expelled from school tomorrow.

*Seems like he realized how important that is.*

"It isn't easy to become someone who can do the obvious things naturally, be it studying or keeping secrets. But if you've realized that, maybe you can do it. Don't forget that."

As if a teacher was giving advice to a student, Yukimura-kun said as much.

After that, the class took turns heading to the podium to speak.

"Even just basing off Ike and the others' discussion, it looks like most of the class is gradually growing."

"That's true. It's a world of difference compared to when we first enrolled, Ayanokōji-kun."

"What's your goal, Horikita?"

"Me? My goal is..."

I decided to let nature take its course—thinking too deeply seemed likely to lead me astray.

"To believe in myself and in my classmates… I think. If we can achieve that... we should definitely be able to graduate from Class A."

A small, determined declaration.

It was surely a declaration that would continue to torment me in the future.

Nevertheless, I wanted to show my resolve by making sure Ayanokōji-kun heard it, cutting off any path of retreat.

"That's a good goal."

"I-Is it? It might seem obvious, but..."

"Doing the obvious can be surprisingly difficult."

"...Yes... that's true."

It was supposed to be easy.

It certainly wasn't easy, though.

"What's your goal?"

"I'm not telling you now."

"Hey, wait a minute, that's not fair!"

I pressed Ayanokōji-kun, unsatisfied that I was the only one who had spoken.

His face came closer, and somehow, I felt a bit embarrassed and hurriedly backed up a little.

"Well... fine. Tell me next time."

"Next time."

I escaped his cheeky gaze, looking out the window.

There were many things I didn't like about him, but Ayanokōji-kun's presence was truly reassuring.

I couldn't deny that he was a source of support.

As I calmed myself, looking at the scenery outside for a while, another goal emerged.

"In another year, I want to become a classmate you can acknowledge again."

I spoke naturally about what came to mind.

"I won't ask you to help me with everything, but I want you to keep watching over me…"

I glanced at Ayanokōji-kun standing next to me, slightly aware of my warming cheeks.

However…

Ayanokōji-kun, who should've been there until a moment ago, had disappeared.

"...Ayanokōji-kun?"

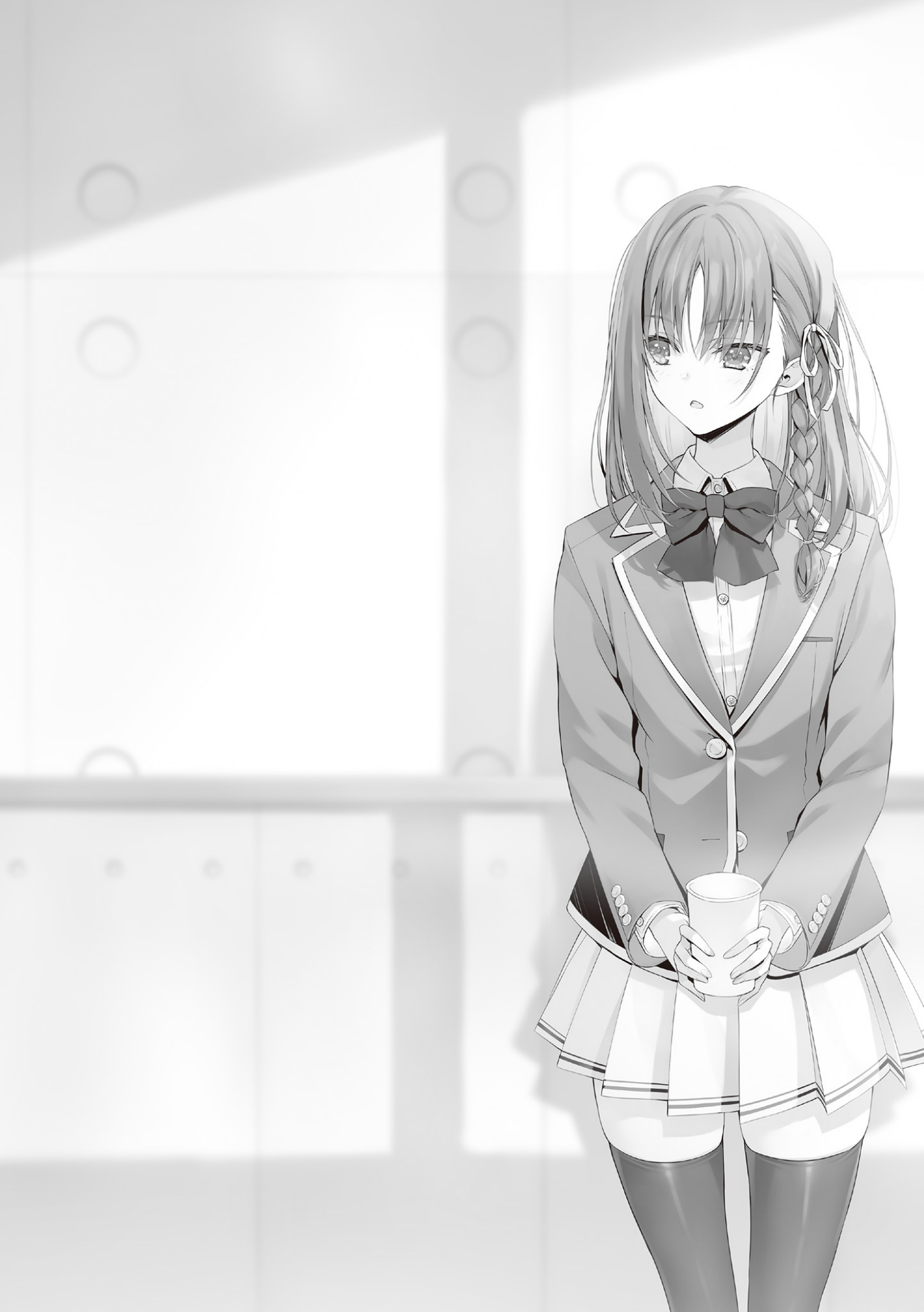
No matter where I looked around the class, he was nowhere to be found.

*Maybe he went to the restroom?*

Normally, that would be the only thought.

Yet... strangely, there was a feeling of loneliness—of sadness.

…And even after the victory celebration ended, he didn't return to the classroom.



# Epilogue:
# A New Beginning

AFTER THE OPENING CEREMONY, the teachers gathered in the staff room for a brief meeting.

Soon, it would be time for the teachers to head to the classrooms where their students were waiting.

"Let's go together for a bit, Sae-chan."

For the first time since they'd met in Mashima's room during the spring break, Hoshinomiya called out to Chabashira.

They left the staff room ahead of the other teachers.

"Ah, yes."

Hastily grabbing her tablet, Chabashira followed.

"You're curious about what I'm going to do from here on, aren't you?"

"Naturally. You'll let me hear your thoughts, right...?"

"Of course. I won't change—I absolutely won't let Sae-chan graduate from Class A."

*Ayanokōji isn't just any student.*

*He just might manage to come up with a solution.*

She had harbored that faint hope, but it remained an unfulfilled dream.

Of course, it was natural that he couldn't do it.

*It isn't a problem between students, but one that transcends beyond that. It's a matter between teachers, after all.*

Or so she had thought.

"Then, are you seriously going to resort to misconduct?"

"Ah, right, that was an issue. Wait, wait. Then, I should properly let you know."

Chabashira braced herself. If Hoshinomiya admitted it there, she would take the initiative to report it to the school.

She had resolved to prevent it from happening.

"What I said before about resorting to cheating to stop you from finishing as Class A—I'm retracting that statement."

Contrary to expectations, Hoshinomiya spat out a line as if she'd had a change of heart.

"I-Is that really true? You're not just lying because you're in front of me, are you?"

"I understand why you're doubting me, but it's true. I promise."

'Promise.' Hoshinomiya clearly stated it.

Upon hearing this, rather than feeling happy, Chabashira was first struck by surprise and agitation.

“Does that mean... instead of resorting to misconduct, you’re going to impose something on me in exchange?”

“Not at all. Sae-chan, you should just continue seriously engaging with everyone in your class just as you’ve been doing. I’m not going to be imposing any conditions on you here.”

“But then...”

“I know. So, you’re wondering why I changed my mind... right?”

To that perfectly natural question, Chabashira nodded firmly.

“Ayanokōji-kun persuaded me, so I accepted the situation as it is now.”

“Ayanokōji did...? Really?”

“Really. He’s an amazing student, isn’t he? Not only can he easily influence the outcome of the class competition, but he can even manipulate my resentful feelings toward you. He’s truly like a joker, right?”

Previously, Hoshinomiya compared Ayanokōji to a joker.

In the midst of the surprising conversation, that thought briefly crossed Chabashira’s mind.

“Are you curious about what he did to persuade me?”

“Yes... honestly, it’s still hard to believe.”

“Right? But don’t worry. I think you’ll soon realize that this is true, Sae-chan.”

Afterward, they finished climbing the stairs and approached the corridor where the third-year classrooms were located.

“Because…”

After climbing the last step and turning the corner, the corridor came into view.

At that moment, Hoshinomiya directed her most malicious smile toward Chabashira.

“Now, Sae-chan, you no longer have the joker you need to win.”

“The Joker is... gone...? What do you mean...?”

Comparing Ayanokōji to a joker, and then saying the joker wasn’t in her hands anymore.

Confused by her unclear words, Chabashira was bewildered.

“Yes. And if that joker joins our side, the battle dynamic changes significantly. Then, I might see a chance to win. So, let’s fight fairly in the next school year.”

Saying so, Hoshinomiya, who reached the door of Class 3-D, smiled wickedly.

“Come on, why don’t you go to your classroom and check?”

“Check...? Chie, what on earth are you talking about…?”

She had a doubt. However, immediately after, a thought she would never normally consider crossed her mind.

"Ahahaha. I'm looking forward to seeing your face turn to despair."

Saying so, Hoshinomiya entered the classroom and slammed the door shut.

*It couldn't be.* As a possibility—one that was less than 1%—filled her thoughts, Chabashira finally reached the farthest classroom, resisting the urge to run.

The room sign read "3-A," a sight she'd dreamed of.

A staff member rushed over, flustered, toward Chabashira.

"Chabashira-sensei… just now, a student transfer from your class was decided—!"

Half of the staff's continued explanation failed to reach Chabashira's ears.

# 1

Just before entering the classroom, this class's homeroom teacher was stopped by a member of staff.

Upon seeing me standing next to the staff, the teacher stared at me in shock as they learned of the circumstances.

Having reconciled our understanding, the two of us entered the classroom.

The opening ceremony ended, and it should've been time to start the homeroom period.

The students had been kept waiting.

An unfamiliar scene.

A student with a nervous, almost bitter, smile.

A student sizing me up with a stern face.

A student who welcomed me with a smile.

A classroom that somehow contained a new and different scent.

Although there were students who looked at me strangely, none were completely astounded.

This was because they'd been informed beforehand that I would appear at this time.

Only the homeroom teacher, who hadn't been informed, was yet to accept the reality.

"Just after the opening ceremony, I used 20 million private points to transfer to this class. I am Ayanokōji Kiyotaka. I cannot replace Sakayanagi, who voluntarily withdrew, but if all my classmates still have the will to fight, I am confident that I can help overcome the greatly deteriorated situation."

With all the private points I earned.

With all the private points Hashimoto saved for the transfer.

And with all the students within this class in agreement, they pooled their private points equally to make up the deficit, gathering a total of 20 million private points.

That enabled my transfer to this class.

*With this class filled with so many capable students, they'll surely do a good job. They'll be convenient when controlling various aspects on the gameboard.*

The initial vision—a battle for Class A among the four third-year classes.

*This might not be its ideal form in the truest sense.*

*But still, the preparations are completed…*

My final year began in this new class.

# Author's Postscript

After entering November, it suddenly turned cold. Kinugasa here.

My son is currently in a big Mario craze, insisting on dressing as a Red Koopa for Halloween, and everything has to be about Mario when watching TV. If he loves it this much, I'd like to take him to USJ someday. I want to try my best as a parent, but whether it can be realized...

Also, about my recent condition, my hernia has recovered about 40% compared to when it was severe. I can't work as long continuously as I could when I was healthy, but I'm getting a bit more capable of pushing myself, so I hope to bring better news next time.

Now, about the second-year edition. This time, it's about the spring break episode, which I think was a peaceful and happy volume for everyone. Oh, but that's just my personal opinion, so no complaints if the reality is different. You'll have to see for yourself what it's like, but with this volume, the second-year edition concludes. There were parts that were hard to fit into the main story or parts I had to tearfully cut out due to page limits, which is a shame because they might've deepened the understanding of the work... but it would be nice to have a chance to publish a short story about such spring break events somewhere.

Anyway, thank you all for sticking with us until the completion of the second-year edition! But the third-year edition is starting soon, so please continue supporting us! The third-year edition will return to the roots, focusing on battles within the same year like the first-year edition. Even though it's the same stage, the positions have changed significantly, so I think we can deliver a fresh story until the end.

Also, the official guidebook for You-Zitsu will be released.

It would be great if you could pick it up as it reviews the series so far and prepares for the third-year edition. I'm looking forward to it myself, reminiscing about what happened.

So, I hope to see you around March. See you!

# Hiyori Shiina's Short Story:
# Friends?

ISHIZAKI-KUN WAS SERIOUSLY CONSIDERING ways to make Ayanokōji-kun join as a comrade.

*I hope it happens, but I think it'll still be difficult.*

"That is...! Well then! Let's do this!"

"Do this?"

Seemingly struck by a new idea, Ishizaki-kun smiled.

I couldn't predict what he would say next, so I was somewhat excited.

"If you come to our class, you can date Shiina! How about that?"

Suddenly, Ishizaki-kun grabbed both Ayanokōji-kun's hand as well as mine, bringing them together and raising them up.

"Eh, eh...?"

I couldn't understand what was happening, but before I knew it, I was holding that hand.

"What kind of proposal is that…?"

"It's an aspect your class doesn't have, but ours does!"

"I already have a girlfriend, you know?"

"So what, just break up with Karuizawa when you change classes!"

The warmth of Ayanokōji-kun's palm—as if responding, my hand subconsciously warmed up, and I felt embarrassed by it.

*Why has this situation even come about...*

The situation changed in an instant, and my mind was in a panic.

"That's absurd."

"So you don't like Shiina then?"

At Ishizaki-kun's words asking if he disliked me, I found myself staring at Ayanokōji-kun without thinking.

"I don't dislike her."

First came relief, then joy bubbled up amidst the panic.

*I need to get a grip on the situation and calm down...*

Ayanokōji-kun was an important friend, nothing more, nothing less.

"Then there's no problem, right? You like Ayanokōji too, don't you, Shiina?"

Just when I thought I could calm down, Ishizaki-kun said something unpredictable again.

"Eh...!?"

Ayanokōji-kun said he didn't dislike me, which was a relief.

*But now... my feelings, you say...?*

*If it's a matter of like or dislike, of course, I like him... Because Ayanokōji-kun is...*

I failed to control the emotions I had almost managed to rein in.

"Give it a rest, Ishizaki. It's better not to trouble Hiyori. It's cruel to make someone express their feelings in front of the person concerned, whether she likes them or not. Only a few people can say they don't like someone to their face."

"But, you know, Shiina is quite straightforward about what she wants to say..."

*It's true that normally, I tend to speak what's on my mind relatively openly. But, I feel like I shouldn't say that...*

"Um... this is troubling."

Perhaps Ayanokōji-kun noticed my pathetic feelings. Perhaps he was pretending not to notice, sparing me the concern.

Ayanokōji-kun gently released my heated hand.

*If only he could become closer... like maybe a classmate...* While I wasn't like Ishizaki-kun, that was what I found myself thinking. *Also, to seal these strange feelings, I need to shift my focus...*

"...Hiyori?"

"May I say just one thing, even if it's hopeless...?"

Hiding my feelings on the topic of like or dislike, I decided to invite Ayanokōji-kun just one more time. I thought my desire to be in the same class was unmatched.

# Ichinose Honami's Short Story:
# The Other Side of the Promise

THE WORLD WAS DARK, and only the sound of the rain could be heard when the chime rang.

I hugged my knees and kept my head down, slowly breathing out with my eyes closed.

The time had come.

Yet, I didn't move my body to respond to the chime.

Soon, the phone on the bed lit up.

It faintly vibrated three, then four times.

I listened to the sound, still not moving.

Then, there was a gentle knock on the door.

"It's me. The deadline for our promise is about to end, that's why I came here."

It was Ayanokōji-kun's voice.

I knew I would hear it today.

I knew this moment would come before the day of the promise ended.

Because today, I had been continuously ignoring Ayanokōji-kun's calls since the morning.

He came to convey his conclusion before the night grew late and the date changed.

"I'll wait just three more minutes. If there's no response, I'll leave, so don't worry."

This was the final notice.

If I didn't respond now, Ayanokōji-kun would leave from beyond the door.

But if I did respond, Ayanokōji-kun would surely reply.

I reached for the phone that was within arm's reach and typed a message.

*['Why did you come?']*

*['I told you. Today was the promised day.']*

*['It's already late at night. It's past curfew.']*

I hinted that he should go back and checked Ayanokōji-kun's reaction.

*['I don't have the courage to go to your room right now, Ayanokōji-kun. Sorry.']*

*['I understand that. That's why I came here.']*

As expected, Ayanokōji-kun didn't leave.

The fact that he wouldn't leave—I knew that too

*['I'll wait one more minute. If the door doesn't open by then, let's pretend the promise never happened.']*

I wouldn't run away.

I had to meet Ayanokōji-kun today. I had to keep that promise.

However…
It wouldn't be in Ayanokōji-kun's room.
*['The door is unlocked, come in.']*
In my room, we would fulfill the promise we made a year ago.
It wasn't because I lacked the courage to go to him.
I thought it was best for us to meet here.
My intuition turned into conviction.
What Ayanokōji-kun wanted to convey.
What I had to convey to Ayanokōji-kun.
I understood it all.

# Chabashira Sae's Short Story: Since When…

I WAITED NEAR KEYAKI MALL for Ayanokōji to arrive.

A consultation requested by a student.

*Honestly, I could hardly imagine such a thing years ago.*

*I suppose I pushed my students away because I was treating them coldly.*

In such a state, no one would open their hearts and come to me for a consultation.

But recently, students gradually started opening up and talking to me.

They spoke about their career paths, job hunting, and friendships.

Having touched both the past and present as well as the light and darkness of the unanimous vote special exam, I was able to change.

And this was undoubtedly thanks to Ayanokōji.

I had become capable of facing myself and the students.

"However, well..."

Meeting one-on-one with a male student on a day off was certainly unexpected.

If it weren't for Ayanokōji requesting this consultation, to whom I owed a debt of gratitude, I wouldn't have allowed it.

I had no intention of mixing personal matters with work... but yes, this time was special.

"I'm sorry to keep you waiting."

Soon, the awaited person arrived.

*Was I kept waiting?* I checked the time just in case.

"You haven't really kept me waiting. There's still some time before our appointment; no need to worry."

More importantly, this one-on-one situation was still unsettling.

"I never thought I'd be meeting a student at Keyaki Mall."

"Has this never happened before?"

"Of course not."

Meeting with the opposite sex on a holiday—this was the first time since my student days.

*My memory of it has already faded, and it certainly didn't become a good memory either, however…*

*No, that's a completely different story.*

What Ayanokōji was talking about now was between a teacher and a student.

In other words, my past, cold self never had such an opportunity before.

"Ah, I see. Sensei, in the past, you deliberately kept a distance from students—"

He rudely intruded into my thoughts without mercy.

"Ayanokōji. You speak too lightly."

"I apologize."

"An apology is not enough, isn’t it?"

"...Was there really a need to meet at Keyaki Mall?"

If we moved from here, other students would inevitably see us.

Honestly, it wasn’t a favorable situation.

"I understand your sentiment, but I judged that meeting here was the best option."

"I’d like to know the reason for that decision."

Ayanokōji was my student, and certainly nothing more.

*Considering the Maezono incident as well, this situation is an emergency.*

As the class aimed to reach greater heights, Ayanokōji's presence was indispensable.

*As a teacher, I must make an effort to provide emotional support…*

# Yamamura Miki and Morishita Ai's Short Story: Truly Observing

CRAWLING ON THE GROUND, Morishita continued to stare at the soil through a magnifying glass.

Yamamura had been watching this scene in astonishment for over 20 minutes.

"Shouldn't we head to the meeting location now...?"

"Not yet. Please don't disturb me and just wait quietly."

"But... we're already past the meeting time, you know...?"

"What's the harm in making him wait? It used to be the era when women waited. Now it's the era when men wait instead."

"I-Is that so...?"

Yamamura, who had never heard such a thing, asked again, but Morishita ignored her and continued observing.

As she gripped her cellphone and stared at the time, a call from Ayanokōji finally rang.

"Ah, um, sorry I'm late."

*I guess I really need to hurry,* Yamamura thought as she looked at Morishita, who gave her a sharp glare.

Then, she gestured vigorously to hang up the phone.

"Eh, hang up the phone…? But… it's past the time we agreed…"

*'Is Morishita with you by any chance?'*

Perhaps frustrated by the ongoing phone call, Morishita stood up and approached Yamamura.

"Ye-yes. Um, please come to the back of the dorm, ah, stop messing with my phone—"

Morishita then forcefully grabbed the cell phone from Yamamura's hand and pressed the button to end the call.

"Um, Ayanokōji-kun must be troubled..."

"That's fine, Yamamura Miki. I am testing Ayanokōji Kiyotaka."

"T-Testing...?"

After returning the stolen cellphone to Yamamura, Morishita went back to searching for bugs.

"Yes, a test. I want to know in detail what kind of attitude he shows when he's kept waiting, how he behaves, and how he acts towards us."

"...W-Why would you do such a thing?"

"Something about Ayanokōji Kiyotaka is fishy. He's trying to use us for something. Also, I've heard a little from Sakayanagi Arisu... Oops, but that's a secret, okay?"

After answering, Morishita fell silent.

Her bottom fidgeted.

She was so engrossed that occasionally her underwear was visible beneath her skirt.

"I have no idea what you're talking about..."

Yamamura wanted to ask more, but Morishita didn’t answer.

# First-Year Guidebook Short Story: First Contact

IT WAS JUST PAST 4:30 PM on April 1st.

The female student, Horikita Suzune, was waiting in front of the school entrance.

Even though she had no business relating to the school itself, she had come here for a single purpose.

She wanted to see Ayanokōji's family.

Such curiosity had driven her to this place.

"Surely it's not over yet, right...?"

She opened the schedule on her phone just in case and reconfirmed that Ayanokōji's three-way meeting started at 4:30 PM. Therefore, she figured they were still talking in the counseling room. Since it was mandatory to wear a uniform to enter the school, she had come dressed in it just in case, but she had no intention of boldly stepping inside. She only planned to make brief contact, pretending it was a coincidence. She didn't think Ayanokōji would blatantly object to it, but if he seemed annoyed, she intended to leave immediately.

Soon, an unexpected male student approached where Horikita was alone waiting.

She waited for the male student, Ryūen, to pass by silently, but he stopped next to Horikita.

"...Do you need something from me, Ryūen-kun?"

"Huh? I don't need anything from you."

"...Then why are you here? You don't seem to be wearing a uniform either."

"I'm free to go wherever I want. What are you doing here? The three-way meetings should’ve ended by now."

The schedules for other classes weren’t generally made public. Thus, it was apparent from Ryūen's words that he had obtained the information beforehand from someone within her class.

"I was just curious about something."

Ryūen closed his eyes and faintly chuckled in response.

"What a coincidence. I also came here because I was curious about something."

Saying that, he leaned against the wall next to Horikita. It was as if this was his destination as well.

Just from those actions, Horikita realized he had the same purpose as her.

"Is that so? Then I guess I have no right to stop you."

Horikita also stood her ground and crossed her arms.

"It's impossible not to be curious. Anyone would want to know what kinds of parents and methods raised that monster. Whether he came from a surprisingly normal environment or not, I want to know at least that much."

"Right. I couldn't resist the temptation either. Honestly, I can't imagine it at all."

"Maybe he shows a face in front of his parents that he doesn't show anywhere else."

"I wonder. It seems to me that his attitude doesn't change no matter where he is or who he's with..."

After a while of standing silently by each other's sides, they heard the sound of visitor footwear, different from the indoor shoes. Horikita and Ryūen subconsciously tensed their expressions.

What Ryūen and Horikita soon saw was an adult in a suit they had never seen before.

With a phone in one hand, he appeared to be on a call with someone.

"Ah. It seems it will take a little more time, please wait—"

As the conversation's details faintly reached them, the adult noticed Horikita and Ryūen's gazes and ended the call. Horikita was about to speak up but was momentarily intimidated by his stern expression, carrying an undeniable force.

They couldn't be certain whether the adult in front of them was actually Ayanokōji's family.

Nevertheless, Horikita and Ryūen intuitively felt that he must've been Ayanokōji's father. However, he was different from what Horikita had imagined. She had thought that Ayanokōji's parents might've been expressionless and somewhat listless, but that notion was instantly shattered.

A strict father. That would be everyone's first impression.

"Um... excuse me."

Horikita managed to muster her voice and hesitantly spoke.

"...And you are?"

"I'm Horikita, a classmate of Ayanokōji... of Kiyotaka-kun. Actually, I was waiting here for Ayanokōji-kun..."

She started speaking in such a way because she had thought the parent and child would appear together.

"Ah. Kiyotaka is still upstairs talking with his homeroom teacher."

"Is that so? Um, you are Ayanokōji-kun's father... right?"

Ayanokōji couldn't ignore her and nodded in affirmation.

Horikita couldn't shake off the stern and intimidating impression their first meeting gave off, but she was momentarily relieved that her responses were clear. Of course, Horikita and Ryūen had no way of knowing that the man in front of them was a politician. Few politicians were discussed on TV. Among the

many members of the Japanese Diet, it was impossible to recognize Ayanokōji Atsuomi's face—he disliked the mass media, crawling at the bottom of the earth. However, his constantly stern expression drove them to speculate that he must be someone strict.

"Are you also Kiyotaka's classmate?"

Atsuomi, who was being silently appraised by him, addressed Ryūen.

"No, I don't think so? I'm neither a classmate nor a friend. I'm just that guy's enemy."

"Wait, wait, Ryūen-kun, you—"

Horikita was flustered by Ryūen's behavior, declaring Atsuomi's own child as an enemy upon their first meeting, but the man looked impressed as he listened.

"An enemy... huh?"

"He's given us a hard time over these past two years. That guy's dangerous."

"Ryūen-kun."

*He wouldn't like his son being referred to as someone dangerous.*

Horikita repeatedly cautioned him in a fluster...

"It's fine. I suppose he shows you two a side of himself that he doesn't usually show."

Surprisingly, Ayanokōji's father showed a tolerant attitude, and Horikita was taken aback.

He seemed pleased to accept what could be construed as clear criticism of his son.

"I wanted to ask you something. How did you educate him to turn out like this?"

Horikita glared at Ryūen, who made no attempt to change his rude way of speaking. Meanwhile, far from hurrying away, Atsuomi turned to face Ryūen.

"As for his education, there was nothing special. I just made him live a disciplined life."

He answered, stating nothing special was done.

However, he added immediately after…

"If there was anything different, it would be that I didn't set limits on the number of cram schools, tutors, and extracurricular activities, nor the budget of his learning. And he was seriously engaged in them too, which probably led to these results."

*He was just raised in a privileged family environment*—those were the words his father was expressing.

"I have an appointment later, so I'll take my leave. Please continue to get along with my son."

Ayanokōji's father left those words as he departed in front of Horikita and Ryūen. He had some time before he needed to enter the chairman’s office and had no intention of talking at length with his son's classmates.

"His father has quite the presence, but things ended up being anticlimactic. He was just a pampered rich kid after all."

"That's right. I also thought he received some kind of special education."

However, a slight sense of discomfort remained in Horikita.

"Did Ayanokōji-kun really grow up in the kind of home his father described…?"

It was rare for children to grow up in such privileged environments, yet even in that kind of environment, she doubted they could turn out this way.

Ryūen shared the same thought as he listened.

"For sure. If that were true, it would be one extreme case of a mutation. But since his father won't speak the truth, we have no way to verify it."

Ryūen moved his rested feet and began to walk.

"Well, we didn't find out about his roots, but my course of action remains unchanged. I'll just have to defeat both you and Ayanokōji together. Be prepared."

Horikita quietly listened to Ryūen's declaration of war and watched his back as he left.

This was the first meeting between Horikita Suzune and Ayanokōji Atsuomi.

Both were, of course, still unaware of anything.

They were destined to meet again in the future.